

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 130
No. 21



TUESDAY
25TH NOVEMBER, 2025

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

PAPERS—

- (a) Report of the Finance Committee on the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025— [Col. 126]
- (b) Report of the Finance Committee on the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025— [Col. 126]
- (c) Report of the Finance Committee on the Ghana Education Trust Fund (Amendment) Bill, 2025— [Col. 126]

BILLS—SECOND READING

- (a) COVID 19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025— [Col. 128]
- (a) Value Added Tax Bill, 2025— [Col. 199]

BILL— CONSIDERATION STAGE

- (a) Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025— [Col. 167]
- (b) Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 — [Col. 229, 264]

BILL—THIRD READING

Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025— [Col. 168]

STATEMENT—

Government's Financial Policy, 2026— [Col.7, 15, 152, 169, 231]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 288]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

©2025 Parliament of Ghana.

THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Tuesday, 25th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:06 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would take the item numbered 6, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

The Speaker: We would start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 21st November, 2025.

Page 1— Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I do not see the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday on the console. What has rather been displayed is that of Thursday, so it is very difficult for us to follow through with what really transpired on Friday.

The Speaker: Table, the Hon Member said they do not have the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 21st

November, 2025— *[Pause]* Hon Member, you are right. As of now, we have only the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 20th November, 2025. But I think that was corrected early on.

Hon Members, do you have the hard copies with you? If you have, we can rely on that while they upload the current one on the console. Can we go ahead with the hardcopy?

All right, thank you so much.

Page 1...8— Yes, Hon Member?

12:16 p.m.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. With respect, may I kindly invite you to the item numbered 7, the third line. The Sixth Week of the Third Meeting is supposed to be ending on Friday 28th, November 2025, not 21st. The Business Statement was rather presented to us on the 21st of November, 2025. Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 9...11—

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you again. On page 11, item 3 (iv), the proper designation of the Deputy Minister should read “Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources”. The word “Housing” has been inadvertently omitted. Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Table Office, kindly take note of that too.

Page 12, 13—

Yes, Hon Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, on page 13, the words “Ag. Director General” should be hyphenated. That is xxviii; roman numeral 28.

The Speaker: Hon Member, address the Chair.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. That is roman numeral 28.

The Speaker: Table Office, take note of that.

Page 14...19—

Yes, Hon Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, just a minor correction. Roman numeral 85, that is lxxxv, the district, Ningo Prampram should reflect a hyphenated form. Thank you.

The Speaker: Item lxxxv, “Mrs Solace Osei Appiah, Municipal Director of Education, Ghana Education Service, Ningo Prampram Education Directorate, Greater Accra”?

Mr Afriyie: Exactly, Mr Speaker, except that the word “Ningo Prampram”, the district name, should be hyphenated.

The Speaker: Yes, thank you. Please, Table Office take note of that.

Page 20...24?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 21st November, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Item 7, Urgent Questions. We have three Urgent Questions so we would start with—

Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompseh): Mr Speaker, if you may indulge me, it is unfortunate that we could not engage with our Colleagues before you came in. I concede we have a backlog of Questions, but today, as was programmed by the Business Statement, is expected to be the last day for Hon Members to make comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented. So, it is the pleasure of this Side of the House that we start off with the debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy because we have quite a number today. So, depending on how we progress, we can intermittently stop and revert to item 7. We have done it before.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

The Speaker: Majority Frontbench?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, it is true that we agreed that this morning, we would start off with the debate so that after some time, we can take the Questions. So, we are entirely in your hands in this at this time.

The Speaker: The list of contributors—*[Pause]* Which Side of

the House is to start the debate for today? Is it the Minority Caucus?

12:26 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it has always been the practice; they start, and then we come in. So, there should be no debate about this, unless their people are not ready. If they are ready, then he should start. What then is his problem?

Mr Speaker, I have seen Mr Agbodza and Mr Akandoh here. He is trying to strengthen his Side—*[Interruption]* Let me speak.

Mr Speaker, last week, we started with full force, and I have realised that Mr Agbodza and Mr Akandoh are here. They are all here for a reason. Their legs are wobbling so they have to reinforce. But if their people are ready, they can start.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we do not need to stretch this.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, this Budget Statement and Economic Policy speaks for itself. Without even a debate, this Budget can win. However, it is good that we always have the Minority Side comment, and then the Majority Side will have the opportunity to respond. That has always been the practice.

Taking a look at the list of those who are commenting today, we have a number of Hon Ministers. For instance,

on the commentary on the health sector, it will not be appropriate for Mr Akandoh to speak, and then afterwards, the Ranking Member on the other Side for the Committee on Health to speak. It has to be the Ranking Member speaking first, so that Mr Akandoh can respond. It is the same for the Roads and Highways sector; it will be good for the Ranking Member on the Committee on Roads and Transportation to speak, and then the Minister for Roads and Highways, in commenting, will also have the opportunity to respond.

So, let us go with the way we have always gone, which is that the Minority starts and then the Majority responds.

The Speaker: Hon Members, this is a Budget Statement and Economic Policy from the President, and it was presented to us by the Minister for Finance in the form of a Statement. Hon Members are making comments on that Statement. We have not even reached the stage of debate, but when the Appropriation Bill is presented, then you will go through the process of debate.

So, I just wanted to know where it ended on Friday, then we will continue from there. So, you are all making comments. So, which Side made the last comment, so that we could go to the other Side.

Yes, Alhaji Habib?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, on your last question, we concluded on Friday. Even at the start of the

commentary on the Budget, they started it, and that has been the practice. It has been like that since Tuesday, when we started with the debate; that is how it has always been. So, on Friday, they started from their Side, and it ended here. So, today, they have to start. The Hon Majority Leader thinks that the Ranking Members on this Side should speak before the Hon Ministers, but it is never the case. So, they should start as we have always done, since Tuesday.

So, Mr Speaker, let us go in that direction.

The Speaker: Hon Members, you know the Hon Ministers would be appearing before the Committees, so at the Committee level, you can engage. But so far as the Floor is concerned, you are making comments. I have the list of the Majority Caucus with me. I was given the list of the Minority earlier, but it looks like it has been mixed up with the plenty of voluminous documents here. I am unable to locate it, and I have requested a replacement. So, in the meantime, could we start from the Majority Side and call on Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh?

You have 15 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from 21/11/25]

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to

comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, as we all know, the right to quality health care in this country is clearly enshrined in the 1992 Constitution. In the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we will find the policies underpinning the health sector from paragraphs 1056 to 1074. This Government sees any expenditure in the health sector as an investment. We cannot grow a wealthy or productive nation without investing appropriately in the health sector.

It is said that a healthy nation is a wealthy nation. The health of the people has a direct correlation with the productivity of the country. Worldwide, it is estimated that for every dollar spent in the health sector, we get not less than two or three dollars in economic returns. Mr Speaker, as leaders of this country and as part of the resetting agenda, His Excellency the President has set out to fix the challenges in the health sector. The biggest health financing scheme in this country, is the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS).

Mr Speaker, before we took over in 2024, and His Excellency the President was sworn into office on 7th January, 2025, we will recall that there were a lot of cries about the delay in the payment of service providers in the health sector. We always heard the threats from service providers about the withdrawal of services because their claims have been delayed.

Mr Speaker, on this very floor of the House, both Sides had advocated that we uncap the National Health Insurance

Levy (NHIL) but it fell on deaf ears. The President then was simply not listening.

Mr Speaker, again, there is this statement in the health sector called “unrealistic tariffs”. I am telling you the challenges we met with respect to the NHIS and how we have set out to solve those challenges.

Mr Speaker, as we all recall, one of the policy directives when His Excellency the President was sworn in, was the fact that the NHIS must be uncapped. As I speak to you now, the NHIS has been uncapped. Not only has it been uncapped, but now there are prompt releases of funds into the National Health Insurance Fund (NHIF). As I speak to you, we even sometimes have to call service providers to come for their claims. The issue of threats of withdrawal of services due to non-payment of claims are long gone.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, in a matter of one year, in fact, in less than one year, the active coverage of the NHIS has grown from GH¢18 million to more than GH¢ 20 million, and we are looking at about 60 per cent coverage. So, the prompt release of the funds and the uncapping of the Fund have boosted a lot of confidence in the NHIS. That is leadership; that is the Resetting Agenda; and that is governance.

12:36 p.m.

Mr Speaker, for your information, beginning January 2026, the current

tariffs on average will see an increment of 120 per cent of National Health Insurance Tariffs—*[Hear! Hear!]*—giving meaning to realistic tariffs and trying to fight the issue of co-payment—the illegal payment that some service providers charge although they are subscribers. So, the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS), as I speak, has seen tremendous improvement. As of September, this year, not less than GH¢7.5 billion has been disbursed by the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA).

Mr Speaker, as I have already indicated, leaders set out to solve problems. One of the biggest challenges across the world, on the continent, and Ghana is no exception, is the rise of non-communicable diseases. About 45 per cent of our mortalities are due to non-communicable diseases. In Ghana, about 4,000 people are diagnosed with cancer yearly; one out of every three people is diagnosed with hypertension; kidney failure and diabetes is on the rise. So, His Excellency the President sets out to find a solution to this particular challenge so that the catastrophic expenditure on Ghanaians will be a thing of the past. When people get themselves into this non-communicable disease, it pulls them into the poverty line and therefore, His Excellency the President established another fund called the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, popularly known as MahamaCares—*[Hear! Hear!]* The Bill was brought to this House, it has been passed into an Act, the Board has been constituted, and it is now in motion—*[Hear! Hear!]* This particular Fund is dedicated towards the funding of non-communicable diseases. That is

leadership; that is the resetting agenda, solving problems, investing in where it is needed most [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, again—[**An Hon Member:** Teach them]—one of the hindrances of achieving the Universal Health Coverage is cost. As I speak, His Excellency the President has directed that every Ghanaian, starting from 2026 will have access to free primary health care—[*Hear! Hear!*] That free primary health care will give real meaning to the promotive health care, the preventive health care, and the curative. [**An Hon Member:** Teach them! Teach them!] Mr Speaker, you would also agree with me as you have been the Minister for Health before, that the primary health care need of this country is about 80 per cent. Therefore, when we get the primary health care right, we will have a very strong health sector. And so, His Excellency the President is investing at the right places.

Mr Speaker, quite apart from that, in 2025 alone, this Government has enrolled not less than 13,500 nurses on the payroll—[*Hear! Hear!*] Again, in the attempt of Government to ensure equitable distribution of the workforce, this year we are distributing not less than 700 medical doctors across the length and breadth of this country—[*Hear! Hear!*]—and it is the directive of His Excellency the President that he would not want to hear that there is any district in this country without a medical doctor. And so, these 700 medical doctors are being posted to the districts where they are needed most. [**An Hon Member:** That is leadership] That is leadership.

Mr Speaker, again, in a matter of less than one year, we have paid approximately GH¢500 million to nursing trainees as allowance. And in the next two weeks, we would pay additional GH¢231 million. The days of arrears in multiples of 20 months, 10 months, 18 months are gone. Now we are paying on time.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency, the President, as part of his 2024 Manifesto, promised the good people of this country that we used to have 10 regions and therefore we had 10 regional hospitals. During the last regime, we thought that, once they had created extra regions, it was going to go with other facilities. It will interest one to know that none of the six additional regions has a regional hospital. [**Some Hon Members:** Oh! Oh!] So, His Excellency the President, has directed that with immediate effect, we start construction of regional hospitals in the regions where there are none. As part of the 2026 Budget, we are going to begin the construction of three regional hospitals in this country, namely, the Savannah Region, the Oti Region, and the Western North Region—[*Hear! Hear!*]—and we would continue the abandoned health facilities.

Mr Speaker, the last administration dotted a lot of uncompleted structures across the length and breadth of this country. His Excellency the President, has directed that he will never abandon any ongoing project—[*Hear! Hear!*] We are going to finish those projects to give meaning to the investment. [**Some Hon Members:** Yes]. Mr Speaker, we do not start projects just for the sake of starting,

without assessing the real impact on the economy. Let me ask, what is the value those abandoned hospitals? We are going to complete all those projects.

Mr Speaker, again, we admit that Government cannot do it all alone, and therefore, we are looking and seeking to bring the private sector on board [**An Hon Member:** That is innovation]. For example, it is the directive of this Government that as part of getting all our hospitals retooled to have the right equipment, we are inviting the private sector in to do equipment placement so that we can get the required equipment at each hospital while Government also procures more for the smooth running of our various health facilities.

Mr Speaker, it is our expectation that our Colleagues on the other Side will join us to celebrate and contribute meaningfully to this particular Budget. If we check the Budget, we are investing in people and at the right places—[*Hear! Hear!*] We are just not dotting infrastructure around. We target what we can complete. So, if it is three regional hospitals we want to do, we start and finish before we roll in the next one. As part of the Agenda 111, clearly in this Budget an allocation has been made, and not only has it been made, we are also going to partner the private sector, bring them on board, complete the Agenda 111 hospitals, equip, and then manage them. What is important to His Excellency the President is the fact that the ordinary Ghanaian will have access to quality health care delivery—[*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

12:46 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the Hon Member used just about 13 minutes out of the 15 minutes. But before we go to the next contributor, let me acknowledge the presence of our visitors. So far, I have three institutions.

The first is from the Learning Tree Foundation, led by the Chief Executive Officer, Rosemary Osei Kuffuor. They are 60 in number and they are from the Ayawaso West Wuogon Constituency. They are on the left side of the Speaker at the Public Gallery. On your behalf, I warmly welcome them to Parliament and congratulate the Chief Executive Officer for leading them here. You may resume your seats.

[Pupils of the Learning Tree Foundation were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: We also have students from the Mawuli Senior High School—[*Hear! Hear!*—led by their teacher, Mr Christian Agbatsi. They are 77 in number and they are from the Ho Central Constituency. Straight ahead of me are the students. Please, you are also warmly welcome, and you may resume your seats.

[Students of Mawuli Senior High School were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: The third group is from the St Paul Catholic Church, Senase Berekum. They are 36 in number, and they are led by the Chaplain and the Financial Secretary, James Owusu Ababio and Antwi Augustine. They are located in the Berekum East Constituency. You are also warmly welcome, and please, you may resume your seats.

[Members of the St Paul Catholic Church, Senase Berekum were acknowledged.]

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from column 7]

The Speaker: We will now listen to the comments from the Minority Caucus in the person of Dr Nana Ayew Afriye. You have 15 minutes.

Dr Nana Ayew Afriye (NPP — Effiduase/Asokore): Mr Speaker, I thank you as I take my turn to comment on the principles of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, I have heard the Minister for Health speak copiously on the policy, and as I take my turn, I would want to say that there is a high level of inconsistency as far as this Budget is concerned. I am not sure if the resetting is actually

adjusting. Mr Speaker, if we go to paragraph 590, it says that:

“The Ministry continued to expand access to quality healthcare in line with the Universal Health Coverage roadmap. The NHIF was uncapped to provide stable financing for vaccines, essential commodities, HIV services, and the Free Primary Health Care initiative under MahamaCares.”

Mr Speaker, I would dissect this paragraph into two halves. The first half talked about uncapping NHIF. This does not sit well with the people of this country. If we talk about uncapping, last year, the envelope was GHC8 billion, capped at GHC6.8 billion. Of the GHC6.8 billion that was given to the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA), GHC6.5 billion was released to them, a performance of 95.5 per cent.

Mr Speaker, now, when they uncapped, the envelope size was GHC10 billion. It was revised to GHC8 billion. When it was revised to GHC8 billion, they capped an amount of 20 per cent for the Ghana Medical Trust Fund—*[Uproar]*—that is by law. The 20 per cent of that amount was allocated for the Ghana Medical Trust Fund. In essence, that was capping. If they capped 20 per cent, they have taken GHC1.6 billion out of GHC8 billion. That itself remains GHC6.4 billion, which is woefully less than what was allocated to the NHIA last year. We gave them GHC6.8 billion, and

they gave GH¢6.4 billion. As of now, 25th November, they have performed worse. The allocation to the NHIA as of now is woefully under GH¢4.5 billion. *[Uproar]*

Mr Akandoh — *rose* —

Dr Afriye: This Budget Statement and Economic Policy says they are uncapping to make funds available—

The Speaker: Hon Member, please, just a minute. We are taking note of your timing, so nobody will take a minute from you.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, with respect, my Colleague is misleading the House. As I speak, the disbursement from the NHIA, even the allocation and enlargement of funds in the National Health Insurance Levy, stands at around GH¢7.5 billion and not GH¢4 billion. Where is he getting the GH¢4 billion from? Mr Speaker, this is a House of records. He cannot be misleading the people like that.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you may continue.

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, he may want to table the respective documents at the Table Office. Otherwise, he is misleading us.

The Speaker: Hon Members, to solve the problem, I want both of you to table your documents—*[Laughter]* So that we know whether it is GH¢4.5 billion or GH¢7.5 billion. We just need

your documents, and that is all. We will solve the problem. Yes, but you may continue.

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, so if they uncap and make GH¢8 billion available and further cap 20 per cent of it to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, now what is actually available is not the GH¢8 billion. It is GH¢6.4 billion for NHIA to perform. That is the truth. So, we cannot be here for them to write in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that the NHIF was uncapped to provide stable financing for vaccines when they know very well that the uncapping was recapped, and what is available is not actually what they are saying. So, this one does not really sit well with the resetting agenda.

Mr Speaker, then again, when we look at the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Minister, he says that “...and the Free Primary Health Care initiative under MahamaCares”. This is confusing. They say that the MahamaCares is for specialist services and non-communicable diseases. Then they come and say in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy that they are making funds available as they made it for MahamaCares to take care of MahamaCares, including free primary health care services.

So, are we further smuggling the free primary health care services under MahamaCares to further compete with

other financing allocations to the NHIA?
This is inconsistent.

Mr Speaker, as I move on, I come to the principles of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. They did not talk about blood, the lifeline of the human and this country.

12:56 p.m.

Mr Speaker, today I say, and I tender in this document, that Zipline is decommissioning three of its centres: Centre 4, Centre 5 and Centre 6. What does this mean? There has been non-engagement and also an inability for the Government to provide funds for Zipline. Mr Speaker, the allocation this year was GH¢20 million, knowing very well that they owe Zipline an amount of GH¢175 million as of now. What this means is that, as this letter says they are shutting down these three centres—the Anum Centre supplies the whole of Volta Region. It supplies part of the Eastern Region and the Afram plains. They are also shutting down the Western North, the Minister's own backyard, Sefwi Wiawso Distribution Centre. That means that they are not supplying blood, medicines, and vaccines to the whole Western North, part of Western Region, part of Central Region, Ashanti Region, Ahafo and Bono Regions. They are also shutting down, the Kete-Krachi Distribution Centre effective today. That means Krachi, part of Savannah and also East Afram plains. Effective today, people will needlessly lose their lives

due to shortage of blood, medication and vaccines. The reason they are shutting down is because of the lack of funding. The resetting has made sure that there is no funding to the Zipline entity. The resetting has made sure that these people are not able to provide services. For that matter, Zipline is best described as a comatose entity in need of resuscitation. The only resuscitation they need is actually *l'argent*, money, which they are not being given.

Mr Speaker, this news is terrifying to the ordinary people living in the remote areas in this country. As a matter of fact, we must act urgently because the shutdown takes effect today. This is not right. Something should have been done about it and it should have been mentioned in the principles of this Budget. But that was not so. I hope the Minister will do something about this because life loss—especially a lot of emergencies that occur including maternal deaths are all linked to the shortage of blood and blood-related products. This letter states that the Ministry has not engaged them and as a result, they are shutting down, is worrying. It is addressed to the Minister of Health.

Again, on the issue of recruiting of staff. Let us be honest with ourselves. This year, we are told in the Budget that 13,500 nurses were placed on the payroll. This document—[*The Hon Member held out a sheet of paper*—this clearance, was given to 15,200 nurses

and midwives in August. This was to take care of all those who graduated in 2020. This year, about 6,700 of them had not been taken, and there were all these agitations. One of the staff even actually had to speak in a way that the Minister was not happy about. We had to come in. But why should they sit for the opposition to come in on an issue or put pressure on the Ministry before they see the need to get to sort themselves out? What was the issue? The issue had to do with ant extension—In any case, once you give a warrant and it expires, all you have to do is to extend it. But because of political reasons, they did not extend it. Therefore, as I stand here, if this Budget claims that this year they took 13,500, this is not true. Anyone who was placed on the payroll was done so under the allocations extended from last year. So, what it means is that they have now enrolled the nurses who graduated in 2020.

Mr Speaker, I would like to ask: the 2021 batch of nurses and midwives are expecting to be recruited into the Service. Recruitment is normally done in August. Has that been done? It has not been done. So, if they say that they have placed people on payroll, on which payroll? Which nurses are they? Which midwives are they? Which country are they serving? Once we are clear—they are listening to me. The nurses of the 2021 cohort, are listening to me. Yesterday, I met a number of them. They have not been placed on the payroll. If they claim to be doing something, all

they are trying to tell Ghanaians is that they continued what the NPP Government did.

Mr Akandoh — *rose*—

Dr Afriye: The 6,000 or 7,000 people who were not placed that they claim to have placed, they should not take the credit for it. They are taking credit for what has not been done that they should have done, that they had to agitate for before they did so

The Speaker: Hon Member, hold your breath.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, let me remind the House that you invited the two of us to table our evidence on the National Health Insurance expenditure, and my evidence is ready. I want to table it, so that the Hon Member will also table his evidence.

Mr Speaker, as Minister for Health, I have stated it on this Floor that Government has put about 13,500 nurses on the payroll. This was approved by Cabinet, and the Minister for Finance has written to that effect to the Controller and Accountant General, and we have a Member of Parliament on his feet saying that nobody has been put on the payroll. How could he speak like that? Based on what evidence is he saying that nobody has been put on the payroll?

Is there any evidence? The Minister responsible for Finance has written to the Controller and the Accountant General, and he sits here and says that nobody has

been put on the payroll? Salaries have been processed to that effect.

Dr Afriye: The 2021 cohort of nurses and midwives both public and private, have they employed them?

The Speaker: Hon Member, he is just—

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, I refuse to be interrupted. I would want to, under your direction, continue my presentation, if you so allow.

The Speaker: Yes, I just wanted to draw your attention to the fact that he is challenging your statement, which I believe is a statement of fact that the number he gave of Government putting 13,500 on the payroll is untrue. That is what you are saying. That is the position you have taken, and he is asking for the basis. He has provided the basis for his, 13,500.

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, my position is that—

The Speaker: No, I am not talking about your position. I am talking about the statement of fact.

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, technically speaking, 7,000 of all those people were part of the clearance that was issued last. Those were the ones which were placed, that is the 2020 batch. But I am asking, have they— Ghanaians are listening. Have they recruited the 2021 batch of

nurses and midwives? That has not been done. [*Uproar*]

That has not been done, so that is the politics of it. They are creating the impression to Ghanaians that this year they have recruited nurses and midwives, whilst they are enjoying the clearance of last year. I am only exposing them. We are speaking to two things. They met a financial clearance.

The Speaker: That is what we wanted clarification on. Now, your position is that, yes, we have 13,500 on the payroll, but that did not include the 2021 batch of nurses.

Dr Afriye: Absolutely. [*Laughter*]

They are based on the NPP financial clearance. So, they have done nothing. They have not added any recruitment.

The Speaker: Now we get to your point. Please—

Dr Afriye: They have not added anything to— Because you are only coming to the public—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you can go on.

Dr Afriye: The Speaker, I have tidied it. Thank you for your guidance. Mr Speaker, the clearance of last year under the NPP Government was not 13,500. Hon Minister, you need to add 1,700 more. It was 15,200, and you have placed

them on the payroll and which actually reflects 13,500. You need to add some 1,700 to it. These are going to be those of the 2020 batch. Again, every year, we have to add on. So, this year, we are expecting the clearance for the 2021 nurses and midwives. That has not been done. I am asking my good Friend on the other Side to do it. That one, he can come here and tell us that this year, they have added on 2021. Otherwise, we move into next year, and they are not going to do 2021.

They have shortchanged those of 2022. Else, he has to combine the two of them, 2021 and 2022. That is worrying. This fundamentally exposes the agenda of resetting. They should reset properly, so that we know that this year, they are adding on 2021 and adding 2022. But for them to give a reset gap, where they take 2021 to 2026, is worrying. With regards to the Agenda 111—

1:06 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, he has raised a very serious matter, that there are some of our nurses that are crying to be absorbed on the payroll, and that you should take it as a priority and make sure that that is done.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I am guided by your appeal, but let the records capture that they left 74,000 health professionals at home. [**Some Hon Members:** Eii!] Mr Speaker, when they recruited in 2024—we do not just recruit, we make financial provisions, so when

we recruit, we must pay them. Mr Speaker, no financial provision was made for the recruited nurses. It was also not even part of our handing over notes. So, we were confronted with the realities in 2025, and we had to make an amendment to put all the 13,500 nurses on the payroll in 2025 alone. If we put 13,500 on the payroll, and we have not even exhausted everything, we must make some strategies to reflect how we absorb more, going forward.

Mr Speaker, not only that, Government has decided to use this to manage migration. We are looking at how we can export some of these health professionals outside the country, and some other countries are responding to it. So, we have better plans than they did. They could have done it; 74,000 people? What were they doing?

The Speaker: Hon Member, you may continue.

Dr Afriye: Mr Speaker, I hope you will be generous with me with regard to the time.

Mr Speaker, I stand again to say that the good people of this country voted against the New Patriotic Party (NPP) and for that matter, they should fix it. They were voted to fix it, so they should fix it.

In 2017, the NPP met a backlog. As of 2017, the last batch of nurses who were recruited were 2011 and this was six years, but we fixed it. So, it is for them to fix it. I do not expect him to complain of what was left, as at now that

they are 11 months into government, when they left people for over six years— There is no room for this.

The Agenda 111 commitment is so poor, Mr Speaker. They are talking about building regional hospitals—

The Speaker: Kindly give the Hon Member one minute.

Dr Afriye: I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Agenda 111—How can they go and build regional hospitals to increase referrals, when they are supposed to take care of the many hospitals in those same Regions that will allow people to not spend a lot of money and the referrals will be less? They want people to leave their homes and take costly transport, knowing very well that, according to Thaddeus and Maine, it affects access to health care? They want them to leave their districts to go to the regional centres which would increase referrals when they are supposed to look for money to take care of Agenda 111? Mr Speaker, there is an anomaly here. This is inconsistent.

Mr Akandoh — *rose* —

Dr Afriye: Would the Hon Minister sit down as I make my contribution? So, Mr Speaker, I want the Hon Minister to know that for attaining universal health care by 2030, every country is going towards districts, citing hospitals close to the rural areas. We have gone past that time where we put them in the cities. That is what they are encouraging—

The Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Members, it is now the time of Hon Kwame Agbodza. You have 15 minutes. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to comment on a very realistic and forward-looking Budget read on behalf of the President by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, there is an issue that is of national concern that I want to touch on before I speak about roads. When I became a Member of Parliament (MP), one day I was there and I was told that the former MP of my Constituency had taken ill. I quickly called and I was told that he needed to be airlifted from the Ho Government Hospital to 37 Military Hospital. I called Hon Nitiwul, who was the Minister for Defence at the time, and then, within the shortest period, he dispatched a military helicopter that airlifted Hon Akorli to the Air Force Base and onwards to Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital.

Mr Speaker, I am saying this simply because the military provides services beyond what we think in our country. So, when we are discussing providing support for the military, it is not merely to support them to fight wars. The military provides significant civil support services. I listened last week when Colleagues sought to critique the Government's decision to retool the Ghana Armed Forces. In their view, the amount of money set aside to provide four new helicopters and some two other aircrafts for the use of the military and the Executive was unnecessary.

Mr Speaker, I just want to draw the attention of this House that it is in our interest to be cautious when we make these comments. It is quite interesting that Mr Speaker, today, the Side that opposes this was comfortable, for instance, to spend US\$97 million on the site of the cathedral. To them, prioritising the US\$97 million to dig a hole was better than supporting the military. The same Side actually looked on when GH¢1.6 billion was misapplied at the National Service Secretariat. They are saying that they prefer GH¢1.6 billion to be misapplied at the National Service Secretariat rather than supporting the military.

Interestingly, Mr Speaker, a certain Minister for Defence sat in Cabinet when it approved the purchase of three helicopters. It turned out that those helicopters were 50 years old, in fact, older than that Minister for Defence. In fact, at that time, a certain Minority Leader was also around 47 years, participated when those three helicopters were bought for the police. Today, Mr Speaker, nothing has become of the three helicopters that were bought for the police; they cannot even fly it anywhere. This Side of the aisle supported those things and yet today, when we say we want to retool the military, they are talking about it. I do not think this is the right way to look at this, and so I am encouraging them to be careful when we talk about these things, especially if it is about the military.

Mr Speaker, let me come to roads. Indeed, almost everybody I meet, whenever we visit every community,

Colleagues, including this morning, come to the Minister for Roads and Highways complaining about the terrible nature of the roads in their communities, and Mr Speaker, that is true. Yes, I agree with them. The road network in our country is nothing that anybody should be proud of, and we should invest to improve the roads.

But Mr Speaker, I want to give you a perspective of where we started from. In 2016, the entire commitment under all the agencies of the Ministry of Roads and Highways was just GH¢10 billion. That includes the road projects awarded across all the agencies, including the Road Fund, and bills unpaid was just about GH¢7 billion. By the end of 2027, Mr Speaker, the Side opposite left projects contracted at least GH¢110 billion and then the bills left unpaid is in excess of GH¢40 billion. They look us in the face and tell us that this is a better management of a country. No, it cannot be.

1:16 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as of the time President Mahama took office, more than 90 per cent of contractors were not on site. Colleagues from the Minority and Majority came to me to ask what I would do to get the contractors back to site, as if we were the ones who asked the contractors to leave site. Some of those contractors left site from 2020 to 2023 because they worked and were never paid. That is what the situation is. But guess what, Mr Speaker? The President directed, as the Hon Minister for Health also said, that no ongoing project should be abandoned, unlike 2017 when the Side opposite took over power.

What did they do? They made a policy statement to suspend all road projects, especially cocoa roads, and said that they were doing investigation. By the time they finished, and in fact, I remember very well, the former Minister stood here and said that there were so many things wrong with the cocoa roads and other things. Mr Speaker, I beg to say that today, if one sees the Cocoa Road Programme they left, it is appalling.

Mr Speaker, we would find resources and make sure that all these abandoned projects are continued. There is one that is dear to my heart, and I wish my Colleague, Hon former Minister for Roads and Highways, Mr Asenso-Boakye, was here. Mr Speaker, when someone serves in a privileged office as a Minister, that person should act as a nationalist. All his examples were as if the road between Accra and Kumasi is the only road in the country. It does not sound well when we have tunnel vision about development in our country.

Where Mr Speaker, comes from, the Upper West Region, one would not even dream of driving from Accra to Wa. This is because it is one of the most terrible roads in our country because it has been abandoned for years, and people say that there is no traffic on that road. How can we have traffic on the road that is completely abandoned? What kind of traffic is one expecting on the road between Bolgatanga and Wa? This is nothing to write home about. That is why President Mahama has put together a plan to retire the debt with all contractors. For the first time on record,

at a single payment, he paid over GHC5 billion to contractors who are owed about GHC40 billion. Mr Speaker, that cannot clear the debt, but it is a significant amount of money for a government that came to power and cannot borrow anything. So, we would continue this, and guess what, all these payments went to contracts that were awarded before we took over. That is a government that is determined not to have a situation where it abandons projects.

Mr Speaker, I also want to talk about the Big Push. Again, my Colleague actually sought to make very unfounded statements on this floor. For instance, the Big Push projects are not feasible. I put it on record; every single Big Push project has a full feasibility report as required by the agency under the Ministry of Finance. So, being a former Minister for Roads and Highways, he should speak with credibility. I wish he were here. I would have offered him the opportunity to withdraw and say that he did not get it right. Mr Speaker, he also sought to say that all the Big Push projects are sole-sourced; that is also not right. And since he has served in that office, he should be able to speak so that he can be believed.

Mr Speaker, this is the fact; the President's Big Push projects are not merely road projects. They are intended to create access through the major corridors of our country. The Eastern Corridor, the Western Corridor, the Central Corridor, the North East Corridor, and some of the ring roads in our country. Mr Speaker, I am happy to

report this morning that all these corridors that I have mentioned, contractors are already on site and working. I heard him say that we would not be able to complete it. Where is the source of funds? We have already allocated GH¢13 billion for phase I, which is in this Budget. Mr Speaker, I can say that GH¢13 billion actually exist this morning. Any contractor working under the Big Push who raises a certificate this morning would be paid, and I want to encourage contractors to continue.

In the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, we set aside another GH¢30 billion to make sure that even next year, when contractors raise certificates, they would be paid. I am dreaming of the day that Mr Speaker can drive — not because he cannot fly — from Accra through Wenchi through Sawla to Wa on an asphalt road. That is what the President is thinking of, and that is what is going to happen by the end of 2027. So those naysayers who say that we are not going to be able to do it—Of course, there were people in this country who said that Ghana cannot get independence, but we got independence. When the Akosombo Dam was supposed to be built, some people actually told the Americans not to fund it. Today, the Akosombo Dam is there for all of us.

Even when Terminal 3 at the Kotoka International Airport, was about to be built, they said it was a waste of money. Today, the duty-free and other shops there belong to some of their relatives. So, it is not unusual for a certain group of people to always doubt the capability

of Ghanaians. I am telling them that Ghanaians are capable. We are going to be able to build this road. Under President Mahama, we would drive on an asphalt road from Wenchi through Sawla to Wa. This is going to happen within two and a half years.

Mr Speaker, there is also an issue of abandoned projects. The reality —

Dr Stephen Amoah — *rose* —

The Speaker: Hon Minister, Dr Amoah is on his feet.

Dr Amoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

My respected Friend and Brother, Hon Minister, has made a statement per the content of Order 122 content. This is an august House of facts and figures. He mentioned that when H.E. Dr Kwame Nkrumah was trying to construct the Akosombo Dam, the Americans were told by some Ghanaians that they should not finance it. This is a serious statement. I would like my Minister to substantiate what he said because this is an august House. This is where we make laws. This is where Ghanaians are taking a lot of pieces of information for their decision-making processes.

So, I would like my Hon Minister to provide the source and how credible it is, so that we can also correct this in the near future.

Thank you very much.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, he is demanding evidence to support the

statement you made with regard to the construction of the Akosombo Dam.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I would provide that evidence in due course. I did not only mention that. I started by saying that there were citizens of this country who, when Ghana, under President Nkrumah wanted to have independence, said it was not yet the time. I am wondering why he did not even worry about that one. I went ahead and talked about the fact that, yes, Dr Nkrumah's attempt to build a dam faced challenges. Mr Speaker, I am happy you recommended somebody to sell some books to all of us. I would reference it from that book. Of course, Mr Speaker, I did not want to mention the names of those people. So, I would continue.

Mr Speaker, there is also a question about why a particular project, the Accra-Kumasi bypasses, have not been completed. Let me put it on record, President Mahama's Government never asked any contractor working on the bypasses on Accra-Kumasi Road to stop work. Indeed, I called all the contractors and encouraged them to continue working. However, what they told me was that, at the time of contracting, the time they were asked to go to site, they were not shown details of the alignment. This was told in the presence of the Minister for Finance, that they flew a drone and showed them a drone image of the alignment. When they got to the site, and they started working, they saw *galamsey* pit and swamp areas. Mr Speaker, as we speak, almost all the contracts have their prices increased to more than 100 per cent. This happened in 2023.

Unfortunately, the Side opposite made no effort to actually capture the variation. Today, as we speak, we are told that we need another GH¢3 billion or so to be able to complete the bypasses on the Accra-Kumasi Road, and President Mahama is doing that. Indeed, one of the sections has actually been completed and taken over. We intend to make sure that in stages, we would complete the site of the Accra-Kumasi Road.

Mr Speaker, there is also an issue about the Accra-Kumasi Expressway. This project —

Dr Amoah — *rose* —

The Speaker: Yes, just a minute.

Yes, Dr Amoah?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, thank you once again. Because my Hon respected Member could not substantiate the credible source needed for such an important piece of information, I would like the statement to be expunged until he does so. Because, we cannot keep any piece of information here that we cannot substantiate. It is extremely inimical to the performance of our Republic and we need to do *it*. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, one of the books—

1:26 p.m.

The Speaker: Dr Stephen Amoah, if I have to apply this rule, I do not know how many of you can make a contribution on this floor—[*Laughter*]

You may disagree with him. He may provide some evidence and you may disagree with that evidence. Because these are records that some people kept and they are actually in books. Some of those records have partisan colours, and you need to investigate those matters seriously. So, you start to look at what weight to attach to this evidence and that kind of thing—This is not a trial and that is why usually, in these cases, we allow the debate to flow. If you have anything beyond that, then the avenue is different from the Plenary session of Parliament.

Please, let us move on. Hon Minister, you have a few more minutes.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, one of the books I would have recommended to my Colleague is a book titled *Dark Days in Ghana* by Dr Kwame Nkrumah. I am sure when he reads that book, he will notice that—Because there are so many things in there. There are also concerns about why we need to build an expressway from Accra to Kumasi. I think we should have done that many years ago.

Currently, if you want to drive from Accra to Kumasi, you are faced with a journey of over 250 kilometres through communities that are now overpopulated and are encroaching the road. The bypasses alone cannot solve the problem. We are creating a new growth pole. Halfway through the study, we just realised that we can cut that journey to under 200 kilometres. Imagine what 50 kilometres mean to the fuel tank of an average person. It means that 40 per cent of the travel time can also be taken off.

How can you tell me this is not important?

Mr Speaker, not only that, once we are able to determine this alignment, the idea is to put alongside, a railway, which is finally a high-speed train from Accra to Kumasi and beyond in the future. How can they say this is not important? Indeed, they spent over US\$100 million under the so-called Boankra Integrated Logistics Terminal, which is in the bush. Nothing is being done. Because no transporter is ready to move goods from Tema by road and take it to Boankra and then somebody from Suame will now come to Boankra to clear it. If you can get it at Boankra, you would rather take it to Kumasi itself. So, this project will actually unlock the potential of the Boankra Integrated Logistics Terminal—

The Speaker: Hon Minister, your time is up.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, can I plead for the same one minute you gave to my Colleague?

The Speaker: Yes, you have one minute to conclude.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I just want to recap. There are two issues I came here with, that Colleagues, when we are talking about the Military, the Ghana Armed Forces—today, they forget that some of us have police personnel following us. Even if we go to the grocery shop, they follow us. All these costs money and providing the necessary support for them is very necessary. Let us not trivialise the issue

of retooling the Ghana Armed Forces; it is very critical.

Mr Speaker, we would work together with our Colleagues in this House to make sure that, all budgetary allocation made on behalf of the Ministry of Roads and Highways is applied to improve the road network in our country.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, are you up on a point of order?

Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, with all due respect, I would like to correct an impression being created by the Minister for Roads and Highways. He is creating an impression as if—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you rose on a point of order and now you are correcting impressions? What is the Order that has been breached?

Mr Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker, I was up already for a very long time but I could not catch your eye.

The Speaker: You caught my ear.
[Laughter]

Mr Amankwa-Manu: I was rather trying to catch your eye.

The Speaker: Because you said point of order. So, I turned and then I saw you on your feet.

Mr Amankwa-Manu: No, I did not say that.

The Speaker: Hon Member, please, you said “point of order” and I just want to hear the Order that we have breached. If it is not a point of order, the rules are clear. Maybe a point of clarification or elucidation, then I would listen to you. But to argue with me, you cannot win this battle.

Mr Amankwa-Manu: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Obviously, I can never win a battle against you. There is no way I can do that. But I am up on a point of clarification.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways created an impression that the NPP Government did not do anything to retool the Ghana Armed Forces; that is palpable falsehood. In fact, the retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces was done to the extent that at a point when we wanted to acquire a long endurance vessel for the Ghana Navy, my Colleagues from the other Side of the aisle actually rejected it, even when the International Monetary Fund (IMF) gave us an opportunity to do that—

The Speaker: Hon Member, that is not point of order or point of clarification. When we get to your turn, you can put that across. There are so many things that are in our heads. But you know, we allocate it in such a way that we try to give you some time to also say what is in your head. So, please, I am

sure that your name will be submitted. Let me check and see whether your name is there. The name is—

Mr Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker, unfortunately, my name is not there. I have been ill for some time now, so I could not give my name out. I was scheduled to be here on Friday but I was taken ill. So, I could not do that.

The Speaker: Sorry, because we have about 13 Members from the Minority Side and the same number from the Majority Side for today. So, a lot more will be contributing and you may get the opportunity if the Lord smiles at you. Please, it is now the turn of Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah. You have fifteen minutes.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the 2026 Budget Statement and the Economic Policy of the Republic of Ghana, which was read by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, before I proceed on my point of argument, let me correct this erroneous statement that was made by the Minister for Roads and Highways. We have adopted unto ourselves, constitutionalism. This country is ruled by rules and by laws. It cannot be said that, things that are cardinal to our Constitution, that is presumption of innocence before you can be pronounced guilty or if you would plead guilty by yourself—So, it is erroneous for the Minister for Roads and Highways to say that at the National Service Secretariat,

GH¢1.6 billion was misused by certain people. On what basis did he say that? This cannot be allowed to stand.

Mr Speaker, number 2, when he also says that the Akufo-Addo Government did not do anything about retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces, that is also not correct. Last year, I was right here in this House when the Akufo-Addo Government presented an Agreement to be considered by this House. At the time, they were here. They resisted and argued against the retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces, to the extent that that Agreement was not taken on this floor.

So, on what basis can they conclude that the Akufo-Addo Government failed to retool the Ghana Armed Forces?

1:36 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I now move to my own points of argument. Last week, when I was listening to the Minister for Finance, the youth of this country were expecting a Budget Statement and Economic Policy of prosperity. Unfortunately, we had disappointment. We were expecting a budget of relief. After the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, what we got was disappointment. We were expecting a Budget Statement and Economic Policy of opportunity. The youth of this country did not get that opportunity.

Mr Speaker, this Budget Statement and Economic Policy can best be likened

to cow dung; *esoro no dendenden, aseɛ no mɛmɛmɛ, pɛtɛɛ*, to wit on the surface, it looks robust, but the devil is in the detail. In the detail, we would realise that Ghanaians have been short-changed, especially the youth. In the build-up to the 2024 elections, the National Democratic Congress (NDC) championed this campaign policy of creating jobs for the Ghanaian people. Key among them was the Adwumawura Programme. I hold in my hand the training manual of the Adwumawura Programme. On page 10 of that policy, I read, "This programme aims to train and establish at least 10,000 youth-led businesses each year over a four-year period."

Mr Speaker, they are targeting 40,000 businesses by 2029 but here is the catch. They say that fully funded under the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy through the Ministry of Finance, it shall also provide grant funding to 2,000 viable businesses each year. As we speak, in 2025, an amount of GH¢100 million was allocated to National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP). Currently, only a paltry figure of GH¢34 billion has been released to the NEIP. My question is, assuming without admitting that all the GH¢34 million will have to be disbursed which is not even possible, but assuming without admitting that all the GH¢34 million will be disbursed to the 2,000 people, a simple calculation will tell you

that each person is going to get a paltry sum of about GH¢17,000.00.

Mr Speaker, in this country, can we use GH¢17,000.00 to establish a business? How much is a container? *Container boɔ koraa yɛ sɛn?* To use GH¢17,000.00 to establish businesses in this country?

Mr Speaker, they also said that they were going to train over 10,000 people as far as the National Apprenticeship Programme is concerned. I have in my hands here a publication from Graphic online. This publication—when President Mahama was launching the National Apprenticeship Programme. His Excellency the President said that in the year 2025, they are going to train 10,000 people under the National Apprenticeship Programme. I read paragraph 4 and 5—

The Speaker: Hon Member, just a minute. Please, so many of you are on your feet. I do not know what you are doing. You are Leaders and I have told you the rule that when you are on your feet and you want to whisper to a Colleague, you stand by the side of the Colleague so that your back does not face the Mace. That is the authority of the House and you all know traditionally that you are not to stand with your back to the Chief. This is the authority of the House and not the Speaker. The authority is

there, the Mace. So please, when you want to at least whisper to a Colleague, go to the side of the Colleague and then whisper but facing the Mace, not with your back to the Mace. That is complete disrespect. Next time I see any of you on your feet that way, I will name the person and read the rules about naming and be guided by it.

Hon Member, you may continue.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, thank you. To continue with my point, I raised the point that there is a Graphic online publication which speaks to the effect that at the time that His Excellency, the President, was launching the National Apprenticeship Programme, the promise to the people of Ghana was that he is going to train 10,000 people in the year 2025. Per paragraph four and five, His Excellency, the President, went ahead to promise the people of Ghana that in the year 2026, they are now going to scale it up to 100,000 people. I read;

“Additionally, the second phase which is expected to be rolled out in 2026 will benefit more than 100,000 people”

Mr Speaker, now the big question is, in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, an amount of GH¢300 million was allocated to the National Apprenticeship Programme. Now, when we check, assuming that the amount of

money that was released currently, which is about GH¢150 million, if we divide GH¢150 million by 10,000 people, assuming that all the monies are going to be shared to all the trainees, the amount of money that they are going to receive would be about GH¢15,000.00.

Mr Speaker, I ask again, what kind of business can you really use GH¢15,000.00 for? Can it even buy a container? Absolutely not! I do not think, GH¢15,000.00 is enough to be able to establish a business in this country. Because the President also promised that they are going to scale it up to 100,000 people, the budget estimate for 2025 was GH¢300 million. Now, in 2026, logical reasoning will tell you that if you use GH¢300 million to train 10,000 people, then in 2026 the allocation should be about GH¢3 billion.

Mr Speaker, unfortunately, the 2026 allocation for the National Apprenticeship Programme has been reduced from GH¢300 million to GH¢150 million. How do we use GH¢150 million to train 100,000 people? It cannot be the case, and that is why I am saying that Ghanaians were expectant of a Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was going to give prosperity and opportunity, however, what has been given is disappointment—

The Speaker: Hon Member, just a minute. Your time is saved for you. I can see the Majority Chief Whip on his feet. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, I rise in pursuance of Order 122(1). I want to seek clarification from

the Hon Member who just said, that GH¢15,000.00 cannot establish a business. He should clarify what kind of business he speaks of.

Mr Speaker, this is because we are on record to have voted for money in pursuance of Government policy to assist women to set up small businesses—young entrepreneurs. We have voted for money to be allocated to them to set up small businesses. So, he should clarify what kind of business he speaks of.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, what is he to clarify?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the blanket statement that GH¢15,000.00 cannot establish business, that cannot be a factual statement.

The Speaker: Hon Member, that is different from saying he should clarify. It is so clear to you that you do not need clarification again. Because it is so clear to you, you are raising questions on the matter that he has called to question that what business can GH¢15,000.00 be used to start? So, it is clear to you and you are thinking that the GH¢15,000.00 could be used to set up businesses. So, there is no need for clarification again.

So, it is clear to you. You are thinking that the GH¢15,000 could be used to set up businesses, so there is no need for clarification again.

1:46 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, there is a need; he should be specific.

Mr Speaker, in my Constituency, if he says that GH¢15,000 cannot set up a medium-scale business, then we can be clear, even with that, it is debatable, but small-scale businesses—

The Speaker: Please, you may disagree with him, but the issue you raised is one of clarification. In fact, he even cited that GH¢15,000 cannot buy a container. He was specific as to a type of business. You can disagree with him, but he was very clear. You can get up and say that GH¢15,000 can be used to start a banana sales business on a tabletop. You can say those things, but he was very clear; there is no need for clarification.

Please, go on.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, one does not need GH¢15,000 to purchase a container.

The Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, you are out of Order. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Assafuah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for protecting your nephew.

Mr Speaker, we have to always see you in this Chair, because when you are here, we feel protected.

Mr Speaker, the Budget provides no bold recruitment plan, no roadmap, and no credible strategy for absorbing trained young people into productive work. In the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they have indicated to the people of Ghana that they are going to create 800,000 jobs. I am going to give the breakdown of their 800,000 jobs promised, and Ghanaians would judge whether these are sustainable and permanent jobs that they promised the people of Ghana in the build-up to the 2024 elections.

Mr Speaker, I am happy that the Minister for Roads and Highways is here, they said that 490,000 jobs would be created out of the Big Push. Mr Speaker, you and I know that the tenure of engagement of these people who would be employed by the Big Push is coterminous with the lifespan of the contract. So, clearly, this cannot be a sustainable job. These are not permanent jobs that would be given.

Mr Speaker, secondly, they said that they would use the garment factories to create 20,000 jobs. They also said that the agro-processing plants would create 700 direct jobs. They also said the national policy on integrated oil palm development would create 250,000 jobs. *Yerekɔ akɔ dua palm oil*. The point is that these cannot be sustainable jobs based on what the Ghanaians voted for them. Ghanaians in 2024, asked them for sustainable jobs, they asked them for permanent jobs.

This is not the kind of jobs that we ask from them. In fact, early this year, when His Excellency John Mahama was forming his Government, they promised the people of Ghana that they would establish a Ministry for Youth Development and Empowerment. Their strategy was that the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment was supposed to be established deliberately to deal with youth issues in this country.

Today, as we speak, about 10 months down the line, the Ministry of Sports and Recreation can only boast of a “Red means Stop campaign.” Nothing has been done by the Ministry of Sports and Recreation. That is why I am saying that the youth of this country are disappointed because we were expecting a government that would create sustainable jobs. We were expecting a government that would create permanent jobs; unfortunately, that has not been done.

Mr Speaker, let me take you back to the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. I am happy that the Minister for Education is here. In the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, page 78, the item numbered 553, they stated that to address menstrual hygiene challenges and reduce absenteeism among female students, the Government, in fulfilment of their 120-day social contract, will distribute free sanitary pads to 1.3 million female students in basic and secondary schools.

The same 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, on page 71, on the social sector, stated that they have allocated GHC292 million to commence the distribution of free sanitary pads to

female students in primary and secondary schools. The question is, GH¢292 million divided by 1.3 million pads, how much would that be? GH¢292 million has been allocated to the Ministry of Education to purchase sanitary pads. A simple calculation will tell us that GH¢292 million divided by 1.3 million will give you about GH¢225 per pad.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, here is the catch. When they start to account to the people of Ghana that they have decided to distribute free sanitary pads to Ghanaians, they said on page 78, and I read:

“To promote gender equality in education and reduce absenteeism, 6.6 million packs of sanitary pads were distributed to girls in public basic schools”.

Mr Speaker, assuming without admitting that the allocation was not changed, GH¢292 million indeed was used to purchase the 6.6 million pads that they said they have distributed. A simple calculation will tell you that one pad is GH¢45.

Mr Speaker, I have in my hands here a publication that was made by the Ministry of Finance. The Ministry of Finance posted this on their Facebook wall, which says, and I read, “Sanitary pads have reduced from GH¢25 to GH¢15”. According to their own words, if indeed a sanitary pad is now GH¢15, why are they now accounting to the people of Ghana that one sanitary pad is GH¢45? This is a “chobo” Government.

This is not what the people of Ghana voted them to do.

Mr Speaker, to end with my submission, here in this House—

The Speaker: Hold on, please, your time is saved.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I should not intervene but I just heard my Colleague say that this is a “chobo” Government.

Mr Speaker, he said all sort of—
[*Interruption*]

Mr S. A. Jinapor — rose —

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I just saw my Friend, the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. The last time he got up here to say something, he had to apologise and withdraw. Today, he is still up again. I would encourage him to wait.

Mr Speaker, I will repeat it. He stood there last week and actually told an untruth, and he was caught—
[*Interruption*] Mr Speaker, I will not withdraw. Was that not the case?

The Speaker: Hon Minister, you are up on a point of order. So, raise the point of order, and let us go on.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, there are two things. My Colleague said that, first of all, the 480,000 jobs are not sustainable.

Mr Speaker, civil engineers, quantity surveyors, and architects, most time in the world, do not have a permanent job. They move from job to job. I am happy that the Government can create at least 480,000 jobs for two years. That is actually a good record. When we get to 2027, we continue. So, these are actually sustainable jobs.

Mr Speaker, the second one is that everybody knows in this country which part of the aisle actually has fleeced this country. To the extent that today, the National Service Scheme, which is supposed to be for ordinary people, somebody would take GH¢1.6 billion, and he says that has not yet been proven, and he is calling this Government a “chobo” Government. Really, this Side? He should not even be talking. If that is “chobo” then they were “chobo” times twenty thousand.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, you have not raised a point of order. You are rather contributing to the discussion. So, please, let us allow him to complete his submissions. Hon Minority Chief Whip, if you are asking to speak, you would take some of his time.

1:56 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I know you are too benevolent to do this to me.

On a lighter note, my Friend should just take it easy. I know he is a bit sensitive to some of the thrilling revelations coming out of the Budget, but he should relax and enjoy the flight.

We are only playing back their own facts, and it is coming from the Budget.

But seriously, Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I would not do this to my good Friend. He said, the Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor said something last week, and he has to withdraw. In fact, I came in to endorse **[An Hon Member:** Is that a point of order?]**]**—Listen.

The Speaker: You are falling into the same trap. What you are saying is not a point of order. I have already ruled on that matter, so do not go back there. Let us allow the Hon Member to complete his comments.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, thank you so much for protecting me from this needless interruption.

Let me put this matter in proper perspective. What the Hon Minister sought to say in this House had no basis—*[Pause]* As far as the National Service Secretariat—*[Pause]*

The Speaker: Please, one minute for him.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, there is no basis at all. The point is that I have given a basis in their 2025 and the 2026 Budget. And they are telling the people of Ghana that they are using GH¢292 million to purchase 6.6 million sanitary pads. How do they tell me that the argument that I am making here is baseless? It is true and it is a fact that in this Budget, their own Budget, they have used GH¢292 million to purchase 6.6 million sanitary pads, and I am saying

that a simple calculation of this figure tells us that one piece of sanitary pad is GH¢45. This is a publication from *Woezor*. It says that the price of Yazz sanitary pad which was GH¢25 in January is now going for GH¢15. Now at GH¢15, they are buying it for GH¢45.

[The Hon Member displays a photocopied document.]

Mr Dafeamekpor — rose —

The Speaker: Before he concludes, the Hon Majority Chief Whip is on his feet. Let me listen to him.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I rise in pursuance to Order 123 (1), Content of speech. The Hon Assafuah references the Government as “chobo” government. That is very unparliamentary.

The Speaker: Sorry, I did not hear the statement.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, you may not have heard it, but it has gone into the *Hansard* now—

The Speaker: I mean I did not hear what you said.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member, as part of his commentary, said the NDC Government is a “chobo” government. That is unparliamentary. They can say so on radio, but in this House, that language is not permissible. So, Mr Speaker, I am seeking your

guidance that that portion of the speech be expunged.

I thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, are you mentioning the word T-O-G-O? Did you say “Togo” government?—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, “chobo”, not “Togo”. He said “chobo”, C-H-O-B-O or T-S-O-B-O.

The Speaker: Hon Assafuah, did you say the Government is “chobo” government? *[Laughter]*

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, precisely so.

The Speaker: What does that mean?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, it means that 6.6 million pieces of sanitary pads that we could have procured with GH¢99 million, they are using GH¢293 million. That is more than three times the amount—*[Interruption]*.

The Speaker: The meaning of “chobo” government.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, it means wasteful. One can also say that there is no value for money. So, this is a wasteful Government. It is an overspending Government.

Mr Speaker, when we say overspending government, it means that they are a “chobo” government, *simpliciter*.

The Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, the Hon Member said that the word “chobo” means wasteful.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, not at all. It is a strict expression for fleecing somebody—[Uproar]—That is the phrase we use when one is fleecing somebody, that the person is taking “chobo” from the person. One is fleecing the person. That is what it suggests.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I do not know which language from which these words were taken. Actually, I do not understand the meaning of “chobo” at all, particularly the spelling. I am told either it is C-H-O-B-O or C-H-O-G-O or whatever, I do not know. But Hon Member, when you buy sanitary pad at GH¢15, you need to transport it to where you are going to distribute it; there is cost to it. [Uproar] Hon Members, you have been in government before. [Uproar] You want me to name you?

Yes, Minister for Education?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am compelled to rise on a point of order to my Colleague Member of Parliament on the issue of sanitary pads. This is the second time I have seen efforts to trivialise a major initiative by President Mahama to deal with female absenteeism which results in drop-out of young girls from school because of menstrual poverty.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague said authoritatively that each piece of sanitary pad costs GH¢45. It is simply untrue. Mr Speaker, 6.6 million pieces of sanitary

pads is not the final output of the sanitary pads contract. Part of it was competitively advertised and determined through a procurement process. While 6.6 million pieces of sanitary pads is what has been supplied, additional quantities are being delivered to Government. So, the Hon Member should not engage in “chop bar” arithmetic to say that 6.6 million divided by GH¢292 million is GH¢45, that is woefully inaccurate and grossly misleading. We are still in the procurement process of additional sanitary pads. [Uproar]

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, if you decide to reduce the deliberations to a shouting battle, I would have to reduce the time allocation. Let us listen to each other. The Minister for Education was trying to let you know that 6.6 million pieces is not the final quantity that is to be delivered. The 6.6 million pieces of sanitary pads has been delivered, but he says more is to be delivered. So, you listen, and then later on you can get up to counter it.

But when you start shouting, you disrupt everything, please. Hon Member, now, you may conclude.

2:06 p.m.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, thank you so much for the protection. The Hon Member, on a point of order, failed to provide any documentary evidence whatsoever to dispute whatever I am saying. I am quoting the figures from

their own Budget Statement and Economic Policy; I have not quoted anything different.

Mr Speaker, to simply and respectfully answer his analogy, if one goes to Mallam Atta Market today and wants to buy a single pad, and it is GH¢15—

The Speaker: Hon Minister, let me listen to what he is saying, then I can come to you. Yes.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, and if one were to go to Mallam Atta Market and a pad is GH¢15, how can they suggest that if one is buying it on wholesale, it will even be GH¢15? That is less in economies of scale. They do not need a soothsayer to tell them this. They do not need an economist to suggest this to them.

So, I am saying that, Mr Speaker, as far as their own documents are concerned, this is an overspending Government, wasteful Government, *chobo* Government— [*Hear! Hear!*] It is a Government that has failed the people of Ghana, and we did not expect this kind of Budget from them.

The Speaker: Hon Member, let me now listen to the Minister, because I have heard what you said.

Yes, please.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my Colleague is grossly misleading this House. Of the 6.67 million sanitary pads purchased, each of them contains 12

packs. So, the total is 79 million packs supplied. Not the simple mathematics he is doing. Every pack contains 12 pieces. So, in total, over 79 million sanitary packs are being supplied at the cost of the GH¢ 292 million.

And Mr Speaker, the process is not yet complete. We just awarded the last batch of contracts to complete the supply of what the Government requires to get the young girls in school. I thank you. He should stop misleading the House.

The Speaker: Hon Members, what the Hon Minister said is a point of clarification to explain the cost components. And that is what we need to clarify issues that are raised on the Floor that may create doubt. So, it is now left to the listeners to at least make up their minds. But when you leave it at that and start shouting, we do not carry the people along with us.

Please, your conclusion.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, surprisingly, the Minister for Education is trying to portray that he is an expert in the usage of sanitary pads. I do not know whether that is what he is trying to say. But it cannot be the case that whatever he is saying here is different from what I am saying.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, what did he say? Please—

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the authority in this House on education policy matters is the Minister for Education. My Colleague was emphatic

by using a certain mathematical formula to divide the amount and concluded on a certain number of individual sanitary pads. The Minister for Education corrected that, and I think it is very important that the Hon Member withdraws that part of his statement because if it remains in the record, it would mean that we used a certain amount of money to purchase a certain quantity of sanitary pads. He must nicely withdraw that part. Because, to put it lightly, Mr Speaker, he lied about that portion, and it must not remain in the record.

He must be compelled to withdraw that part where he divided the number of sanitary pads by the amount of money. He must do that. He can hold his view. On this Floor, once we are lucky to have the Minister for Education, who gave the facts, that becomes a fact. We are not going to take facts about education from a Colleague; we take them from the Minister for Education.

The Speaker: Hon Members, what the Minister for Roads and Highways has just done is to draw my attention to the fact that the clarification given by the Minister for Education should occasion a withdrawal of the earlier statement made by the Hon Member, Mr Vincent Assafuah.

I believe the only directive I can give is for him to take that as a guide because both his statement and the Minister's statement will be on the record of Parliament. So, people reading will then judge who is speaking the truth. But if we are to come to the conclusion that what

he said is not true, therefore it must be withdrawn, then many of you would have to withdraw your statements here. And at the end of the day, we may not even have the *Official Reports*.

So please, Hon Member, I take it that you have concluded because I have given you more than necessary.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, they have not allowed me to be consistent with the truth.

The Speaker: I have allowed you, not them.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, just one minute.

The Speaker: 30 seconds.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, thank you.

The truth of the matter is that nowhere in this country can one go to a supermarket or shop to buy a single pad. Nowhere. When one buys the pad, they are given 12 in a pack. So whatever the Minister is saying is not different from what I am saying. It is indeed the case that they bought one pack of sanitary pads for GHC45, *simpliciter*.

The Speaker: Please, this disorder is not allowed. You are not all on your feet. I have given one Member the opportunity to contribute, and you are all talking. If I allow that, with this number against your number, would they ever hear you? Please.

Hon Member, you know your voice is very loud—[*Laughter*]. It is so unique that anybody can identify who is speaking. I just gave him 30 seconds to conclude, then we move on. Because you will all get the opportunity to rebut what is being said. Please, that is what the debate is about.

Yes, please. 30 seconds.

Mr Assafuah: So, Mr Speaker, it is settled that according to their own Budget Statement and Economic Policy, that is how much they are buying the sanitary pads.

The Ghanaian people do not crave for another profligate, convoluted and economically injudicious fiscal manifesto. They yearn for a budget that is coherent, credible and genuinely catalytic. One that galvanises employment, institutionalises teacher and nursing recruitment and energises the aspirations of our youth.

Mr Speaker, let us therefore repudiate this fiscally errant and socially regressive blueprint and champion a framework that is equitable, transformational and anchored in long-term national prosperity. I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Hon Members, before I call on the next person, I promised to give you some books. Because of what has happened—by the formula of distribution—I have 20 copies, and I am handing them over—It cannot be 10 on each Side—[*Laughter*—Your Leader stood here and argued forcefully that the

formula must be applied to all situations, and I was drawing his attention to the fact that, in many situations, it will be to your disadvantage. He disagreed, and it was adopted by the House. So, please, that is the formula you have to use to distribute.

2:16 p.m.

This one is somebody's candid, and I must say, bold perception of what politics in Ghana is, and this is a very respected statesman. That is how I see him, Mr Kofi Bentum Quantson. Those of you who know him, you know him very well as one of our security—capo, one of the best. Please, kindly take these books, read and be guided. I am buying them for you. I cannot buy for 276, but at least 20 copies are available because I am also distributing some to some political heavyweights outside Parliament so that we all read and be guided by what he thinks we are doing in Ghana here. Please, you may hand them over to the Majority Leader who is the Leader of the House.

[*The books were placed on the Table.*]

Hon Members, it is the turn of Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan. He has 30 minutes.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu, he has not started.

Yes, what is it?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my issue has to do with the time

allocated to him because the Business Statement that was presented by the Chairman of the Business Committee only gave the Leaders concluding more than the 15 minutes allocated, not necessarily every Leader on the Frontbench. The Business Statement that was presented by the Chairman indicated that Ministers and any other person, including Leaders, have 15 minutes. I do not know on what basis the Deputy Majority Leader will be speaking for 30 minutes.

The Speaker: Yes, please, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I recall that originally, we allotted 45 minutes to the Leaders and 30 minutes to other Leaders. I proposed that we should make it one hour for the Leader, the arrowheads. That was the only change we effected by moving 45 minutes to 1 hour for the arrowheads. All the other times allotted for the other category of commentators remained the same, and it was 30 minutes for other Leaders.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I am guided by what is submitted to me by the Leaders, and the time allocation that is stated there for each contributor. That is what I am going by.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I think we have to settle this matter. He is our Colleague in Leadership. I am sad that we have to do this on the Floor. Fact be told, Hon Majority Leader, yes, at the Business Committee meeting, it was an argument whether we should allot one hour to the Leaders. There was a debate

about it. We even extended it by saying that we should reduce it so that that time could be given to more of our Backbenchers to speak. That is fact—it is a fact.

However, we said that apart from the Leaders who will speak for one hour each, all other Leaders inclusive of the Frontbench and Ranking Members and Chairpersons, 15 minutes. What you have there is at least generated by the Whips. If you look at our list, all the Members are Ranking Members, except Ms Ida, who is not a Ranking Member. Hence, she was allotted time less than 15 minutes. So, I do not know why— But Mr Ricketts-Hagan, it is not about him. It is about the principle and the time agreed on. The Hon Member is not harmful. We know he is not harmful, but let us go by the agreement. This House has adopted the Business Statement, so we cannot do otherwise. We adopted the Business Statement, and adopted the time allotment. Therefore, we can vary it. If you are seeking to vary it, seek the leave of the Speaker. Probably, you can seek the leave of the Speaker to get more—The Speaker is charitable. He could give you some five minutes in addition to your 15 minutes. But do not on your own allot 30 minutes to yourself. That is wrong.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, these matters go to integrity, and I take them very seriously. In fact, at the Committee Meeting, in the absence of my two Leaders, I chaired it. When the draft came, the only correction, and my Brother will bear me out, was to shift the time allotment of 45 minutes for the arrowheads to one hour. When my Leader came eventually, I gave him that

draft. The draft will indicate that, and I have it here, it was only the time allotment that I used my ink to change from 45 minutes to 1 hour. All the other proposed times remained the same.

The Speaker: So, what is the proposed time for the frontliners?

Mr Dafeamekpor: For the other Leaders, it was 30 minutes.

The Speaker: It is 30 minutes. Please, I was not here when the Business Committee's Report was adopted.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, if I may read page 2 of the Business Statement as approved by the Committee for presentation on the Floor—

Mr Speaker, the item numbered 4(c) reads:

“Accordingly, the Business Committee recommends the following time allotments for contributions by Hon Members. (i) Majority Leader and Minority Leader, one hour. Other leaders, 30 minutes. Ministers, 15 minutes. Chairpersons, Ranking Members of Committees, 15 minutes. Vice Chairpersons and Deputy Ranking Members, 10 minutes. Other Hon Members, 5 minutes.”

This was what we adopted subject to other commentaries by Members on Friday. Mr Speaker, I humbly submit it.

The Speaker: Please, do you have something different from that?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker. I have a copy of the Business Statement that was presented and adopted by this House. What the Majority Leader—If you come to page 2 (5), commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government, “Pursuant to Order 195(3), the Business Committee is reminded, Hon Members, that the commentary of the Budget...” Mr Speaker, there is nowhere—*[Interruption]* No, wait Mr Speaker, no allocation—

Mr Speaker, this is a matter that—*[Interruption]*—when you check this Business—*[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, the introduction—*[Interruption]*—wait. They said the arranged Business of the House of the sixth week ending Friday, 28th. This Business Statement is supposed to end on the 28th. So, what he is saying is not something that was captured—*[Interruption]* No, we never said Leaders are going to speak for 30 minutes in this Chamber. He is the only one saying it. Does he mean we on this Side never listened to the Business Statement or what? We did, and we were in the Chamber.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, there was a Business Statement presented to this House on the 14th of November, which set out the time and the commentary that will be done for the week beginning 18th and ending 21st. What he is presenting is the most recent Business Statement which covers the 25th which is today and ending on 28th November, 2025. That one does not delve into the time

allotment. It is the Business Statement that ends on the 21st that delves into the time allotment, and that is what he has referred to.

So, if he has the Business Statement for the period ending 21st November, he can check it and see if what the Hon Member has read is inaccurate.

2:26 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I have your attention?

The Speaker: Yes, please.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Orders allows you the power to exercise discretion when it comes to interpretation and such occurrences. This is not a matter that we should split hairs over. Thirty minutes to be given to Hon Ricketts-Hagan, one of our own in Leadership is not too much of a demand. We were arguing on principle and the Hon Majority Leader came back to say that the Business Statement referenced by my able—One thing we cannot take away from Hon Habib Iddrisu is his attention to details. He is always paying attention to Business on the floor of the House. So maybe he could not get the date as the Majority Leader was communicating, but it does not mean that he is saying something out of malice.

The Speaker: Hon Members, it is all right. I do not have access to the contents of the two Business Statements, and I do not know whether the first Business Statement was continued by the second Business Statement. It is the first that has

the details as the Majority Leader has stated. I do not know whether in the second Business Statement you referred to the first and adopted that portion. If not, it will be taken that that first Business Statement lapsed after 21st November. But if there is a reference in the second Business Statement to it, then it will still apply. It means if you discontinued it and you did not include it, then you cannot assume that that is still applicable. But I do not have the content of that Business Statement.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by way of a guide, in the Business Statement that he referenced, that was adopted last Friday, the item numbered 5(a) states as follows:

“Commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 195(3) the Business Committee is reminding Hon Members that the commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government which commenced on Tuesday, 18th November, 2025 will continue on Tuesday, 25th November. The Majority and Minority Leaders will conclude the commentary on Wednesday, 26th November.”

So, the commentaries, as we arranged before, are the same principles and guidelines that we have adopted this week. It is as a result of that, that as agreed, the Leaders will conclude tomorrow. We have varied the conditions and terms.

The Speaker: Let us agree that we will give Leaders 30 minutes, then finally, the arrowheads, as we call them, will have one hour each. Do not let us drag this further. Let us go on. So, Hon Ricketts-Hagan will have 30 minutes, then when it comes to the Minority, there will also be 30 minutes. That is all. So let us go on.

Hon George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan, you may commence your comments now.

Deputy Minority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Whether I speak for 15 minutes or 30 minutes, I do not think that will change how good this Budget Statement and Economic Policy is. Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 financial year, which was ably presented by Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, the Minister for Finance, on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, on behalf of His Excellency, the President of the Republic, John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, my Friends on the other Side have the right to worry about, in a way, trying to limit the time we talk or trying to gag us. Because they do not want us to remind Ghanaians of the bitter experience that they have been through for the last eight years. The story must be told; Ghanaians must know how abysmally our friends on the opposite Side ran this country for the last eight years, the painful story and how His Excellency, John Dramani Mahama has managed to turn the mess around in 11

months. Mr Speaker, Ghanaians will not forget the hopelessness and the helplessness that our Friends on the opposite Side presented to people in this country.

Mr Speaker, the economy of Ghana had basically collapsed. The economy was on a life support machine. It will probably be best described as an economy in a vegetative state. Apologies to people who are probably suffering somewhere in hospitals either here or abroad, who unfortunately may be in a vegetative state or a life support machine. Mr Speaker, I pray that they get well soon and be up on their feet, including those who are not here, and getting treatment elsewhere, so that they will be able to come home and account for their stewardship.

Mr Speaker, our Friends on the opposite Side are contesting this Budget Statement and Economic Policy that we have before us. But they have forgotten that they ran this country into bankruptcy. They collapsed Ghana's economy and created serious liquidity problems. The economy was run recklessly. They created, looted and shared, irresponsible borrowing and wasteful expenditure. That is their record, and that is what Ghanaians will always remember them for. Ghanaians have not forgotten about them.

All of a sudden, under a year, they have put on a new cassock and are giving a different preaching. They are telling Ghanaians that now they are patron saints of Ghana's economy, yet when they were in office for eight years, they

absolutely ran this country to the ground. Mr Speaker, the embarrassing and shameful reminder of our friends who were incompetent in government cannot soon be forgotten.

Mr Speaker, I am sure pensioners will remember them. Those who lost their savings and could not afford to treat themselves. I am sure bondholders will remember them with the haircut that they got and the difficulties that they went through. I am sure that farmers will remember them. Mr Speaker, I am sure the fisher folk in my Constituency will remember them.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the Hon First Deputy Speaker to take the chair.

2:36 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Order!

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, just before the NDC Government came to office, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme that we were under had been derailed by the NPP Government before they left office. They have missed all the benchmarks. It took this Government in the last 11 months to correct these benchmark figures and get the economy

back on track. Mr Speaker, it looks as if they have solutions for the economy when they are in opposition. But when they are in government, they have no idea what they should be doing.

Mr Speaker, they talk about inflation; in fact, they try to take some credit for the good news that we have in this Budget. At the same time, they criticise the numbers in the Budget. I heard some of my Colleagues on the other Side say that the single-digit inflation we have is not sustainable, and that the Government is not tackling the supply side problem that can get inflation out of hand. I have no idea what they are talking about, because the inflation we have today, the single-digit inflation that we are enjoying has no supply side effect.

In fact, when they were in office, and we had the COVID-19 pandemic and supply chain disruptions, that was when we had a supply-side problem with inflation. The so-called Russia-Ukraine war, that they were hanging on to, also created some supply-side problems. But what did they do, Mr Speaker? Instead of trying to find solutions on the fiscal side and deal with it, they rather ceded to the monetary policy, that is, the Central Bank to print money for them to solve that problem.

Today, they are talking about the supply-side. The inflation we have today is a demand-side inflation. It is not coming from any disruptions from anywhere. It is amazing to think that the Russia-Ukraine war is still going on; it has intensified, more bombs are being thrown at the capital Kyiv, more bombs

are being thrown at Russia, but Ghana's economy is actually doing better. When the war started, they claimed that our woes were as result of the Russia-Ukraine war. The war is getting more serious, but Ghana's economy is actually now getting better. Mr Speaker, it tells us clearly that they did not have a clue about how to manage Ghana's economy. They did not have it then, and they do not have it now. We listen to their debate, and we cannot get the head from the tail. We have no idea what they are talking about.

Mr Speaker, they should not forget that they got inflation up to 54 per cent in 2022. Today, we are hovering around 8 per cent, and things are looking better. Mr Speaker, do you remember debts? This country was so much in debt that our debt was about 80 per cent of our Gross Domestic Product (GDP) at some point. Today, our debt is around 45 per cent of GDP. Mr Speaker, they said they were dealing with a currency problem. Our cedi got to about GH¢17.00 to the U.S.A. dollar. Today, it is around GH¢10.00 or GH¢11.00. Nothing has really changed much, but the economy of Ghana is getting better. It tells us the incompetence of our Friends on the opposite Side, not having a clue on how to manage Ghana's economy, and they still do not. They think they can shout. They call themselves the mighty Minority, but that will not change the economy. Things are so good. Life in Ghana is better than it was last year. Things are getting better in this country. They can deny it for as long as they want.

Mr Speaker, the exchange rate is now doing well, and they are saying that, "this

will evaporate very soon". To where? They say that we are pumping money from the Central Bank to prop up the currency. None of that is true. It tells us clearly, they do not even understand the economy that they want to manage, or they did manage. There is no such thing. The Central Bank is doing the regular monetary policy or the monetary measures, but they are not doing anything that is out of hand, or extraordinary in terms of basically getting our currency to where it is.

I have said it in this Chamber before that something fundamental has changed in Ghana's economy that they are not paying attention to. They are still on the old economics, and I said that the GoldBod that was set up has become a game changer. We can also talk about the gold purchase, which, of course, they started, but it has been intensified by this Government. For about 100 years, we have produced gold, but we have not backed our economy with gold until this year. All these factors contributed about GH¢2 billion to Ghana's economy. This is what has stabilised our currency, not anything like what they are talking about in terms of anybody putting money to try and prop up the currency. At some stage, our reserves were just about one month of import cover. Today, there is a solid three months of import cover, and it is because of the prudent management of Ghana's economy, which they did not understand then and do not understand it now.

Mr Speaker, I heard someone talk about how we are not meeting our tax revenue. Let me give them the statistics

of tax revenue. I had the opportunity to work with the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA). The budget tax up until this point is GH¢145.8 billion, and we have collected GH¢144.7 billion. Therefore, there is a shortfall of 0.7. Mr Speaker, typically, at this time of the year, which is like October or November, about 76 per cent of the taxes have actually been collected. Currently, we are at 76.5 per cent, which means that by the end of the year, the overall tax of about GH¢189 billion will actually be collected. Yes, we still have room to go. Yes, we are still not the same as our peers, and we must continue to increase revenue and rationalise expenditure, but we are not far off.

The Value Added Tax (VAT) measures and reforms we have put in place would address a lot of these problems, to make sure that our taxes get to where they should be. [*Hear! Hear!*]

2:46 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has to rationalise the expenditure. They talked about the cut on expenditure items. Yes, we would not do things the way they used to do it. We will not spend recklessly. We would not waste the taxpayers' money. We will make sure the money of this Republic is used prudently. We will make sure that we cut our coats according to our cloth and not do the things that they did that got us to where we were. We have worked hard to bring things to where we are today.

Mr Speaker, inflation is down because food inflation is down.

Something they could never manage. Exchange rate inflation is down; something they could never manage. What they were good at is, mismanaging Ghana's economy, spending recklessly and saying that they do not have any solution. In fact, at the tail end of the former President's presidency, he gave up and said that the problems of this country would be fixed by the next president. So, they gave up even before the elections.

Today, their numbers actually tell what they did to Ghanaians and how Ghanaians have paid them back. They lost the elections abysmally because of their bad management of the economy. I am quite surprised how they are able to get here every morning to talk about Ghana's economy, something they know nothing about. Everything is here in this Budget. If they take the opportunity to read it, they would know how to manage Ghana's economy; something they could never manage—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Majority Leader, hold on. Stop the time for him. Yes, Hon Stephen Amoah, why are you up?

Dr Stephen Amoah: Mr Speaker, Order 122(1) (c) "...by a point of information, elucidation or clarification"

My respectable Hon Member stated that we actually did reckless expenditure. I want him to bring clarity on what he described as reckless, so we can all be well informed.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Stephen Amoah, there is no uncertainty or ambiguity about the word “reckless”. So, kindly resume your seat. Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, you have the floor. Dr Stephen Amoah, kindly resume your seat.

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, I will do so. But I am surprised that he is using the phrase “reckless expenditure” and you say there is no problem with it?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, resume your seat.

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan, you may continue.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, they dug a hole not too far away from here for US\$58 million. I cannot begin to catalogue the wasteful expenditure that they were involved in for the last eight years.

Mr Speaker, H. E. John Dramani Mahama had to come in to take this economy and rescue it out of the mess that they created. Today, they are talking about planes and private jets. What did they do during their time with private jets? They were renting them to have a bath in them. Those are reckless expenditures, if they do not know what reckless expenditures are. And they were justifying it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you are up, can we know why?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, thank you.

I rise on a point of order to ask the Deputy Majority Leader—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you are up on a point of order, you have to specifically indicate the Order that has been breached.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I will kindly say that I rise on the combined effect of Order 123(2) (a) and (b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you cannot be on a point of order and again rise on Order 123. If you rise on a point of order to interrupt the debate under Order 122, you must satisfy the condition in order 122(5).

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I hear you. But you ruled when the Majority Leader got up to interject that, the Majority Leader has the right to rise on a point of order to correct a false impression. You ruled on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I was sitting— He was up on a point of clarification.

Mr Nitiwul: I am saying that you were the very one who ruled on it and I am saying that it is the same thing I rise on. I am rising on a point that he made.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. Mr Nitiwul, you are a former Leader. I asked why you were up and you said you were up on a point of order. I know that the point of order is under Standing Order 122(a). And when you are rising on a point of order, you must satisfy the condition stated in Order 122(5). With your indulgence, let us look at it together. Standing Order 122(5);

“A Member who interrupts debate on a point of procedure or point of order shall state the rule of procedure the Member on the floor has breached or the procedural matters that requires a ruling of the Speaker before subjecting the Member on the floor to the ruling of the Speaker.”

So, you told me you are interrupting the debates on a point of order by Standing Order 122 (a), and I am just asking you to satisfy the condition in Order 122(5).

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, precisely, and it is the more reason why you should listen to me, because I could ask you to intervene. You have not even listened to me. You do not even know what I want to say. I could ask you to intervene in the matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you know if you are asking for the Speaker's intervention, once you are on your feet, you would say, “Mr Speaker, I am asking for your intervention.” But with this, you indicated by the record that you are up on a point of order. So, we have to go by the rules.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I precisely agree with you. But the point I am still making is that that, the point of order could also lead to you intervening in this matter. It is precisely why I would want you to intervene.

Mr Speaker, I would ordinarily not rise on a point of order against as a Deputy Majority Leader. So, I want you to intervene on something.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the rules are clear. If you are on point of order, you know what to do. I do not think you are up on a point of order. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 123(2)(a) and (b)—Content of speech. I heard the Deputy Majority Leader say that the NPP Administration went ahead to procure aircrafts, with the sole aim of taking their bath in the aircraft. He said that. He made that statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He made that statement, that, we were taking our bath in the aircrafts. If the Deputy Majority Leader is so minded to stand by that statement, I will not contest him, but he knows what to do. He must provide evidence to what he said or steer clear of that and proceed to make his statement. Otherwise—

2:56 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Minority Chief Whip, are you asking the Member on the Floor to provide evidence of bathing in the aircraft?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I did not ask him to say that. He is alleging.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I overheard the main speaker indicate that we are not at a trial so if we are requesting for evidence on everything, I believe the debate may not flow. There is also have the opportunity to disagree with him so if it is the evidence that you are asking for, maybe when you have the opportunity you can disagree with him.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let me further say that it is an offensive statement. We on this Side feel offended by that statement and that is in contradiction to Order 123 (2)(a) and (b) and he knows that he stands in breach of that of those Orders. I am not just saying that he should just state clearly, he should provide evidence and if he has no evidence, he should do the needful. He has been speaking for 25 minutes; nobody interrupted him to say that we have been bathing in an aircraft. He must be responsible enough to provide the needed evidence.

Mr Speaker, I am not asking for too much, he knows what to do and I am not asking the Majority Leader to come and bail him so he should resume his seat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Chief Whip, if you say that he used the phrase “bathing in the air” and that is offensive or it imputes improper motive, it is one thing, but you are asking him to produce the evidence of the fact that bathing in the air really took place.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think it is important to contextualise things. Some aircrafts, especially the private jets, have provisions for toilets. They function perfectly well and cost less but some jets have bathrooms in them. So when a President is travelling and instead of hiring the smaller one that just has a toilet, he goes for a jet that has a bathroom in it, the presumption is that he would bath in the air. [*Uproar*] That is how the conversation about bathing in the air came about. Hon Dominic Nitiwul said it this week.

Mr Speaker, so when we go for an aircraft that has a bathroom, it is obvious that you want to bath in the air because you pay for that facility in the aircraft and I cannot imagine a President hiring an aircraft that has a bathroom in it, paying for the facility and not utilising it.

Mr Speaker, if the Deputy Leader says that the President was bathing in the air it was more likely to be true than not. The reason I say so is that knowing the former President and his personality, I cannot imagine him not using the bathroom in the aircraft—[*Laughter*]—I cannot imagine him not using the

bathroom in the aircraft because he is a gentleman.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Yes, Hon Nitiwul?

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader mentioned my name. There is a big difference between engaging in propaganda outside—The media engaging in propaganda or reporting and then he coming to Parliament to come and say that. I have never said in anyway not in this House or outside that the former President for whom I was serving as a Minister for Defence has bathed or intends to bath in the air. Never!

Mr Speaker, the closest— And I know my words very well, at least I was very diligent with my work and it is the reason I stayed for eight years. I came here and said that one of the problems that we have is that to even freshen up is a problem and these are the words I used and I would still use those words. Yes. I use the words, “to even freshen up is a problem” but they would pick propaganda outside and drag it into this House —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, you have made your point. You said that you never used the phrase “bathed in the air”; you said “to even freshen up is a problem.”

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I never said that but I want to repeat that the Leadership of Majority Side should stop

impugning bad motive to the former President.

Mr Speaker, if they do not stop, he knows that I know that the President used to hire Global Express which is a private jet. I will show pictures of that private jet but I was the Minister for Defence and I was forced in this House to say that when President Mahama was a first-time president, he was hiring private jets. Former President Akufo-Addo was not the first. If former President Akufo-Addo learnt from somebody, he learnt how to hire private jets from President Mahama.

Mr Speaker, they should stop. I have been very careful in doing my work and as a former Minister, I am not able to say what I know. The Members of the other Side should stop what they are doing, if they want to debate, they should do so because former President Akufo-Addo is not here but if they read some propaganda piece that their papers are writing, that is their own headache.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, *Joy FM online*, a credible media house in this country published on its website on 16th June, 2021 at exactly 12:30 p.m. and the heading is;

“Akufo-Addo can’t even shower in presidential jet – Nitiwul defends President’s alleged extravagant foreign travels”.

So, Hon Nitiwul was complaining that the presidential jet that Ghana has is inconvenient because president Akufo-Addo cannot shower in that jet—*[Uproar]* And he said that it was inconvenient to use that aircraft because it meant that the President had to travel to his destination, alight, go and shower and now attend his meetings so the President needed an aircraft that he could shower inside so that when he lands he goes straight to his meetings.

Mr Speaker, let me read quotations not reporting, quotations because the media has quoted you verbatim. It says:

“The Defence Minister has justified government’s decision to hire a luxury aircraft for President Akufo-Addo’s latest foreign trip which is alleged to have cost £15,000 per hour. Addressing Parliament on Wednesday, Dominic Nitiwul insisted that using the presidential jet would not have been a good idea he stated that the presidential jet, the Falcon, was not conducive and presented many challenges when the President was embarking on his 10-day foreign travel. He stated that although the Falcon was airworthy, it lacked certain facilities like a washroom. It lacked a washroom, where one takes their bath, because I know it has a toilet, like a washroom, and it could not contain more than eight passengers.”

3:06 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, the Hon Former Leader, Mr Nitiwul Bingab Aduna, said that what you are reading is media

propaganda, and that he did not say it. What he said on the floor of Parliament is that he used the word “freshen up”.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I read:

“The Bimbilla MP said, the President was embarking on a reputable business trip in multiple destinations...”

And mentions the countries.

“Thus, hiring another aircraft to those destinations became a suitable option.”

Then they start to quote Mr Nitiwul, and this is what he said, and I read:

“In practical experience, since the aircraft was acquired in 2010, whenever the aircraft is travelling to the eastern part of the United States or Asia, the aircraft will not load through more than eight plus the luggage. So, it depends on where it is going, and the payload with it. Secondly, I have also said, the aircraft has to do refueling stops. And also, in this COVID-19, when you are travelling to multiple destinations, like the presidential recent travel, the Falcon could not have been taken, because he would have had to do technical stops, which are not desirable. Again, when he is travelling with more than 20 people for a business trip, as he has done, and brought huge sums of money to this nation, he will need more than just a Falcon. Otherwise, the others will have to go a day

ahead before the President to prepare themselves. In fact, the President would have to go a day ahead, because no President can shower in this aircraft. He cannot move from this aircraft straight to a meeting.”

So, the President wanted an aircraft in which he could shower, then move from there straight to a meeting. This is what he said. Mr Speaker, there are a lot of quotations, but that is the point I want to make. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us continue with the debate.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, if I am asked this question again, just as I did last week, I would repeat exactly what I said. The Question Mr Okudzeto asked me demanded a Written Answer; it is in the *Hansard*. I remember my words, and I am very careful with my words. In fact, if they do not know, I wrote to Joy FM on this very matter. I used the word “freshen up” and they have it. So, if the Majority Leader is quoting some propaganda—I used this very word and it turned out to be a propaganda. Let me repeat that it is for that same reason that the Government is looking for two aircrafts; one long haul and the other short haul. It is for that same reason that I stated it here. I do not run away from those reasons. I still state that Ghana, as a leading country, cannot continue to do what it is doing because tomorrow, we would regret it. I have said it here. I said that our aircraft, whether it is the jet fighters, presidential, or the helicopters, have problems and that we would regret

it one day. I did not know when we would regret. I did not even know we were going to regret the next year. I said it, and I repeat that we would regret it. I continue to say that if we do not fix the problem, we would regret it one day.

Mr Speaker, if you are sick, I would not be able to ferry you out of the country. But I used the word “freshen up,” and I am saying that if they quote a propaganda piece, that is their cup of tea. They should go and look at the *Hansard*. It was a Written Answer. In any case, I still want to repeat that and I stand by those words. The only word I do not stand by is “shower”. A President should have the ability to freshen up and be able to go to meetings. I do not run away from that. I want to say that a President of a respected Republic, one that knows what he is doing, when that President travels, he should be able to travel with investors, and should be able to freshen up and go for meetings. If they choose to say that the President should go and bath in the air, that is their cup of tea and not the former President, Nana Akufo-Addo’s. I never said that about Akufo-Addo, and I am very clear. I first used the word “toilet”— [*Interruption*]

Mr Speaker, if they have money, they should go and buy an aircraft that has a shower. Last week, when they took 12 military officers to France, they should go and see the kind of aircraft that the officers recommended. They should not let me start talking. But we are waiting for them. Parliament had not passed the Budget, but they took 12 military officers to France, and they should go and check what the officers

recommended. I used “freshen up” and that is the word I used. I will not run away from that. I stand by that word today, and I would stand by that word tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, I say that if we do not do something, one day, we would regret. We have regretted once. We may regret a second time.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the disagreements are noted. I do not know why we are crying over this. Mr Nitiwul indicated that he did not use the word “shower”. He used the word “freshen up”. Whatever the media has published is media propaganda.

So, Mr Ricketts-Hagan, kindly continue your debate.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: In this House, we should respect your guidance. Your conclusion was that what was said in the media or media propaganda cannot be used in this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I am quoting Mr Nitiwul and that cannot amount to my conclusion.

I indicated clearly that they both have disagreements. One person said: “These were your words...”, and read from a source, and Mr Nitiwul said, “I spoke on the floor of Parliament, and these were my words”.

So, we need to end somewhere, to continue with the debate.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, I timed the Hon Majority Leader; he spoke for about five minutes, copiously and selectively, reading from his so-called source, and that is written in the *Hansard*. It is going into the records of this House.

Mr Speaker, I plead with you, in line with your directives, to the extent that the Hon Majority Leader is not referencing the *Official Reports*, and he is referencing other sources that cannot be authenticated, you should expunge that from the records in the first place.

Mr Speaker, secondly, you have also ruled that where we differ with facts, and we get the opportunity, then you can recant or rebut. I came under Order 123 based on context. Mr Speaker, you have ruled that when we get the opportunity, we should rebut; that should be the ruling. So, if our Side also makes pronouncements, and this Side disagrees, they cannot come under context —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is exactly what I am saying. Whatever is happening between the Hon Majority Leader and Mr Nitiwul is a disagreement between them. So, if you have the opportunity, you can do so on the Floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, Mr Nitiwul said he used the word “freshen up”, he did not say shower—

. **Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Majority Leader, let us make progress

3:16 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, Hon Nitiwul said, he used the phrase, “freshen up” and not “shower in the air”. So, I decided to find the meaning of “freshen up” on Google, and it says—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, that cannot be—
[Laughter] Hon Majority Leader, with all due respect—

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, “freshen up” means refresh oneself by washing—
[Laughter]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we should make progress. We have a tall agenda.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, let me read. The Hon Majority Leader was the one who claims somebody did not go to a good school, and yet he cannot read.

Mr Speaker, let me read. “Freshen up” means “refresh oneself by washing or changing into clean clothes”—
[Laughter]. Where is the bathing? “Refresh oneself by washing or changing into clean clothes.” Two, “make something look newer or more attractive”. Where is the bathing? Read. Did he not go to school, or he does not know how to read?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think I still stand by my ruling.

I will call on Hon Ricketts-Hagan to continue the debate. Hon Ricketts-Hagan, you have the floor.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I think the debate has already been made for me by my Hon Colleague. Whether it was to freshen up or to wash, something took place in the air.

Mr Speaker, the fact of the matter is that the NDC Government in office today are better managers of the economy of Ghana than the NPP in the past. [Hear! Hear!] If they would take some time and go through the Budget, they will begin to learn something, and hopefully someday, they may get the opportunity again to right what they did wrong.

Mr Speaker, the economy is getting better. We are out of the mess; inflation is in a better position today; interest rates are in a better position today; GDP is in a better position today; primary balance is in a better position today, Ghana is back again, and the economy is getting better. I urge my Colleagues to spend some time to look through this Budget and support the Government in making sure that we put the right things in place for Ghana to grow, for jobs to be created, whatever they call sustainable jobs, but for jobs to be created so that our youth will have something to do and better their lives.

Mr Speaker, with these words, I thank you very much [Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, none of you is the timekeeper.

I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth. You are speaking for 15 minutes.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP — Okere): Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me this opportunity to make commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 financial year.

Mr Speaker, a lot has been said by both Colleagues on this Side and the Majority Side. One of the most important things we all ought to know is that as government, it is important to commit to our words. It is important to stick to the promises that we make to the people. When we deliver our manifestos and assure the people of Ghana of our intentions for them, it is important that when we are voted into power and given the mandate, we walk our talk. The NDC made a lot of promises and a lot of fanciful projections; Big Push, Youth in Agriculture programme. They talked about the 24-Hour Economy and a lot more. But it is said, “the devil is in the details”.

Mr Speaker, on Big Push, the Minister for Finance presented the 2025 Budget and indicated an amount of GH¢13.8 billion. If we take the appropriation amount, it is actually GH¢13,759,693.13. That is a shortfall of GH¢40 million. His attention was drawn to it in this House. Yet, even in the revised budget, he kept mentioning GH¢13.8 billion for the general public,

when in fact, the amount allocated was short by GH¢40 million.

Mr Speaker, notwithstanding, the Minister for Finance told us in the revised Budget that all the revenue fund from the oil revenue Annual Budget Funding Amount (ABFA) and the mineral royalties was going to be used to fund the Big Push. Again, he indicated that for the next two years, which is the year 2025 and 2026, the Big Push was going to focus only on road infrastructure projects. In paragraph 469 of the 2025 Mid-Year Review, the Minister for Finance stated, and I quote:

“Mr Speaker, as part of the 2025 Budget, we announced the commencement of the Big Push Programme, a flagship initiative of President John Mahama for massive infrastructure development”.

He moved on to say in paragraph 470 that:

“Since then, the President has dedicated all Big Push budgetary allocations over the next two years to improve road infrastructure”.

Mr Speaker, he goes ahead to say, “Mr Speaker may recall, that Parliament approved that all oil revenues and mineral”, emphasis on ‘all’. What do we see? In 2026, when he was giving accounts, the Minister for Finance indicated that as at the time he was reading the Budget, no allocation had gone to the Big Push. However, sitting in the books in accounting for the ABFA was some US\$290 million of which

about US\$1.9 of it had gone to District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF).

Mr Agbodza — *rose* —

Mr Addo-Kenneth: So, my question is, what is the rest of the money sitting in the books for? Are we just keeping the money in the books just to create an impression that we have good indications while the project that has to be done has been left?

Mr Speaker, again, the revenue for the minerals for quarter one to quarter three, was also projected at GHC3.9 billion. As we speak, all these moneys are sitting there, and the Minister for Finance has indicated that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, hold it, they will stop your time for you.

Hon Minister, you are on your feet. Kindly tell me why you are on your feet.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my Colleague has the right to express his views about the Big Push but I have been here already to say that almost all the contractors on the Big Push Projects are on site. Even today, per my latest briefing, a contractor has already done 35 per cent of the work. Why do we keep the US\$3.8 billion? Because we are expecting that between now and 31st December, some contractors will raise certificates, and we do not want a situation where contractors raise certificates, and we tell them there is no money, because we commit that within 30 days when they raise certificate, they

are paid to go back to site. So, this is a settled matter.

I do not know the constituency of the Hon Member, but if he tells me his region, I can read out which projects we are doing. [**Mr Boamah:** Eastern Region.] Eastern Region? Very good. Do I have the right to read what is happening in Eastern Region?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Boamah, I do not like what you are doing. You are not supposed to talk directly to the person on his feet. If the person is asking a question, you are not the one being asked the question. So, Hon Minister, I do not expect you to answer that question emanating from Hon Boamah.

Mr Agbodza: Just because this is a House of record, I was going to read out to him the projects that are in the Eastern Region under the Big Push Project. In fact, one of the contractors is doing extremely well. So, the money is not sitting doing nothing. The projects are over 60 billion. I can tell you that the 13 billion can be consumed in a month if contractors start raising certificates. So just wait. Give us up to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, noted.

Yes, Hon Addo-Kenneth?

3:26 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I was wondering if my good Friend is coming under Order 122 or 123. You

have given guidance that where there is a disagreement, the other party should wait, and when it is their turn, they can respond accordingly. So, he should allow the Hon Member to flow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Exactly so. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, for emphasis, I never said the “Big Push” programmes had not started. The Minister for Finance indicated a lot of feasibility—Some have mobilised to the site. What I am saying is that he indicated that none of the funds had been disbursed at the time he was presenting the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. And if I were allowed, the Minister would have known where I was going.

Mr Speaker, in paragraph 472 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, he said that as a result of the GH¢13.8 billion, 32 new roads have begun, and 13 abandoned roads have also been captured. Those 13 abandoned roads are roads that were already there, with some contractors looking for payment of their Interim Payment Certificates (IPCs). The Adenta-Dodowa Road is captured. The Tapa-Mabang Road is captured. The Navongo-Chuchuliga Road is captured, among so many other roads. These are ongoing road projects. So, if we are mindful to speed up this rapid infrastructure project, we will not keep US\$288 million or some GH¢13 billion sitting down and say that we are waiting for new projects.

My point is that there are ongoing projects, therefore, it is important that we spend and pay them while the new ones also continue.

Again, Mr Speaker, when we talk about this utilisation, the Minister for Finance came and laid before us the amended Bill for the Petroleum Revenue Management Act (PRMA), and he amended section 21. He indicated that 21(3)(a), for any financial year, the Annual Budget Funding Amount shall be used for infrastructure development. So, if there are already projects that are ongoing and have been duly captured, which is very good, why do we keep the money? And that is our business, because we want to get some good books. Meanwhile, they projected GH¢17 billion for 2026, and in 2025, they talked about GH¢13 billion.

Mr Speaker, for 2026, the Minister is now talking about GH¢30 billion. Do the maths. A simple calculation of GH¢13 billion plus GH¢17 billion will amount to that GH¢30 billion. It is not as if we are creating additional money and telling the Ghanaians that we are giving them some GH¢30 billion. It is because we are not spending the GH¢13 billion, but adding on to it.

Mr Speaker, the Minister went ahead to indicate that these are priority projects. For me, when one says something is a priority, that is where one puts their money. So we cannot say something is a priority and not spend. That is not acceptable. The people of this country voted massively for them and wanted them to take action. We complain about

abandoned and delayed projects. If we are fine to spend, why do we do that?

Again, the Minister mentioned that this is the first time we are talking about an expressway. I was even tempted to believe so. But again, the devil is in the detail. Mr Speaker, let me take you to page 108, paragraph 610 of the 2025 Budget, where the Minister for Finance indicated that works on the dualisation of the Nsawam-Ofankor 16.7km Road achieved a fiscal progress of 68 per cent. It involved the widening of the road to 10 lanes with a 6-lane expressway.

My simple understanding is that, in the interest of managing our meagre finances, it is good to have an expressway. But if a certain 16.7km expressway had already begun by the previous government, I was thinking that this Government would realign and continue to do the expressway, rather than abandoning all this, while finding additional money to go and create another. Why are we doing this to Ghanaians? Why are we unduly placing stress on the finances that we do not have? Why do we play undue negative politics with programmes and projects that will benefit this country?

We keep talking about abandoning programmes and the wastage in the system. If a programme has begun, and they have a better programme, my understanding, and I plead to the Majority Side, to rethink this and realign so that we do not spend double the amount. Because the Minister indicated that they are going to continue what is happening, and indeed it is captured, but

they are going to start a new one. Why? Meanwhile, we have not been able to capture every other project.

Mr Speaker, please, this House and the overwhelming Majority should reconsider this and note that we need to put to judicious use the scarce resources that we have. We do not need to do this politics again. Ghanaians are tired of this kind of politics.

Again, if we look at this—and I am passionate about this because when we look at the various stages of implementation: Osino South-bound, 11km, 74 per cent; Osino North-bound, 11.5km, 70 per cent; Anyinam South-bound, 6.1km, 57 per cent; Anyinam North-bound, 93 per cent; the one the Minister indicated is completed, and Enyiresi South-bound, 60 per cent. The list goes on. The minimum we can find is 57 per cent. Why do they want to stop this from doing a new one? Please, on behalf of the people of Ghana, we are pleading.

At the workshop, I saw how passionate the Majority Leader was about resource utilisation, so I will plead with him to take a look at it. The expressway is good, but let us not abandon ongoing projects. Let us realign so that we can have judicious use of the scarce and scanty resources that we have.

Mr Speaker, on jobs and the 24-Hour Economy. This Government came to power and probably had the majority of numbers here because they promised the people of Ghana jobs. They promised the youth jobs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, hold it. Please stop the time for him. Yes, Hon Minister for Roads and Highways, why are you on your feet?

Mr Agbodza: I am pleading with my Colleague. I have already explained the bypasses on the Kumasi Road.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, is it about disagreement or?

Mr Agbodza: Yes, because it is a false narrative.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if it is a disagreement—

Mr Agbodza: No, it is not a disagreement.

Mr Speaker, I am the Minister for Roads and Highways. I have the record of what the technical people have provided as to why the road has been suspended. In fact, Colleagues asked me Questions—Unless we want to say that when Ministers are called here, the Answers they provide are debatable. Then, there is no need for any Minister to come and answer Questions here. When they actually put a project together at a cost of GHC1.9 billion, and within eight months, we needed another GHC3.4 billion to complete it, they should be worried that Ghanaians considered them a completely incompetent government. Because they did not do due diligence, and should be hiding under the table.

And even that, Mr Speaker, we have completed sections.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, take note and proceed.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Eastern and Western Corridor Roads were there, and they never touched them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, conclude.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, as a matter of fact, nobody has abandoned the bypasses on the Kumasi Road, and no amount of their shouting is going to make us stop something very vital for the economy of this country. [*Hear! Hear!*] They can shout; we will do it because it is very necessary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please continue.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, respectfully, if the Minister listened to me, I never said they had abandoned anything. If the Minister listened to me, I said that in their own Budget, the Minister alluded to the fact that construction had started on some 16.7km expressway. I did not write it. So if it is true, and I have quoted the pages and paragraphs, my passionate appeal as a young legislator, representing the good people of this country and the young people whose future will be determined by today's actions, is that we Ghanaians and the youth are tired of the politics, dissipation and misuse of our resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is the misuse of the resources that you are talking about?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, I believe that you will give me more time because the Minister has taken some of my original time.

For me, this country and all over the world, one of the challenges we have had as a Ghanaian community is that projects are started, not completed, and later abandoned by successive governments, who start a new one, which is not completed, and is also abandoned by another government, and the cycle goes on.

What I am saying is that if we are mindful that indeed we are here because of the people of Ghana, let us, for once—

3:36 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me recognise your Leader. Hon Leader, you Hon Member is speaking.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I think you were very clear in your directive that when a Member is on his feet speaking, one cannot speak across and shout at the other. I just want to plead with the Minister for Roads and Highways. We will not tolerate that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minority Leader, should I point to Hon Members at your back, particularly, even if their own Members are on the Floor? I want the entire House to take note of what the Hon Deputy Minority Leader is saying.

Yes, you have the floor.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, one of the core mandates of this House and as Members of Parliament and parliamentarians is to ensure the judicial utilisation of the scarce Ghanaian resources, and that is what we are pulling through.

Let us go to jobs. The 24-Hour Economy, and I take the NDC manifesto, page VII. This was a message from the flagbearer. I have typed some point. Mr Speaker with your permission, I quote, “We offer the Ghanaian people a well-curated blueprint to fix the economy and create prosperity. Implement a 24-Hour Economy for business development.”

Mr Speaker, move on to the message by the Chairman of the NDC, page XV and with your permission I quote:

“In this Manifesto, the National Democratic Congress has provided Ghanaians with clear, actionable, and concise solutions... Our policy on the 24-Hour Economy has been clearly stated in simple terms to enable everybody to understand...”

There is no ambiguity here.

Mr Speaker, in the Message on the State of the Nation, the President said the Ministry for Finance will bring a policy document. The Minister for Finance said he would later cause to be brought the policy document on the 24-Hour Economy. They made in simple terms, one job, three shifts. As we stand here, majority of the youth are waiting for the one job, three shifts, eight-hour shifts. We cannot find it.

In fact, this whole month is a celebration of festivals by the people of Okere, Dawu and Awukugua. When I went there, one of the things they asked me was, Hon Member, the 24-Hour Economy, *bɔnoɛ*? It means, where is the 24-Hour Economy? That is the Okere way of asking, where is the 24-Hour Economy? So, I am asking the Ministry for Finance, the people of Okere and Ghanaians are asking, 24-Hour Economy, *bɔnoɛ*?

Mr Speaker, *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* they are asking *nkere nia bɔnoɛ*? Mr Speaker, Youth in Agriculture, they are asking *agric a bɔnoɛ*? They are asking. We assured Ghanaians that we are going to give them kuroilers, broilers and all that. We paid all this and said that we were going to provide a lot of jobs for them, 2.4 million-day-old chicks. We are going to provide them chicken to produce one million kuroilers. As we speak, we are still on registration and we are a few months to Christmas. Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. It is now the turn of Mr Haruna Iddrisu. He is speaking for 15 minutes.

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, 2026, ably delivered by the Dr Ato Forson for and on behalf of H. E. President John Dramani Mahama on the theme: Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation. In contributing to this debate, I am reminded of my

grandmother's proverb to my friends opposite the aisle, that when you are pounding fufu for a blind person, the best way to assure the blind person you are not eating the fufu is to be whistling. I am sure they want us to whistle the achievements of President John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, 2025 was a correctional year for President Mahama and Dr Ato Forson. A correctional year because Nana Addo Dankwa and the NPP heavily damaged the Ghanaian economy, put Ghanaian businesses into distress, unemployment was high, inflation 54 per cent to 23 per cent, public debt rose up to GH¢726 billion, which was about 61 per cent of GDP, now down to GH¢630 billion. So, President Mahama and Dr Ato Forson have demonstrated that we are better managers of the economy.

The amount of money that this Side spent on servicing debt is less today and that assures the Gen Z's or young people of the future that they will not be overtaxed tomorrow in order to pay for some outstanding debt of an elephant-appetite borrowing government which went on a borrowing spree. Dr Ato Forson has also demonstrated Ghana has borrowed less in 2025 than any other period in the last 10 years. It means that we are making our debt sustainable. As he rightly announced, Ghana will exit the International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme in June. They were those who said they did not even believe in the IMF, yet they ended up with a calabash in hand to the IMF begging for them to come and discipline them in the management of the economy.

Mr Speaker, in contributing to this Budget, I would like to speak to just four themes. One on my sector, education. Mr Speaker, sufficient allocations have been made to the Ministry of Education to deal with education infrastructure expansion. In paragraph 462, an amount of GH¢33.3 billion allocated to the Ministry of Education for 2026, GH¢4.2 billion of it is to implement the Free Senior High School introduced by the previous Government, and to expand it. What they failed to do between 2018 and 2024 was expanding infrastructure to accommodate the increases in numbers in those Free Senior High Schools. H. E. President Mahama will fix that, and he will fix it with a conversion of at least 30 category C schools to category B, 10 category B schools to category A, and expand the infrastructure in a number of category A schools across the country. We will be guided by equity in the determination of those initiatives.

Mr Speaker, this year, GH¢537 million has been allocated for the No Fee Stress Policy. The most impactful initiative of President Mahama was reaching out to young people who otherwise could have not had the opportunity to take higher education because of poverty or the inability of their parents to do so. Even Members of Parliament must be those who should first commend the President because this GH¢537 million would have come back to Members of Parliament paying those fees on behalf of those first-year students who are unable to do it. President Mahama is absorbing it with GH¢537 million. A significant number of tertiary students benefited from it, including

persons with disabilities who, for the first time, have been given GH¢25 million for free tertiary education.

Mr Speaker, a while ago, a Colleague of mine debated on sanitary pads, but what he failed to appreciate is that there is evidence, even from the World Bank, on increased absenteeism. Girls without access to sanitary pads are more likely to miss school, leading to learning gaps and reduced classroom participation, lower academic performance of those girls, and reduced confidence; World Bank 2021. You may refer to SOMA 2015.

Mr Speaker, on this Floor, I heard many of them argue that why is the President allocating GH¢290 million for sanitary pads and GH¢100 million for jobs? If those young girls do not get educated, they would not even be qualified for those jobs we are talking about. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, this intervention is to assure them of consistency to remain in the classroom. A while ago, a Colleague of mine, arguing on sanitary pads, chose to do 'chop bar' arithmetic. He just took the number of 6.6 million packs first batch of sanitary pads supplied and came to the conclusion that Government was procuring sanitary pads at GH¢45. That is palpable falsehood. The total number of sanitary pads being procured by Government is 6.6 million at GH¢292 million. Not for him to just take 6.6 million and divide it by GH¢292 million and come to the conclusion that one of it is costing GH¢45.

3:46 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this year, under President Mahama's reset, we will expand access to higher education. The President has dedicated his award of Chinese support of US\$30 million for a Catholic Science and Technology University to begin in Damongo. A number of technical universities, one in Dambai and a science and technology university in Jasikan and Damongo will take off this year. Mr Speaker, the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) has an allocation of GH¢9.9 billion. Out of it, some GH¢360 million will go into the completion of the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology Teaching Hospital. This is so that the university will have a functional, operational hospital to support the teaching of medicine. That will be done in the course of this year.

Mr Speaker, they argued that they were superior managers of the economy. We were here when they came about debt exchange. President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo while speaking in Brussels was confronted with the reality when he said his darkest hour was subjecting this country to a debt exchange. The country is not out of the woods of his economic mismanagement that deteriorated even the performance of the cedi.

So, Mr Speaker, in respect of basic education, a number of junior high schools will be built across the country because there are many communities where about 15 to 20 communities cluster and have access only to one junior high school. The Minister for Finance

announced in this Budget that some work will begin on some 200 junior high schools across the country. [*Hear! Hear!*] Mr Speaker, some GH¢2 billion has been allocated for that, in addition to the 200 kindergartens and 400 4-unit teacher bungalows.

Mr Speaker, we are currently in discussion with the District Assembly Common Fund (DACF), the GETFund, and using the pension fund of Ghana Education Service Occupational Pension Scheme (GESOPs), to begin the construction of 50,000 housing units for teachers under President Mahama's "Teacher *Dabre*" initiative. Very soon, the President will cut sod for it.

Now, Mr Speaker, when they talk about jobs, whether it is a Big Push of infrastructure or roads, that creates jobs, whether the job is in a highway or in a road—Mr Speaker, I have heard my Colleague who just landed talk about a 24-Hour Economy. In the coming days, the Hon Majority Leader will lay the 24-Hour Economy Bill. It has since been gazetted and will come to this House. A revised Ghana Investment Promotion Centre (GIPC) Act, to make Ghana a friendly country for business, will also be laid before this House to give meaning to President Mahama's plan to make Ghana an investment destination.

Mr Speaker, permit me also to highlight on the NPP and free senior high school education, as I said. Currently, Government will spend GH¢4.2 billion on the feeding for free senior high school education. What President Mahama has done is to amend the GETFund Act. I am

sure the Chairman of the Finance Committee will do what is needful and appropriate. Under the amendment of the GETFund Act, there are three interventions of President Mahama. Firstly, we are guaranteeing dedicated funding for free Senior High School. Two, we are further guaranteeing dedicated funding for free tertiary education for all persons with disability. We are further guaranteeing free education for all learners with special needs, including the Akropong School of the Blind. That, when the amendment takes place, will give effect to that. Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, hold it. May you stop his time? Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, if we read Order 125 of our Standing Orders frowns against anticipation. For the avoidance of doubts, I will read the provision aloud *in extenso*. “A Member shall not anticipate any matter by the consideration of a Motion dealing with a subject matter which is likely to be introduced in a Meeting.”. Mr Speaker, the respected former Leader, in this submission, is talking about a supposed GETFund Amendment Bill which is yet to come. He is not to be introducing a matter that is not before us. He has also talked about a certain 24-Hour Economy Bill. These are all matters that our Rules frown against. Once the matter is not before this House, a person cannot be pre-empting it in their debate. Your duty is to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, can you look at page 7 of the Order Paper, item numbered 30?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, rightly so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: “Ghana Education Trust Fund Amendment Bill”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, it is not a subject matter on the Floor. The fact that they have advertised a matter—Mr Speaker, read it again. You said the GETFund Amendment Bill, page 7 of today's *Order Paper*. Page 7 is here, so which particular item are you referring to?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are talking about Ghana Education Trust Fund Amendment Bill not being before us.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you said I should look at page 7.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Item numbered 30, the *Order Paper Addendum*. Page 7.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, they have not brought the *Order Paper Addendum* to the Minority Frontbench. Mr Speaker, I have found it. Let us deal with it, but this Motion is not in consideration.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your argument is that the matter is yet to be introduced.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The mere advertisement of a Motion does not mean that the Motion is before the House, Mr Speaker, you know it. Let us not mislead the public. The matter is not before us. What is before us is the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill that they have abandoned and do not want to pursue. It is that Bill that they were so anxious about when they were in opposition; that they are not interested in.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, let us be fair to ourselves. This particular Bill that you are talking about has been introduced in this House. It is in the Budget and even on the *Order Paper* up to a Motion for a Third Reading. So, the fact that this particular matter is not before the House, I beg to differ. But I will give the floor to the Hon Minister if he has any response.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me conclude. The Standing Orders is very clear. I want the procedural experts to initiate a further debate on this matter because their silence is too loud—They are too quiet on this matter. The rule is clear; anticipation. What he is talking about is not before us. We should define what the term of art before Parliament is. It is not.

Mr Speaker, since they claim they are a super-Majority, the resetting includes resetting even our rules. If they want to reset the rules, *Hansard* would record them. So, they should do whatever they want to do or like, but we would refer them to this someday.

3:56 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, any Bill that is presented to the House and captured by the *Order Paper* is before the House. On what basis would it be captured by the *Order Paper* if it is not before the House?

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is obvious that the strategy of the Minority Leader is to distract the Minister for Education. I would not yield to his invitation involving vexatious and frivolous matters.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader knows very well that I am in my own right, a constitutional and procedural expert in this House. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, in his own words, he read the procedure. He said, “likely to be introduced”. I refer to paragraph 4 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, which states:

“Mr Speaker, I will also present the following Bills, Regulations and Memoranda for consideration:

- The Value for Money Bill;
- The Virtual Asset Service Providers Bill;

- The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Bill;
- The COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill;
- The Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) (Amendment) Bill...”

Emphasis is on the Ghana Education Trust Fund Amendment Bill. We are debating the policy principles of the Budget. This is the moment; it has been introduced already. Not likely to be introduced.

Mr Speaker, now, let me come to the very important subject my Colleagues have chosen to use to debate this Budget, which is about the President's efforts to retool and equip the Ghana Armed Forces. Mr Speaker, I want to remind them that in every country, the most significant role of the President is the security of the citizens. I also want to remind them that in 2023, under the auspices of the previous government, we met in Akosombo, and it was their desire that we help them retool the security agencies, including National Security, the Intelligence Agencies, the Ministry of the Interior, Defence, Communication, and Finance.

Mr Speaker, in that meeting, to retool and equip the Ghana Armed Forces and the security agencies, they projected spending US\$2.5 billion. That was a request they made to the Committee back in 2023 as a requirement to retool the Ghana Armed Forces. What President Mahama would do after equipping the Ghana Armed Forces would be same for

the other security agencies, including the Ministry of the Interior. The essence was to respond to Ghana's quest to contain terrorism, privacy threats, and the threat on the sovereignty of our country. It was revealed in that meeting that over US\$24 billion would be required, and that the funding requirement to finance the security was 0.4 per cent of GDP, a figure far below the estimated 2.2 per cent spent by neighbouring countries on average. So, I am surprised that today, they are making the Presidential Jet a flagship of their debates. They asked for the re-equipping and retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces. They did it in 2023 and in 2024. They only did not have the financial muscle to do it. They can raise questions of timing, but President Mahama cares about the security of the Ghanaian citizens and would continue to do more.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, part of this Budget; funding for all constitutional bodies have been maintained, and in some instances, increased so that these constitutional bodies can do their work. Mr Speaker, as the current Minister for Education, let me also use this opportunity to state that there is some ongoing debate on restrictions of some Muslim students in Wesley Girls Senior High Schools, which conflicts with international human rights standards, and even standards expected of us in Ghana's Constitution under article 33 (5) and 26 (1) of the 1992 Constitution. I want to assure our Colleagues that we have a duty to uphold the rights of every Ghanaian child and Ghanaian citizen. No right is divisible, and we would not countenance any action by any person to

deny any Ghanaian girl the opportunity to profess or practice any religion —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is now the turn of Mr Frank Yeboah. You are speaking for 15 minutes. You have the floor.

Mr Frank Yeboah (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government. Mr Speaker, sincerely, I see the theme, “Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation”, to be in contrast with the actual content of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Mr Speaker, why am I saying this? This Budget does not offer any hope for Ghanaians, especially the youth. It does not offer any bold transformational agenda or plan for the country. It only reads like a record of recycled promises.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson, reviewed all the promises that he made in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, recycled all the promises that were not fulfilled, and brought them back into the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Why am I saying this? The NDC in the 2024 electioneering campaign promised all women in this country the

establishment of Women's Development Bank. **[An Hon Member:** It is not in it].

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance subsequently allocated GHC51 million in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. The ladies were hopeful that at least they were going to benefit from the bank. After the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, nothing was heard about it, even though the Hon Minister for Finance, a chartered accountant, knew very well that the GHC51 million was woefully inadequate, there was no way they were going to establish a bank with GHC51 million. Mr Speaker, the same promise has been recycled and brought back into the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, permit me to take Hon Members to appendix 2(c) on page 157, where the budget reviews a very troubling issue. In the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Hon Minister for Finance allocated GHC4.5 billion to the Ghana GoldBod. As at the end of the third quarter, 30th September, 2025, nothing had been spent, and nothing had been released to the GoldBod. Yet, the Minister for Finance was bold enough to have projected to spend all the GHC4.5 billion till the year-end. How can this be? The question is that if the Government could not spend or release GHC1.00 within nine months, how can they spend all the GHC4.5 billion within three months? I only hope and pray that this release, if this sudden release indeed happens, would be used for genuine national programmes and activities that will inure to the benefit—

and would also not be used as Christmas expenditure for the Government Appointees and their cronies. That will also not permit other people to be involved in what my Colleague earlier described as “chop chop”.

4:06 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to tell this House that, Ghanaians are not ready to witness the second episode of “Create, Loot and Share” that we witnessed some years ago. I repeat, “Ghanaians are not ready to witness episode two of “Create, Loot and Share” that was witnessed some years ago. This is in the ruling of Justice Dotse and not from me, Mr Frank Yeboah of Atwima Nwabiagya North.

Mr Speaker, let me address the issue of Agenda 111, which the current Government has described as an overly ambitious health infrastructure project in the history of our country. Public records have it that, the cost of one unit of Agenda 111 will cost US\$17 million. This would bring a total cost of completion, if we are to complete all the Agenda 111 projects, to GH¢19.26 billion.

If you turn to paragraph 1060 in the 2026 Budget, the Minister for Finance allocated GH¢100 million for the completion of 10 of the Agenda 111 projects. We all know that one unit will cost in excess of GH¢170 million, yet the Minister for Finance has allocated only GH¢100 million and he is telling Ghanaians that they are going to use that amount to complete 10 units of the Agenda 111. I understand that we all

know how to calculate in mathematics, so I do not want to waste my time on that.

Mr Speaker, if I remember correctly the arithmetic I learnt at Prempeh College within the period of 1992 to 1993, if we divide GH¢19.26 billion by GH¢100 million that has been allocated by the Minister for Finance, we would get 193. This means that, if we are to go by the pace set by the NDC Government in completion of the Agenda 111 project, it means that the Agenda 111 project is going to be completed in the year 2219, which is 193 clear years. I do not even think any of us will be alive by then. Why is the NDC Government not prioritising the health sector of this country?

Mr Speaker, let me go on to the empty promises that the NDC made during the 2020 electioneering campaign. On paragraph 3, page 5, 2.5, the NDC manifesto promised to commence the establishment of clinics at market and *trotro* stations that would provide basic healthcare for market women, drivers, mates and the general public. Both the 2025 and 2026 Budgets were silent on this promise.

When I go to my Constituency in Atwima Nwabiagya North, specifically, the Asuofua market, Barekese market, Akropong market, Koforidua market, Mfensi market, the people are asking me to ask the NDC, where the clinics they promised them are? Was it *azaa* or not? Then I will tell them not to use the word *azaa* because it is unparliamentary, but that is what my constituents said.

Mr Speaker, let me move to another empty promise that the NDC made during the electioneering campaign. If we turn to paragraph 5 of the same page, page 5.2.5, the NDC promised that they were going to upgrade all the sick bays in our boarding schools. The students in boarding schools thought that the messiah has come. In both the 2025 and 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policies, nothing was said. The Minister for Finance was silent. Nothing was provided. There is no capital expenditure line provided for that.

When I go to Barekese Senior High School, Osei Tutu Senior High School and Spiritan Senior High and Technical School, within my Constituency, they are asking me to ask the NDC where the satellite clinics that they promised to be given to the senior high schools are.

Mr Speaker, I do not want to waste my time. Let me shift to mental health which remains neglected in the national Budget. We all know that we have only three main psychiatric hospitals in this country: Ankaful Psychiatric Hospital in the Central Region, Pantang Hospital and Accra Psychiatric Hospital in the Greater Accra Region. In the 2025 Budget allocation, the Minister or the Government did not make any capital expenditure allocation at all in an attempt to bring the three hospitals to international standards.

In the 2026 Budget, they attempted to do something. What did they do? If they can provide GH¢4.5 billion to the Ghana Gold Board, we thought that they were going to prioritise healthcare and add

more. They only added GH¢50 million for the three psychiatric hospitals. Is it fair? Please, if they are asleep, they should wake up.

Mr Speaker, let me talk to the ladies, my Sisters and Friends on the other Side—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are talking to the whole world—

Mr Yeboah: I thank you, Mr Speaker. But with this one, I want to make a particular reference to our ladies on this Side. We have doctors in there. Imagine you have a sister, daughter, or niece who has met a very handsome man like myself and they get married, the lady gets pregnant and after childbirth, she finds herself in a psychiatric hospital just because she has postpartum disorders. It can happen to anybody. The doctors are aware and know what I am saying is the truth. So, it is not only those who take hard drugs that will end up in a psychiatric hospital. That is why it is incumbent on all of us as Members of Parliament to ensure that the NDC Government prioritises the health sector of this country.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion—
[*Interruption*] I am concluding for them, so that they can have time to talk. They are my Colleagues, so I am concluding for them to also talk on the health sector.

Mr Speaker, I want to urge this House to demand from the Minister for Finance, a credible financing roadmap to be able to complete the Agenda 111 project. It is

because we used the nation's money to begin the process. We would not sit down and let the project go waste. It is the taxpayers' money and it should not go waste.

Secondly, we demand from the Minister for Finance to explain why GH¢4.5 billion was allocated to the Ghana Gold Board. Yet, as of the end of September, no releases were made to the Ghana Gold Board. Meanwhile, a doctor in Ankaful Psychiatric Hospital, Pantang Hospital and the Accra Psychiatric Hospital are waiting for disbursement of money to be able to take care of the patients there. The doctors would tell you that, having a serene environment is part of the healing process in our hospitals.

I urge this House to scrutinise the Budget critically before approval is given.

4:16 p.m.

We will one day regret approving this Budget Statement and Economic Policy which, to the best of our knowledge, has so many inaccuracies and discrepancies.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I wanted to pray you to indulge me to look at the *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, *Order Paper Addendum* at

commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Papers. Hon Members, items numbered 1(a), (b) and (e) are due for Presentation.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Sorry, Mr Speaker. Actually, we are looking at items 1(a), 1(b) and 1(e).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is exactly what I am talking about.

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee—

(a) Report of the Finance Committee on the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025.

(b) Report of the Finance Committee on the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025.

(c) Report of the Finance Committee on the Ghana Education Trust Fund (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the reports contained in items numbered 1(a), (b) and (e) on page 1 of the *Order Paper Addendum* are duly presented and they are for distribution to Hon Members. Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, thank you. I think we would back to the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are we not taking the item numbered 2 on the *Order Paper Addendum*?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Very well, Mr Speaker. I think we can take the item numbered 2.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister for Finance. Deputy Majority Leader, he is not the Minister, so please do the needful.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we want to seek your leave to permit the Deputy Minister for Finance to do this on behalf of the substantive Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Minister for Finance?

MOTION

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP) *on behalf of the Minister for Finance:* Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the Motion for the second reading of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Mr Speaker, I so move.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 2, Motion has been duly moved. Any seconder?

Chairman of the Finance Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved and seconded. It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, this is a procedural motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Yes, consequential Motion.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we will now take item numbered 3, the Motion. Again, we seek for the Deputy Minister to do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Minister for Finance?

BILL— SECOND READING

COVID 19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP) *on behalf of the Minister for Finance:* Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee, may you present the Report.

Chairman of the Finance Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion moved by the Deputy Minister and in so doing, I present your Committee's Report.

Introduction

The Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 was presented to Parliament by Hon Minister for Finance, Mr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, in accordance with Article 174 of the 1992 Constitution and read the first time on Thursday, 13th November, 2025. Subsequently, the Bill was referred to the Finance Committee for consideration and report in accordance with the Article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 226 of Parliament.

Deliberations

The Committee, in considering the Bill met with the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson; Hon Minister for Health, Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh; Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem; the Commissioner-General of the Ghana Revenue Authority, Mr Anthony Sarpong; officials from the Legislative Drafting Division of the Ministry of Justice and Attorney-General's Department; the technical team from the Ministry of Finance, Ministry of Health and Ghana Revenue Authority.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents in the consideration of the Bill:

- (a) The 1992 Constitution
- (b) The Standing Orders of Parliament
- (c) COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy Act, 2021 (Act 1068)

Rationale

The Government introduced the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy as part of fiscal measures to mobilise additional revenue to support the response of the country to the COVID-19 pandemic and to facilitate economic recovery in the aftermath of the crisis.

In the 2025 Budget Statement, the Government announced its commitment to streamlining the indirect tax regime and reducing the overall cost of doing business as part of broader efforts to stimulate growth, support private sector-led recovery and improve compliance in the Value Added Tax system. One of the key policy measures is the rationalisation of consumption taxes by consolidating multiple levies into a simplified Value Added Tax structure.

Object of the Bill

The object of the Bill is to repeal the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy Act, 2021 (Act 1068).

Content/Structure of the Bill

The Bill contains two clauses indicated as follows:

Clause 1 repeals the COVID-19 Recovery Act, 2021 (Act 1068).

Clause 2 saves a right, a liability or an obligation in existence immediately before the repeal of the enactments until the right, liability or obligation is exercised or terminated.

Observations and Recommendation

Rationale for the Repeal

The Committee observed that the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy has outlived its original purpose. The repeal is therefore a part of the comprehensive Value Added Tax reform agenda aimed at creating a more transparent, equitable and growth-friendly consumption tax system.

Fiscal Impact

The Committee noted that the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy Act, 2021 (Act 1068) imposed 1 per cent levy on the supply of goods and services made in the country, other than exempt goods or services and on the import of goods and services, other than exempt imports. The Levy was also applicable to the supply of goods, subject to the flat rate scheme of the Value Added Tax.

It is worthy of note that the Levy is not allowable as an input tax deduction, effectively increasing the cost of goods and services for final consumers.

Proposed Amendment

No amendments were proposed by the Committee during the consideration.

Conclusion

After careful consideration, the Committee is of the view that the Bill will remove cascading tax effects, reduce compliance burdens for taxpayers, improve the profitability of businesses and improve the efficiency of Value Added Tax administration.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its report and pass the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Committee met with the Deputy Minister for Finance representing the Ministry and his technical team to look at the Bill that was presented to us. We were informed that during the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy the Minister for Finance had announced that as part of the broader reforms to the value-added tax, he would come to this House to repeal the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy.

Mr Speaker, subsequently, the Ministry included that in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy and indicated that the repeal of this Recovery Levy would lead to a fiscal impact of about GHC3 billion. In other words, the people of Ghana would be given GHC3 billion that they would have paid as taxes.

Mr Speaker, we also observed that as a result of this Levy, the effective VAT rate had gone up because it being treated as a levy meant that when businessmen imposed this levy, they were unable to get the input VAT recovered. As a result,

they passed this on to the consumer, which increased the cost of doing business. As a matter of fact, the Committee was unanimous that this is something that has been long overdue, COVID-19 is long gone, and the reasons for imposing this, which was to raise additional resources to support government in its effort to fight COVID-19, had since been rendered useless. Therefore, there was no need for Government to continue to impose the COVID-19 levy on the people of Ghana. As a result, the Government appeared before us seeking to repeal and remove this COVID-19 Levy.

Mr Speaker, the Committee therefore recommends to this House to accept the Minister's request and approve the Committee's report accordingly.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, Motion moved and the Report accordingly presented. They are for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance?

Mr Ampem: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to support the Motion moved by the Chairman of the Finance Committee and to say briefly that this is in fulfilment of the promises that H.E. President Mahama made to Ghanaians when in opposition and also in Government. You would recall that when the Minister for Finance came here to present the first

Budget Statement and Economic Policy on behalf of the President, he reiterated the promise that we would take steps to rationalise the VAT system and, in the process, abolish the COVID-19 Levy. We have gone through a rigorous consultation process and we are here before this House—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minority Leader?

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyeyi): Thank you, Mr Speaker. It looks as if the agreement we had with the other Side has been breached. This is because we never agreed that the Motion—our understanding was the laying of the Paper for the meantime. We did not have an understanding that we should take the Motion. If you look on our Side, Members of the Finance Committee are not present. We would have prompted them if we had that agreement.

So, how can we just go ahead? I am not happy about what has happened. It looks like we are just being stampeded with this discussion and I need to show my objection to this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, yes.

4:26 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we agreed to take this Report. That is why the *Order Paper Addendum* was prepared. We gave adequate notice.

Mr Speaker, The *Order Paper Addendum* has been ready for over an

hour, just to give notice to our Friends on the other Side to marshal, especially the Members of the Finance Committee. The Reports are ready and some have been loaded onto the console; we are still making efforts to get the rest loaded onto the it. So, I want to plead with the Deputy Minority Leader, Ms Patricia Appiagyei. The Motion has been moved and seconded; the Report has been presented. So, I am sure there are a lot of capable men. Prof Nyarko is here; my Brother, Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah is also here. They are all capable of making—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Capable men and women.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Thank you, Mr Speaker, including the Hon Deputy Minority Leader herself— They are capable of making contributing meaningfully to the Report for its adoption.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I still stand by my word that we are being stampeded—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I am listening to you. If that is the situation, then what will happen is that we may end it at Second Reading, and not continue. Because we have started the process of the Second Reading already.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it is in our interest as Leadership, and you know, on any day, I will defer to you on such matters, but this is not how we should approach this Business. If you would recall, early in this morning, we were supposed to start with Questions, but we varied the order of Business to start with a debate. We were supposed to revert to Questions, but now, they are laying Papers out of the blue, nobody discusses with anybody. No, Leadership must engage. That is the practice of this House. I try to reach—Please, let me finish.

Mr Speaker, they must do the proper thing. They know the proper thing. The First Deputy Speaker is presiding and he has been sitting all day. You know what to do. They should do the right thing. But I would defer to you, Mr Speaker, because we have got to where we are now, we should just finish and then the rest, let us do the appropriate engagement before we can continue. The Hon Deputy Minister for Finance is supposed to know better.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, you have the floor.

Mr Ampem: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I was saying that bringing COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy to Parliament for it to be repealed is to fulfil a promise that H. E. President Mahama made to the good people of Ghana. This levy was introduced to help the Government respond to the

challenges of COVID. We believe that the levy has served its purpose, and it is time that we relieve Ghanaians of that burden. So, we are seeking to repeal it and to put back about GHC3 billion into the pockets of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, the effect of the 1 per cent COVID-19 Levy, and the cascading effect of the GETFund and NHIL, because these three were not allowed to be tax-deductible, so it had serious impact on businesses. So, in our attempt to restructure the VAT system, we are repealing it, and we believe that this will help ease the burden on taxpayers. Interestingly, this is one request that received overwhelming support from even Members of the Minority. So, we believe that we will all support this cause and give effect to the good intentions of H. E. President Mahama and his Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo?

Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment (Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Report of the Finance Committee on the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, we all know what taxes represent. They represent an interest in the citizens to contribute to the development of the nation. A collection of taxes drives the effort of the nation. It gives government the machinery to

move, and it provides all the things we need in the country.

Mr Speaker, I wish that we would, first of all, thank the people of Ghana, that at a critical moment during the COVID-19, they agreed to be taxed so we could solve the challenges and confront COVID-19 with all our might to make sure Ghanaians live through it. But I know that taxes are often obnoxious to many people because it takes away your private income into public use. Despite that, they agreed to do it. But the most annoying aspect of it was when COVID-19 ended, and everywhere you go, people were asking, why are you still taxing us for COVID-19? So, I want to also commend Government and H. E. John Dramani Mahama for allowing to make sure that we satisfy the general will of Ghanaians to remove this tax from the system. According to the Minister, it was to streamline the tax regime, to take off the burden on Ghanaians, and to be able to run the economy with people paying tax without getting angry over it.

So, Mr Speaker, this Report is a very important report because I believe it is going to receive an overwhelming support by both Sides, that we are willing and have taken this tax off and that taxes that are subsequent to it must have some meaning so they can develop the desire to be part of it.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the Committee for a diligent work done and thank the Minister for Finance and the President for bringing it to us and where we have reached now. I want to also thank the

Minority; after raising the issue, they agreed to go along with us so we can have a unanimous approach to it.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah?

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Mr Speaker, first and foremost, we would like to thank the Committee for bringing us this Report. In fact, for us on this Side, because we have also used it as a campaign promise that we were going to repeal it, we were expecting the NDC to have brought it last year, but it is better late than never, therefore, we would like to make it clear that we will support the repeal of this 1 per cent COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy.

Unfortunately, we were thinking that since we took this as a levy, maybe the Ghanaian businessman should have been given a better benefit of this tax than what it is today. In fact, if we had made it complete 20 per cent VAT, Ghanaian taxpayers and businessmen would have got a better input value than what we are currently doing. So, if at least they come to the first stage, we agree, maybe next time we will get the opportunity to do a second stage. So, instead of separating the taxes, we would make it a bulk so a Ghanaian taxpayer can get more than what they are getting from just the repeal of the 1 per cent.

With this, I want to support the Motion for the removal of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy. After all, time has passed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leadership?

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, ordinarily, repealing a tax law should not generate any debate. But where the Government itself is not being consistent, same ought to be pointed out. The impression this Bill seeks to create is that Government is a listening one and wants to lessen the tax burden on the ordinary Ghanaian. The reality is that, that is not the case.

4:36 p.m.

Mr Speaker, just last week, the Government came to this House with a 20 per cent tax exemption, amounting to US\$10.4 million, granted to one entity, a foreign company. The argument was that the previous government had a certain agreement, which they were only following through on. But they said they are resetting, so if indeed there was anything bad, they should cancel it. They should not come here and claim that they are trying to do it better. Do what better? If the agreement with the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA) was bad, I dare them to cancel it. They should not come to this House and further grant US\$10 million to that company if they say it is bad.

Two, Mr Speaker, this year alone, the ordinary Ghanaian who uses electricity has been burdened with a total of 18.4 per cent on electricity tariffs alone. This is the total tariffs they have imposed on the ordinary Ghanaian. So, they should not turn around and create the impression

that this is the COVID-19 levy that the ordinary businessman was paying, so they are taking it away as if they care. They do not.

Mr Speaker, whereas in 2018, the Akufo-Addo Government, through the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC), announced a total tax tariff adjustment. In this case, it was a reduced tariff adjustment, ranging from 18 to 30 per cent. Households enjoyed 18 per cent, and Corporations enjoyed up to 30 per cent. This was the status quo. When they came into office this year, they increased electricity tariffs by 18.4 per cent. If they care about the ordinary Ghanaian, why did they impose the tariffs?

Three, they have imposed a GHC1 levy on petroleum products at the pump. For any litre purchased, an additional GHC1 is paid. Mr Speaker, if we calculate it, it is far in excess of the amount they claim they are giving by way of repealing this law. Mr Speaker, a government must be principled and consistent. They impose an 18 per cent tariff, and grant US\$10.4 million in tax exemptions, forgetting that when they were in opposition, they stood against tax exemptions for Ghanaian businessmen who were coming into the country, and were investing under One District One Factory (1D1F). They were opposed to it. They said they were against the tax breaks.

Today, they are imposing GHC1 per litre on the diesel or petrol I buy. Everybody, the *Okada* rider who buys

one litre is paying GHC1. Then they turn around to say that they are repealing. Mr Speaker, if the Government is minded to indeed relieve the ordinary Ghanaian of their everyday hassle, it should demonstrate that by immediately repealing the levy on diesel and petrol. Then we will take them seriously.

Mr Speaker, they should immediately reverse the 18 per cent tariffs that they have imposed on electricity. Then Ghanaians will take them seriously. They should not come here and say we should praise them because they are repealing the COVID-19 levy. No, I do not take such a posture seriously.

Mr Speaker, we have witnessed a situation where this Government promised that the importers were going to have relief; they were going to take away taxes on the importation of spare parts. What have they done about it? In their 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they said nothing about it. The Abossey Okai spare part dealers have been disappointed by them. They disappointed them; they know it. If they are really interested in taking away taxes, there are huge taxes that they imposed when they were first in office far back as 2016, that should be dealt with.

They should not get up and introduce these small things. They are interested in Public Relations (PR) and the optics. The Hon Deputy Minister for Finance should take this governance seriously. It is their time to rule, but they should leave a record, a record anchored on principle and consistency, not convenience. If my

mother in Winneba has to pay 18 per cent more on electricity, and my dad in Tsiamie has to pay 18 per cent more on electricity. That is real impact. The ordinary folks at Ashaiman, Chorkor, Nima, those at Labadi, and the poor people in the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance's Constituency are paying 18 per cent more on electricity. Because when they came into office, that is what they chose to do.

They are telling the *Okada* rider to pay GH¢1 on each litre of petrol he buys. That is what they are doing. Then they turn around to say they are repealing what? Why did they impose that Energy Recovery Levy, which was not in place when Akufo-Addo was in office? Whereas their predecessor reduced electricity tariffs, they are increasing electricity tariffs under their so-called reset. And they want us to praise them when they have even forgotten about their own promise of one job, three shifts.

Mr Speaker, we are not against this in principle, but for their inconsistency and lack of principle, we want Ghanaians to know that they deserve better and should not fall for this mischief. The ordinary Ghanaian must know that he or she has been overburdened with more taxes than it was previously. People cannot afford electricity. People cannot afford petrol and diesel because they are making life difficult. [**Some Hon Members:** Ei!] Yes, that is true. Because they can afford it, they think that the *okada* rider is not burdened. If the *okada* rider buys 10 litres—[*Uproar*] Well, they need the Bill, they should keep shouting.

Now, the *okada* rider in their own constituency buys 10 litres of petrol a day, they take GH¢10 from that *okada* rider.

4:46 p.m.

Previously, that was not the case. Now, if one goes and buy electricity, they are imposing 18 per cent more on it. That is the reality. If it is their style to act without principle and without consistency, the world is watching, the Ghanaian people are watching, and their mischief is hereby exposed. I rest my case, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me draw your attention to Standing Order 167, which governs the debate at Second Reading. At the Second Reading, it is the principle, the rationale, the brain behind, the mischief that the Bill is seeking to cure that is debated. Hon Members, the Bill under consideration is COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Act 2025.

Yes, Mr Adongo? I thought you presented the Report?

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, this is a House of records. We will not leave this Chamber before we see all that is happening in the House on TikTok. All that is happening here is not about rules. It is about what they will say on TikTok. There are a lot of misleading information, in fact, lies, that have been peddled here. It is not true that former President Akufo-Addo did not increase electricity tariffs. He was imposing increases in electricity tariffs every

quarter under the pretext of the IMF programme. We paid close to over 100 per cent tariff increase in one year under the IMF programme. So, to be complaining about 18 per cent now when the same people sat here and told Ghanaians to pay more than they were imposing, they cannot turn around to be saying the things they are saying.

The truth is that we inherited an IMF programme. In that IMF programme, they had gone to sign an agreement with Tata Consultancy Service Ltd, and that agreement became a benchmark for the people of Ghana to meet. Now we have inherited an IMF programme where they had already gone to take close to US\$2 billion. If we cancel the agreement, where are we getting the US\$2 billion to go and give to IMF? We needed to make do with it. They signed an agreement to impose that US\$10 billion on the people of Ghana. The Minister for Finance renegotiated that agreement from US\$54 million to US\$44 million. You should be clapping for him. The same people who imposed this on Ghana, having taken US\$2 billion on account of a benchmark which had become a prior action are now saying that we should have cancelled it so that the IMF will come looking for their money and now they will be hiding and laughing at us. We will not fall for that.

Mr Speaker, the people of Ghana know how much they were buying fuel before the NDC came and how much they are buying fuel today. They know the people who love them. The people who make them capable of buying fuel at a cheaper price are the people they love,

not those who have now found love for the people of Ghana. Mr Speaker, the truth is that this agreement that they imposed on us, we are now better off by US\$10 million. We are now better off than they gave us.

But what is even worse is that when they went through a competitive tendering, just two months before they left office, they cancelled the tender and went for sole-sourcing. They went for sole-sourcing and picked Tata Consultancy Service Ltd. We did not pick Tata Consultancy Service Ltd. They did not pick Tata Consultancy Service Ltd by competitive tendering. You went and sole-sourced them. Just a month or three weeks before they left office, they amended the agreement and now slotted into that agreement the US\$10 million we were to pay. How can they sign an agreement without tax exemption, and three weeks before they leave office, they now re-sign that agreement, amend it and add tax exemption?

Now they tell us we should cancel it, so that we go to arbitration and the people of Ghana will be slapped with damages and charges. We will not do that. Rather, we would go and renegotiate it and save the people. The truth is that they were collecting COVID-19 taxes when COVID-19 had gone. We were the only country imposing COVID-19 taxes on the people of Ghana. They were collecting US\$3 billion a year from COVID-19 for four years without COVID 19. They were the people collecting e-Levy and told us that e-Levy was like *Ako Balm; wode tare wo nan a na ekɔ*. It was curing all diseases, including roads. They were

here. It was as if they were actually blackmailing us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the meaning of that?

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, the people of Ghana know that it is an all-curing medicine. If you have a swollen leg and you touch it, it will go. If you want roads to be constructed, please give us e-Levy. If you say your tooth is aching, they say e-Levy. If you say you cannot pay the children's school fees, they say e-Levy. Fortunately, we found out that e-Levy did not cure any disease. When we sacked e-Levy, we rather brought interest rates down. When we sacked e-Levy, we rather brought inflation down, and when we sacked e-Levy, Ghana became stronger. [*Hear! Hear!*]

We are not only repealing the COVID-19 recovery; we have repealed e-Levy that has put GH¢ 6 billion in the pocket of Ghanaians. That is what governance is about. This is a Government that truly keeps its promise. We promise we will repeal e-Levy; we have done it. We promise COVID-19 recovery levy would be gone, it is going. Some people are praying that when we wake up next year, we will now begin to live the way they lived. That dishonest governance that we experienced will never come back. The essence of this conversation is that we want to repeal the COVID-19 Recovery Levy and save the people GH¢3 billion a year that they have since been paying for four years without COVID-19. I so submit. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, thank you, and let me commend my Colleagues for their silence in listening to Mr Adongo's submission. I am up because my Colleague opposite me, who moved the Motion, had an opportunity, and he argued that I lied. My job is to present the facts as they are. Firstly, his argument that the Akufo-Addo's administration increased electricity tariff every quarter is untrue.

[*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, do you see their intolerance? The cameramen will capture their behaviour. I kept quiet to listen to them. That is how a gentleman conducts himself. They have to listen. It is never true. The argument that electricity tariffs increase by 100 per cent is never true. It is a fact; go and check the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC) website. In 2018, major tariff reduction was announced. It is there. It ranged from 18 to 30 per cent.

Secondly, it is a fact that since they assumed office, they have increased electricity tariffs by 18 per cent. It is also a fact that since they came into office, every litre of petrol and diesel that is bought at the pump attracts GH¢1.00 per litre. I am saying that they are inconsistent. They are a government of convenience; they lack principles and it is backed by facts. What they are here doing —have they been bold to tell Ghanaians how much they are getting from the Energy Recovery Levy?

4:56 p.m.

Mr Speaker, have they told Ghanaians how much the 18 per cent tariff adjustment is bringing to Government? I am basically telling them that this thing that they are bringing here adds up to nothing; that is the point I want to make. So, they should not come on their feet in an attempt to defend Government, and put their own reputation on the line. For Mr Adongo to argue that every quarter, Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC) announced electricity tariff is not backed by fact; this is the House of Parliament.

Now regarding the Tata Agreement, his claim is very unsubstantiated. Mr Speaker, I have the report with me. In the report, they did not even refer to the Tata Agreement. He should check his own report that he presented; I have it with me. Mr Speaker, let the record have it that it is never true that any negotiation led to some gains. If indeed, they made some gains, why come and take US\$10.4 million? If they negotiate for US\$8 million, then we give US\$10.4 million to the company, what are we gaining? If they claim that the agreement was bad, I am telling them to cancel it. Now they said that it is against IMF conditionality and they want to play mischief with it.

They said it was bad and that they are against tax exemptions to companies. If they claim there was a tax exemption clause that was bad, why come and impose it? It is hanging on their necks and that is why I am telling them that they are being inconsistent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, we had a good debate on the Tata Agreement and have concluded same. So, if we can humbly—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, please bear with me. I always try to hold myself because it is my duty to honour your Chair. Mr Speaker, please you have always been clear on the rules—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But personally—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me finish—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You hold it. Instead of debating the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, Hon Minority Leader, you introduced the Tata Agreement. You went beyond the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy, contrary to Standing Order 167, and introduced all these matters.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you know, when the other Side, where you belong, comes in to intervene, how you treat them—When Hon Adongo got up, you first said, “oh, Honourable, you moved the Motion”. Under normal circumstances, all of us know, and it is trite, that the Hon Member who moved the Motion cannot come in to do what he did, but you allowed it and I kept quiet. Throughout his submissions, the entire House was quiet. You allowed him to flow and he finished. Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 accordingly read a Second time.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, your job is to protect the Minority, and so far, you have been doing that. Mr Speaker, this Majority must be careful of their conduct this afternoon. *[Uproar]* They are sitting here with—I have counted them and they are 72. **[Some Hon Members:** Eii!] So, if we are not pursuing certain matters—They should stop shouting. Mr Speaker, it is a serious matter. We decide to cooperate with them; they have 72. If they have 72 Members, they should back it with your good conduct. If they want to be rowdy with their 72, they will be compelled to bring their so-called 189. If they would be rowdy and disrespect us, they would have to bring their 189. No, they are 72; we are working together, so let us work together. They are not even up to 73, and we can count now. So, if they will be here shouting, and the Backbench wants to be heard and seen, then we will be compelled to get their numbers in. So, they are forewarned.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, as long as I am concerned, we have taken a decision on the Second Reading of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025. I would therefore ask for any indication but not to open the floor for same to be debated. Yes, Majority Chief Whip.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I will not challenge you at all. Save that, the phrase, “the so-called 189” is unparliamentary. We are 189 for the records. It is not the “so-called”. It is for the records.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is fair. Their 189 is their *bonafide*; I agree. It is not so-called. Hon Etse is my Brother, so it is 189 *bonafide*. It is all right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader, are we through to continue with the Motion numbered 4?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: No, Mr Speaker, we will revert to the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Joseph Appiah Boateng. You have 15 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government’s Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from column 15]

Mr Joseph Appiah Boateng (NDC — Afram Plains South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government of Ghana for the 2026 financial year, Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we have some order and listen to the Member in silence?

Mr J. A. Boateng: Presented to Parliament by Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, Minister for Finance, on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, on the authority of H.E. John Dramani

Mahama, President of Republic of Ghana. Mr Speaker, a lot has been said in the Chamber. Our Friends on the other Side said that the Budget Statement is empty, but it is better than the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

They are known for slogans and theory, but not practicality. Mr Speaker, we were all in this Chamber when the former Minister for Education sold a photocopied sheet at GH¢60. They saw nothing wrong with that.

This Budget is a budget of hope. It will give us good roads, good schools, potable water, electricity and good food. This is because, during their administration, we hardly had two square meals per day. Sometimes we had to go zero-one-zero, that is an empty stomach in the morning, then in the afternoon we have a meal, then in the evening we have zero.

[Hear! Hear!]

5:06 p.m.

But now, the nation builder is back. He is not back for nothing; he is back to put his hands in the archives to bring out the memorabilia he left behind. *[Hear! Hear!]*—He is here to help the good people of our constituencies enjoy the Feed Ghana Programme.

They brought something called Planting for Food and Jobs, and the same year they brought Planting for Food and Jobs, kenkey was GH¢1.00, but before they left government, it was GH¢7.00. At the time they assumed office in 2017,

fertiliser was free, but before they left, fertiliser was GH¢450.00, before they left power, they left us with so many taxes, such as the Emission Tax, Betting Tax, *et cetera*. But we are lucky to have the nation builder back on track, and Ghana would not remain like this. Ghana would grow from generation to generation under H. E. John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I want them to join hands with us; those who have intentionally blocked their ears with wax, we are coming back to remove that wax from their ears, so that they can listen to what is going on. Those who think that they have selective hearing, we are here to give them a hearing aid. Those who think that politically they are blind, we are sending them to optometrists. Those who think that this Budget is not a good budget, we are telling them that there is no way they can compare apples with tomatoes. There is no way they can compare Akufo-Addo's administration with Mahama's administration. It is completely unmatched.

They often say that Guinea fowls have flown to Burkina Faso, but when 250 excavators flew, they did not say or see anything wrong with that. We are building a nation, so those who think they are nation wreckers under Mahama's watch are going to have a sound mind.

Mr Speaker, I was happy when the Minister for Finance said they are going to construct the Adawso to Ekye-Amanfrom bridge; connect Kwampong

Nkwanta to Dome; connect Samanhyia to Bonaso; connect Samanhyia to Chemfre; and connect Forifori to Tela Kope. We are all excited because we know Mahama can do it, and he has done it before. All the projects in Afram Plains, be it electricity, e-blocks, schools, and hospitals, were constructed under NDC. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, during the eight years of the NPP's administration, they cannot even point a finger at one borehole, not a single borehole in Afram Plains. But the nation builder is back. He is back to build the Afram Plains Bridge. He is back to build our roads for us. So, those who disagree with this Budget, the good people of your constituencies are watching. If they block this Budget, they are blocking their roads, schools, health centres, food and Nkokɔ Nketenkete which would give everyone GH¢7,500.00 in six months. [*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, once upon a time, the NPP Government used the Afram Plains Bridge to seek a loan worth €350 million. When the loan came, they diverted it for something else. But now, we have a God-fearing President; we have a President who is not a tyrant. We have a President who thinks of his people. We have a President who has Ghana at heart. He is going to build our bridges and our roads for us. The NPP has been in government for eight years; they did not send one person abroad. Mr Speaker, I refer them to page 139, paragraph 780 of their 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, where they drafted bilateral agreements with more than six countries, such as Saudi Arabia, Mauritius, Egypt *et cetera*

but they could not send one person out. Now, under the NDC regime, we have been able to send over 1,190 people outside of Ghana. This is a government that thinks of its people. The NDC regime has been able to train farmers. That is a co-operative society. We have been able to train over 13,441 farmers. So, a government that thinks of its people always thinks of getting food for them. That is agriculture. Any government that does not believe in science, its people go hungry. That is why we were starving, and the former President's bodyguard was hungry, so he fainted in this Chamber.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Joseph Appiah Boateng, please withdraw that.

Mr J. A. Boateng: Mr Speaker, I withdraw. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You can continue.

Mr J. A. Boateng: Mr Speaker, under Mahama's administration, I would refer you to page 80, paragraph 571 in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it states:

“The Department of Co-operatives registered 1,190 new co-operatives, trained 13,144 farmers, and provided entrepreneurship training for 738 members...”

But what did they do? They did not train anyone at all. So, there is no way you can compare NDC with NPP. Not at all.

Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, page 64, paragraph 431 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, states:

“Mr Speaker, aligned to the 24-Hour Economy, we launched the Feed Ghana Programme in April 2025 to scale crop, tree crop, livestock and poultry, and agri-infrastructure. So far, 2,000 mt of hybrid maize seed, 1,000 mt of rice seed, and 50,000 mt of fertiliser have been distributed nationwide...”

5:16 p.m.

In 2026, we aim to deliver 4,388 metric tonnes, which stands for over 200 per cent. For the year 2026, when it comes to rice seeds, we are delivering 31,000 metric tonnes which stands over 300 per cent—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Sorghum, 240 tonnes, and fertiliser, instead of 50,000, it is going for 272,000 metric tonnes of fertiliser which stands over 544 per cent. *[Hear! Hear!]*

So, this is a government that thinks of its people, feeds its people, and has its people at heart, not a tyrant government that is always trying to suppress their people, wants chiefs and elders to bow and greet them. **[Some Hon Members:** Not quoting of Bible verses and wearing of white dresses] That is not leadership. Leadership is one which carries its people along.

Under their planting for food and jobs, they said they were going to make poultry abundant, but there was no poultry. They had to import poultry, and

it was so expensive because the dollar was so high; it was over GH¢17 to a dollar. When they came to power, they were “running their mouth”. They think governance is about “running their mouth”. They said Ghana is sitting on money, and that money was not the problem, but because of the bad governance of Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, they saw the dollar rise from GH¢4 to GH¢17 to a dollar. A ball of kenkey was GH¢1 but it went to GH¢7 before they left office. Again, an egg was 50 pesewas, but before they left office, it was GH¢3. So why do they call someone incompetent? They claim they were so competent, but look at where they ended us. It got to a point where we were stuck between the rock and a hard place. We could not do anything in this country.

Now President Mahama is back to save Ghana. President Mahama is back to better the lives of the good people of your constituencies. I am not surprised when they sang “Mahama is the hope”, and he continues to be hope.

Mr Speaker, I will end by saying Mahama is the hope for our teeming youth. Mahama is the hope for agriculture industry. Mahama is the hope for Mother Ghana.

On this note, Mr Speaker, I thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

[Members from the Majority sang.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, will you stop that? It is now

the turn of Hon Michael Kwasi Aidoo. Hon Member, you have 15 minutes.

Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (NPP — Oforikrom): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me this opportunity. For the past couple of days, I have listened to submissions from our Colleagues on the opposite Side. What is striking is that when we look carefully at the Budget, it does not have a clear vision and a strategic plan that benefits the ordinary Ghanaian. In fact, the Budget is just pieces of paper. The real intention and policies that can develop this country cannot be found in this Budget. In fact, the Minister for Finance came to present a budget that exhibits the feature of a manifesto.

The Budget is just like promises in a manifesto. Why do I say so? The recent manifesto by the NDC Government in the 2024 general elections was the contract document between the people of Ghana and the Government, anybody would have expected that this Budget would reflect at least some of the promises in the manifesto. But then, there is nothing like that. When we look in the Budget, it just exhibits promises that will not see reality.

Mr Speaker, let us go to the sports sector. In the 2025 Budget, on page 109, paragraph 664, the Government promised that it was going to undertake rehabilitation of the following stadia: the Baba Yara Sports Stadium Phase II, the Accra Sports Stadium, the Essipong Sports Stadium Phase I and II, and to complete the Abiriw Sports Stadium Phase II. So, the question we ask the

Government is how much was given to the Minister for Youth and Sports in 2025 and how much was received. We all know this is something that we do not need to ask, because the slogan now when we go outside is that, “*Ato ntua*” so we know that the Ministry did not receive any amount for these purposes.

I can say on authority that the rehabilitation did not commence. If they did not start the rehabilitation promised in 2025, how are they going to start three new stadia? How do they expect us to believe them when they say that they were going to construct three new stadia in selected regions, as indicated on page 81, paragraph 581, of the 2026 Budget? Meanwhile, on 20th September, when the Asante Kotoko and Bibiani Goal Stars Football Club visited the Jubilee House, the President, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, promised that seven new stadia were going to be built in 2026. They promised seven new stadia in the Jubilee House, and then the Minister for Finance comes to Parliament and presents a Budget which indicates just three new stadia. Can we trust the President? [**An Hon Member:** Inconsistency] We cannot trust the President.

Mr Speaker, the Government also promised that they were going to give jobs to Ghanaians. And when we look inside their Resetting Manifesto, under the 24-Hour Economy, Mr Speaker, if I may read on page 22 in their manifesto, they said:

“The 24-Hour Economy is a deliberate policy intervention by the incoming NDC administration to

stimulate economic growth by creating an enabling environment for businesses and public institutions to operate 24/7, in three shifts...”

They did not say two but rather, three shifts in eight hours and inside this manifesto, they indicated that Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA) and Ghana Ports and Harbours Authority (GPHA) are some of the agencies that were going to run the three shifts. I dare ask, are we running three shifts in these agencies? Have we been able to employ the youth who were promised these employments? **[Some Hon Members: No!]**

Mr Speaker, under youth development, the question we want to ask the Minister for Finance and the Government is, where are the regional digital centres that were promised? Where is the US\$50 million Fintech Growth Fund and the zonal ICT paths that were promised in their manifesto? Where is the National Employment Trust that was promised? I do not even want to dwell so much on their 24-Hour Economy, because Mr Goosie Tanoh had indicated that they will need US\$4 billion to implement the 24-Hour Economy. When we look in the Budget, it is a paltry GHC90 million, which I can say that it is not for anything. It is just “chop-chop”. It will not do anything, because as it stands, there is no implementation plan for the 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, I leave the Minister for Finance with these few words from the

good book, the Holy Bible. In Proverbs 25:14, I quote: “Like clouds and wind without rain is one who boasts of gifts never given”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, are you quoting from the Revised Standard Version, the new edition or which one?

5:26 p.m.

Mr Aidoo: Mr Speaker, if you have a Bible, you can check. Proverbs 19:2: “Desire without knowledge is not good, and whoever makes haste with his feet misses his way”. Promising new three stadia before completing the existing renovation in haste is not sound planning.

Mr Speaker, in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, under the energy sector, the Government mentioned that they have been able to increase revenue of the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) and so on. Where did that increment come from? The increment came from the taxes that they have imposed on Ghanaians and the tariffs that they have increased. Today, they have increased tariffs by 18.4 per cent. They have added a GHC1 levy on every litre of fuel we buy.

Mr Speaker, when we go to ECG, they tell us that the previous government purchased one million smart meters, and that has increased their revenue. And because of that, next year, they are also going to procure three million smart meters. Somebody had wisdom, plan, and vision to implement smart meters,

which increased the revenue of ECG. *[Hear! Hear!]* Apart from that, ECG indicated that the technology Hubtel is using has supported their revenue increment. The controversial Hubtel, which people indicated belonged to some people in this country.

Mr Speaker, to dwell on the issue of power, the Minister for Finance indicated in this Budget that new power plants from Aksa Energy and CENIT Energy are coming on board. We should give applause to the past government. They implemented these things so that by 2025, 350 and 300 megawatts from CENIT Energy and Aksa Energy will come on stream to support our energy needs. Apart from that, the previous government invested in a lot of projects in the energy sector, including substations and so on. That is what is stabilising our power today.

Mr Speaker, today we have given the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, and the Government enough money because they are taking GH¢1 from our pocket to pay for fuel and legacy debts. Killer debts that they created from the monster take-or-pay contracts that they signed. And today, they turn around and tell us that we left debt. During the Akufo-Addo Government, the former President spent almost GH¢1 billion every year to pay for these debts. They should not sit back and clap as if they have done something when Ghanaians offer them GH¢1 to be able to pay the debts. They have not done anything special.

Mr Speaker, let me go to the tourism sector. It is good that I see my Brother, Mr Kwame Asare-Obeng in the House. I was looking around to see if I would see Hon John Dumelo also in the House. Quite interestingly, one of the key programmes that the previous government instituted was the Year of Return and Beyond the Return. These programmes redefined the arts and culture, the tourism of this country. *[Hear! Hear!]* These programmes brought a lot of tourists into this country, supporting the creatives in that regard. Mr Speaker, because of political expediency, this Government came and said they were introducing something called the Black Star Experience. Has Mr Kwame Asare-Obeng experienced the Black Star Experience? It is a question I want to ask my Brother.

Mr Speaker, in their manifesto, on page 51, they indicated that the NDC Government will create and promote the Black Star Experience as Ghana's flagship culture, arts and tourism brand to redefine and affirm our Ghanaian identity, attract investment, and create new jobs. Where is the Black Star Experience? We are in November. We are getting to December, and nothing can be shown. I am not surprised because even the budget allocated to the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts is not enough. How can they allocate GH¢250 million to the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts and allocate GH¢292 million to purchase sanitary pads? That is revealing. It tells us how they take the creatives in this country.

Mr Speaker, as I am rounding up, I would like to say that this Government, at one time, killed the creative industry with *dumsor*. Nana Akufo-Addo came, revived the creatives with pragmatic programmes like the Year of Return and Beyond the Return. December in Ghana was the brand to beat, to the extent that other countries in Africa are even trying to emulate it. But today, we are going into December, we cannot see anything from the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that has been read because the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts is not being supported, the creatives are not being supported, and I can say on authority that December is not going to be a December to remember again.

Mr Speaker, on that note, I would like to end with Proverbs 6:6. This is a very common verse. It says:

“O sluggard, consider her ways and be wise. She gathers her bread in summer and prepares her food in harvest”.

This quote from the Bible refers to the ants. They cannot spend all their money on sanitary pads and leave a key Ministry like Tourism, Culture, and Creative Arts hanging. How do they take the creatives? I know the creatives supported this Government in the 2024 election. We know what the creatives did for them. This is a sign of disrespect to all creatives in this country.

I end here, Mr Speaker. Thank you very much. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we want to go back to the item numbered 4 on the *Order Paper Addendum*. Again, I would ask for the Deputy Minister—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, the item numbered 4.

Yes, Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I think the intention of the Leader is for us to finish with the COVID 19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025, then we can consider the next Business. So, we have no objection.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, the item numbered 4.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 169(1)

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 169(1) of the Standing Orders, which requires that when a bill has been read a second time, the Bill shall pass through a consideration stage which shall not be taken until at least two sitting days have elapsed, the consideration stage of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 may be *taken* today.

Mr Isaac Adongo: Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

5:36 p.m.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025

Clauses 1 and 2 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long title ordered to stand part of the Bill

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member that bring us to the end of the Consideration Stage.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 172(1)

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 172(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the third reading thereof shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has elapsed, the motion for the third reading of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

BILL — THIRD READING

Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 be now read the Third time.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Covid-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025 — *read the Third time and passed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, may we now look at item numbered 8 on page 3 of the *Order Paper Addendum*?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I had earlier called for an engagement with the Mr Nyarko Ampem. We have engaged accordingly. There is no argument. We will do the Business as was laid. But, Mr Speaker, we have we

have about eight of our Members who have to contribute to the to the debate. Let me humbly suggest to the Leader that we try to navigate effectively so that at the end of the day those we have scheduled to contribute will not suffer. We will make sure the Business as was agreed is also done. I will support you to do it. Let us go back to the contribution to the statement, we take a few and then we will come back and take item 8. We will do it. You have laid it, I know, but we have eight people waiting. Otherwise, we will drag into the night. We want to finish early. Let a few contribute—maybe two or three. We will come back. It is a straight forward matter. I am not objecting.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, fair enough. We will do two on each side, and then we will come back to the to the Bill. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Member, it is now the turn of Dr Mark Kurt Nawaane. You have the floor. You are speaking for 15 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from column 152]

Dr Mark Kurt Nawaane (NDC — Nabdam): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the financial year 2026. I want to thank President Mahama and his Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson for presenting a

healthy Budget. This Budget is so good that when a person reads it, that person does not get headache. When one reads it, one does not get hypertension. When one reads it, one does not get stressed. When one looks through it very well, one does not get any anxiety and one does not get depression when one analyses the Budget. It is sad the health sector does not play politics. We must speak the truth and nothing but the truth. We inherited a health financial system that was strangled. The National Health Insurance Authority that was supposed to be used as a vehicle to finance health care was such that they were not getting their releases. It was such that it was capped. The money that was collected in the name of the sick, the money that was collected in the name of accident victims was diverted and used for some other purposes. That is the type of health insurance that we inherited. I must say that common things like vaccine that we used to procure without any problem, indeed, under our friends at the other Side, we had problems with the vaccine. It was such that we had outbreaks of measles in the Northern Region. We had an outbreak of meningitis, cholera, diarrhea and all these because we could not procure vaccines. Indeed, the counterpart funding for the procurement of vaccines was so difficult to come by that I wondered what type of country that we live in.

Procurement of vaccines became a problem even during the COVID-19 era. If you would recollect, the Sputnik V vaccine that was supposed to sell below US\$10 was procured for US\$26. This is the type of nation that we have inherited. That is not all.

5:46 p.m.

About 74,000 health workers are still in the house, of which 50,000 are nurses. I always say that this is a security threat to the nation. It is just like policemen. We take in the policemen, teach them how to shoot a gun and then we do not employ them. There was no policy on the ground that we inherited that was supposed to assist us employ these people.

Mr Speaker, Agenda 111. I always wondered; we had a lot of money, about US\$400 million. We should take ourselves as individuals who have been given US\$400 million – that amount can build, let us say, 30 hospitals – then we decide that, no, we will spread the money and build 101 hospitals. In the long run, we did not contribute a single bed to the bed capacity in the country. Sometimes, as a man in the private sector of health, I do not understand this. I do not get it. Is it that it is good to give out 111 contracts or what? Do we get more money somewhere when we give out 111 contracts instead of 30 contracts? I think God will answer us one day.

All is not yet lost. Ghanaians on December 7th, 2024, put a rescue team together. That rescue team was led by His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, his Minister, Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh, and your good self, Mr Speaker, with your Committee on Health to rescue this country from our Friends at the right corner over there. Indeed, we intend to make the next three years the golden age of healthcare delivery in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, if we take the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, on page 82, paragraph 590, with your permission, I read:

Mr Speaker, the Ministry continued to expand access to quality healthcare in line with the Universal Health Coverage roadmap. The NHIF was uncapped to provide stable financing for vaccines, essential commodities, HIV services, and the Free Primary Health Care initiative under MahamaCares.

By uncapping this Fund, what we did was put GH¢3.5 billion into healthcare. We added that amount of money. I am glad to stand here and say that there is now enough money to pay for claims. All those who have submitted their claims have been paid up to date. If we take Nsawam/Adoagyiri, all the facilities have been paid. [*Hear! Hear!*] All the facilities in Tolon, Asokwa, Nhyiaeso and the government hospital at Winneba have been paid, except those who are not up to date in their submission of their bills.

At the beginning of the year, we had President Donald Trump and the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Kindly stop the time for Dr Nawaane. Yes, Hon Stephen Amoah, why are you on your feet.

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, I dwell on Order 122 (1) (c). The Hon Member just made mention —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order 122 (1) (c) has various categories. Is it information, elucidation, or clarification?

Dr Amoah: Clarification, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, what are you seeking for him to clarify?

Dr Amoah: He made mention of a statement that my constituency has been paid. They are watching. When I go and they ask me, I would not know. So, I want clarification from the Hon Member. What item has been paid?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The point he made is that the service providers of the National Health Insurance have been paid up to date. So, what are you seeking to be clarified?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, that is inaccurate, as far as I am concerned.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are completely out of order. Dr Nawaane?

Dr Nawaane: Indeed, all those who have submitted their bills have been paid. At the beginning of the year, USAID withdrew their services to the Government of Ghana and other countries, so we had problems with managing malaria, HIV/AIDS, Tuberculosis (TB) and child welfare. Because of the de-capping, we had a lot of resources and are now able to cater for the US\$78 million gap that was created

because of the withdrawal of USAID. So, this is a working Government; a Government that is able to face challenges and overcome it.

Mr Speaker, the NDC Government does not run away from problems. For the past 8 years, we know that when we go to the hospital, even if one is holding their insurance card, they pay. We pay for ourselves, our constituents and our family members. We cannot deny that fact. That was due to the fact that service providers were not being paid economic rates. The real value of the payment for their services was far below what they really needed. For all these years, in the books was what we call the actuarial study which they carried out for 8 years. Every year in the formula, they have the actuarial study going on.

Thanks to the leadership of Dr Victor Bampoe, the CEO of National Health Insurance Authority, they have now completed the actuarial study. I am happy to inform the House that they have now realised that they need to increase the tariff rates by 120 to 180 per cent. If this amount is paid to service providers, the top-ups, under-the-table payments and other payment that we do over there will come to a halt. In fact, what the ordinary man sometimes describes as co-payments will be a thing of the past.

5:56 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Medical Trust Fund Act, 2025, was passed some months ago, and this is an area that has been lying fallow for some years now. We always explain situations that were

related to non-communicable disease as due to other factors, but not sickness. For example, if someone should die of cancer, we sometimes explain that it is due to witches and wizards. If someone should die of hypertension, diabetes, and other sicknesses, we explain that it is due to one's grandmother somewhere that is causing all this. That was because, there was no adequate funding; we could not diagnose these diseases, so we attributed everything to "African electronics." That it is one's mother, father, or an old lady somewhere that was causing these problems.

Now, we have enough money; 20 per cent of the NHIL has been fenced for the purpose of taking care of non-communicable disease. Mr Speaker, this money is going to be used for specialist care. In other words, only at the top would it be used. We have not stopped over there; we also have primary health care, that is coming. The primary health care is supposed to be free for anybody who attends the CHPS compounds, the health centres, the clinics, and the polyclinics. It is going to be free. The idea is that we should be able to let people report to health facilities very early. Because when one reports early, we are able to diagnose early, start treatment early, and there would not be complications. In other words, we are going to reduce the cost of treatment. That is what the primary health care is about. When one is sick, whether the person has money or not, the person should go to a hospital and start treatment. In so doing, we would not get complications, and would reduce the cost of treatment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I would proceed to give the floor to Mr Charles Forson. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Charles Forson (NPP— Tema Central): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy made by the Minister for Finance. Prior to that, I wish to empathise with the six lost souls courtesy the El-Wak Stadium disaster.

Mr Speaker, the Budget, as presented by the Minister for Finance, my name is sake, I must say it is a rather unfortunate budget in the sense that it does not give a practical solution to the needs and aspirations of the good people of Ghana. Mr Speaker, why am I saying so? I would dwell on the so-called 24-Hour Economy. We are told that the 24-Hour Economy is going to transform the unemployment situation of the country. The allocation, according to the Budget, is GH¢110 million, which is less than the US\$10 million waiver that the Minister for Finance gave to one corporation just last week.

Mr Speaker, GH¢110 million, if I am using a benchmark of about a million Ghanaian youth who are unemployed as a base to be given to them to go into farming or business, then it means that each person is going to get a paltry GH¢110.00. They told us that they were going to use the 24-Hour Economy to reduce unemployment drastically. Rather, in the same Budget, an allocation of about US\$1.2 billion is being earmarked for aircraft— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly withdraw. Other than that, you link it to the Budget, where it is stated that an amount of money has been allocated—

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, page 136, paragraph 1091 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, show me where the President is mentioned.

Mr Charles Forson: “We are going to— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, would you withdraw, or link it, or use the word in the Budget?

Mr Charles Forson: *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, take the Budget and read page 136.

Mr Charles Forson: It is part of the retooling of the Army.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, when they are retooling the Army, is it stated in the Budget that they are buying it— Hon Member, I direct that the words be expunged as if they do not exist.

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, thank you.

However, this same amount would translate to over GH¢15 billion. I believe that if it is used judiciously, can

transform the unemployment landscape of Ghana. Why am I saying so? Our main national security issue now is unemployment, and if we do have about GH¢15 billion, I believe in sincerity that we can use that to equip the youth of this nation. We import almost everything agricultural.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, early on, we had all intimated that we want the debate to flow and, Mr Speaker, you have shepherded the process all to this point. Our Colleagues on the other Side, especially those here, should leave the Hon Member alone to make his submission. Mr Speaker, the interjection coming from the other Side is just—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, sometimes the debaters are the cause of the interjection. So, if you debate within the rules—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, Mr Speaker, you asked him to do the needful by redrawing some statements—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He did not. I had to ask that the words be expunged from the record. If he had, I would not have asked that it be expunged from the record. Hon Minority Chief Whip, sometimes we notice a little disrespect to the Chair.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have taken a cue, and we would act accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have the floor. You may continue.

Mr Charles Forson: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

As I was saying, we need practical solutions to everything in Ghana. In the sense that, if we do have about GH¢15 billion, I sincerely believe that we can use that to reduce unemployment drastically. The Deputy Finance Minister is here; he would bear me out.

Mr Speaker, I am from the port city of Tema, and everybody may be happy with the COVID-19 levy removal. However, in there, there is a new administrative port charge; is this to say that we are going to collapse the clearing and forwarding industry in Tema? When we go to the airport—going forward, when the Budget is approved, there is an airport development fee.

5:56 p.m.

So, there is an offset. There is a total dislocation in there. They remove one tax and reimpose so many of them. I sincerely believe that we are not being truthful to the Ghanaian. Because, in one breath, we are saying that we are removing the tax and then we now reimpose a lot more taxes. The hardship of the Ghanaian is going to be steeper, I must say.

Mr Speaker, out of the total jump in revenue from GH¢268.8 billion in 2025 to GH¢3.2 billion, almost all will go into services and earmarked for compensation, interest, and transfers. Not much will go to the citizenry. Sadly, core ministries such as Education, Health

and Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs will see less impact.

Mr Speaker, domestically, finance capital expenditure jumped to about GH¢45.5 billion in 2026, including ring fence, GH¢30 billion, Big Push envelope up from GH¢33 billion total capital expenditure in 2025, without transparent project pipeline, strong value for money system and credible areas clearance plan. This risk becomes a politically driven project list that generates new contractor areas rather than reliable infrastructure delivery. What we are saying is that we will end up giving contrast to political contractors with no value for money.

Mr Speaker, social sectors are protected in rhetoric but squeezed in reality. The allocation to the Ministry of Education remains at about GH¢33.3 billion in both Budget and GETFund, and stays around GH¢9.9 billion, which amounts to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Where are you reading from? Are you reading from the Budget?

Mr Charles Forson: Of course, from the Budget respectfully, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you draw our attention to the page from which you are reading and indicate the paragraph.

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, my Colleague is getting me the page numbers. I did an abstract of the Budget.

Mr Speaker, the headline primary surplus of about 1.5 per cent of GDP on

a committal basis in both Budgets is now locked into law under reverse public finance management framework. This anchors an austerity path that prioritises creditor confidence over physical flexibility for jobs, youth programmes and social services, which on a cash basis, the Government still fails to reach the promised surplus. In simple terms, the shift from the 2025 to the 2026 Budget is not a move from pain to relief, but a move from emergency stabilisation to permanent sacrifice for citizens while the State protect its own comfort and political projects.

Mr Speaker, the repeated promise of a 1.5 per cent GDP primary surplus is not matched by cash outcome. Let me repeat; the repeated promise of a 1.5 per cent of GDP primary surplus is not matched by cash outcomes. This undermines the credibility of the fiscal anchor that the government present to parliament and markets. The copy and paste inflation and growth path—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, advert to standing Order 119.

“A Member shall not read the Member's speech, to the largest extent possible, but may read extracts from written, printed or electronic documents in support of the Member's submission or may refresh the Member's memory by reference to notes.”

So, advert to that.

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, thank you. But respectfully, to largest extent, I may refer, and what I am doing is referring, because it comes in numbers.

Mr Speaker, if the rosy growth and commodity assumptions do not hold, Ghanaians should expect more taxes, or more cuts, because the 2026 Budget has no buffer to protect them from future shocks.

Mr Speaker, all I would like to say is that this Budget has failed to meet the expectations of the Ghanaians, and I believe that much more needs to be done because we need practical solutions in solving the needs of the nation.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, may we vary the order of Business and take the item numbered 8 on the *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Maybe the Hon Deputy Majority Leader has not briefed the Hon Majority Leader. Before he came in, we had an agreement that would take two debaters from each Side and then we take the item numbered 8.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we will take two debaters.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, so we have just taken one, so two apiece and then we will do the Motions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I proceed to give the floor to Hon Helen Ntoso.

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso (NDC — Krachi West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy as presented by the Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson.

Mr Speaker, the 2025 and 2026 Budgets are a shift from rhetoric to action. Why am I saying this? Every budget has a theme, and I want to run us through some of the themes of the previous administration. In 2021, the theme that the previous administration presented to this House was “Economic Revitalisation through Completion, Consolidation and Continuity”. In Ga, *Wɔn ya wɔ hĩɛ*. In Ewe, *Mile ɲgɔ yim*; in my language, *Ale yɔ anyinsi tɔ*; in Twi *Ye rekɔ y'anim*; in English, we are moving forward. We heard all this, but we never moved forward.

Then in 2022, they came out with this theme: “Building a Sustainable Entrepreneurial Nation: Fiscal Consolidation and Job Creation. What did we see? Did we experience any job creation in this country?

6:06 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in 2023, the theme was “Restoring and Sustaining Macroeconomic Stability and Resilience through Inclusive Growth and Value Addition.” This Budget is a good one, so I am surprised by how some of our Colleagues on the other Side are

contributing. It is as if this Budget is empty. The theme for the 2024 Budget of NPP was “Pursuing Growth and Development within a Stable Macroeconomic Environment.” Mr Speaker, all this was rhetoric; empty.

Then, in 2025, the theme for our Budget was “Resetting the Economy for the Ghana We Want.” [*Hear! Hear!*] And Mr Speaker, we did what was stated in our theme. We should not forget in this House that His Excellency, the former Vice President, Dr Bawumia, said that he had arrested the dollar and given the keys to the Inspector General of Police (IGP). Not long after that, the dollar broke jail. When the dollar broke jail, the IGP could not arrest the dollar.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, hold the time.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, my good friend just made a statement that I consider incorrect. She said that the former Vice President said he had arrested the dollar and given the keys to the IGP. Mr Speaker, can she provide better particulars? [**Some Hon Members:** Ei!] If she has better particulars, she must back her statement with those particulars. Otherwise, she should stay clear and proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the statement that the former Vice President indicated he had arrested the dollar and given the keys to the IGP. You want her to provide further and better particulars of that?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am contesting. My good Friend and Sister wants to flow, and I want to help her. She should tell this House when and where that statement was made, and then we can allow her to proceed. Otherwise, it is a House of records, and it cannot go into the records.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then you are looking for evidence.

Hon Member, kindly continue.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, the Minority Chief Whip knows that I have very strong political shock absorbers. So, what he is doing will not stop me from soaring the way I want to soar. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, the dollar broke loose, but thankfully, in March this year, the dollar that broke loose from jail reported itself to Dr Ato Forson. [*Hear! Hear!*] That is why the cedi is appreciating, and this is resetting the Ghana we want.

The theme for the 2026 Budget is “Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation.” I can assure our Colleagues on the other Side that this Government is resetting for growth. Next year, 2026, by the grace of God, there will be a lot of job opportunities in this country—[*Hear! Hear!*] Mr Speaker, our Colleagues on the Side agree with me that in 2025, we actually started resetting the economy. And in 2026, we are going to continue. We have moved forward as a nation.

Mr Speaker, this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy demonstrate clear gender and social sector priorities. I have gone through the Budget with a gender lens. And I am saying that this Budget has significant gender differentiated benefits, including one, the promotion of gender equality in education. It will also reduce absenteeism because the girl child who could not buy sanitary pads, thankfully, in 2026, with the distribution of 6.6 million packs of sanitary pads to girls in public schools, will be able to. Not singles. A Colleague was saying that 6.6 million packs, not singles. They were distributed for the basic schools, but it is going to be extended to senior high schools nationwide.

Mr Speaker, this is a landmark intervention. We saw an increase in school attendance by 15 per cent. There was a Colleague on the other Side who asked if absenteeism had reduced. Yes, it has reduced by 15 per cent. [*Hear! Hear!*] The initiative is a welcomed policy with clear gender equity intentions.

Mr Speaker, then on Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP). The Budget allocated GH¢1.1 billion to support extremely poor households, including children, children with disabilities, the elderly, persons with disabilities and pregnant women. Is it not a good policy? When it comes to school feeding, there is an allocation of GH¢1.98 billion for school feeding. It means that school feeding beneficiaries are going to benefit. There is going to be an expansion, and when it happens, it

means that more children are going to be fed. So, if more children would be fed, then automatically there is going to be an increase in attendance.

Mr Speaker, to close the gender gap in ICT education, 10 girls' schools across the regions will receive ICT laboratories in 2026. We do not have to leave our children in the development agenda of our dear country, because no reasonable person boasts on a weak foundation. We left out our toddlers, pre-schoolers, and primary school students, who are the future of this country and concentrated on JSS and senior high schools, but this Budget is taking care of these children in our country.

Mr Speaker, the Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) registration is a big relief. We know that when it comes to BECE registration, Members of Parliament are called upon to help register these children because some parents are not able to afford it. So, it is a big relief to us as Members of Parliament, including my good friend, the Chief Whip. An amount of GH¢160 million has been budgeted to ensure that no child is prevented from writing B.E.C.E due to inability to pay.

6:16 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to the health sector allocation, several components that directly affect women and vulnerable groups are being taken care of. Expansion of primary health care, continual investment in maternal and child health infrastructure, strengthening of Community Health

Planning and Services (CHPS) compounds, the District Assemblies have been asked to, mandatorily, build at least two CHPS compounds. If we multiply it by two, we have about 522 CHPS compounds to be built in one year in this country. Is it not a good initiative?

When it comes to agriculture, the Budget's agriculture priorities go into vegetable planting, rice, poultry, mechanisation, input subsidies and offers potential benefits for women, especially smallholder farmers. So, this Budget is actually a good budget for women, children, persons with disabilities and the vulnerable.

The debates of our Colleagues on the other Side are full of lamentations. I heard a Colleague on the other Side say, why are we putting a lot of money in the purchase of sanitary pads instead of creating jobs? Mr Speaker, the adolescent girls that you do not want to benefit from the national cake, come 2028, they will get to the age of 18 years. They are listening to them. They will be going to them seeking for their votes. So, support this Government to buy sanitary pads for them because they cannot afford them.

Mr Speaker, when you get to the Bible, we have the Book of Lamentations. I am wondering, those who are lamenting that instead of buying only one helicopter, why are we buying four, instead of doing this, why are we doing that— A lot of lamentations. I just want to draw the attention to the fact that the Book of Lamentations have already been written. I do not know whether they

intend writing. We have a biblical Book of Lamentations; I do not know whether they want to write a political book of lamentations. If they write a political book of lamentations, they will not get anyone to buy it because this Budget is a good budget.

I speak the truth, nothing but the truth. Mr Speaker, the scripture says in Jeremiah 29 verse 7, with your permission I beg to quote:

“but seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare”.

English Standard Version.

Mr Speaker, my advice to our Colleagues on the other Side is that they should better pray for H.E. John Mahama and this administration so that the Government will perform, and Ghana will be a good place for all of us to enjoy. Their welfare depends on God and the performance of this administration. They have to pray for this Government to be able to succeed so that we all enjoy as a people in this country, instead of all the time criticising, lamenting, and whining.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, it is now the turn of Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah. You have 15 minutes.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr

Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on this year's Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented to this House by the Minister for Finance. Mr Speaker, the human capital development of every nation is at the centre of everything. That is why international benchmarks require that between 4 per cent to 6 per cent of GDP should be committed to education. Mr Speaker, it will interest you to know that over the past 10 years, the best percentage of GDP for education was what was done by the Akufo-Addo Government in 2020, and that was 4.63 per cent. Unfortunately, 2025 was 3.1 per cent. We were hoping that 2026 was going to be higher. Unfortunately, that one too is about 3.07 per cent. When we were debating the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I made mention of chameleon and people did not agree with me. I also made mention of the fact that *dada noaa, biribiara nsesa ye*, to wit, ‘the same thing, nothing has changed.’

I have in my hand the *Official Report* of 25th June 2025. Mr Samuel Atta-Mills asked the Hon Minister for Education, and I quote, “Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education, why some teachers do not have staff ID numbers and have not been paid for several months.”

In response, and as part of the answer, the Hon Minister of Education went on to say, and I quote, “We intend to recruit as many as 50,000 teachers, which was provided for in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Hon Minister for Finance.” The question we are asking, with the high pupil-to-

teacher ratio we have, just at the basic level, we are talking about a deficit of about 30,000. In 2025, teacher recruitment, *hwi* it means, 'nothing', not even a single one, 'zero'. Unfortunately, in the Minister's response, he stated that those that were employed by the NPP Government in 2024, which was about 5,643, were going to be worked on and hired. The sad truth is that none has been employed as we speak.

Let us come back to the 50,000. The 50,000 that were to be employed, the question we are asking the Hon Minister for Education, the Minister for Finance, and H.E. President John Dramani-Mahama, where are the 50,000 teachers? Why? I have a couple of graduates from Akomadan, Nkenkaasu and Asemaneye, who were happy to hear the Minister announce 50,000 recruitments in 2025. Unfortunately, none happened.

Mr Speaker, let us refer to the NDC Manifesto, because their social contract is through their Budget and Manifesto, and is through their policies. The manifesto of the NDC says that we, the NDC, are going to scrap the mandatory national service for teacher trainee graduates and restore the automatic employment of newly qualified teachers.

6:36 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we have graduates who have qualified since last year but are still at home. Mr Speaker, as I speak, the number of enrolments being given to our colleges of education has been reduced

drastically. Where is the hope? The Hon Minister who just spoke talked about employment. There is no hope for our young Ghanaians. This Budget is like a coffin; outside it is so beautiful, but inside, a lot of sadness. The young Ghanaian is waiting for us. The classrooms are empty —

Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe —
rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Asamoah, the time should be stopped for you. Yes, Hon Nortsu-Kotoe, you are up; why?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I need to clarify a point he just mentioned, that quotas for colleges of education admission have been slashed, which is not true. What happened is the rationalisation of the numbers. Previously, some colleges had the advantage of taking more than others. This year, the Ministry of Education, as much as possible, tried to equalise the admission in schools, so that they will have numbers that commensurate with their facilities. For instance, a particular school where they had only females had to be given more numbers so that they could admit more female students. That is what happened. Even last Friday each Principal was to admit 20 more students in their various colleges of education. So, the information he is giving is not true, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you have the opportunity to debate.

Dr Asamoah: In fact, the sad truth is that, cumulatively, an average has been slashed, which the Hon Chairman for the Committee on Education is aware of. Unfortunately, when we compare the numbers that were given in 2024 to the one they were given for the 2025-2026 academic year, it has been slashed. Some numbers that were around 400 have been reduced to 300 and only added 20. So, the 20 that have been added is still below the number that were given last year, which the Hon Member is aware of.

Mr Speaker, in continuing, the sad truth is that our teachers are waiting. They need to be employed. It was a commitment. They promised the young Ghanaians that they were going to scrap the mandatory national service year and employ them directly, and that is the reason they voted for them. Even those who were employed in 2024 have not been validated, how much more new ones being employed? Mr Speaker, it tells us that this Budget is *kojoto*. In fact, it looks like, Mr Speaker, we are playing *tsaskele* with the youth of this country.

Mr Speaker, let us come to one thing, and I am happy that we are paying something for the young Ghanaians. Mr Speaker, if we look at the Budget, in appendix 4A, page 162, it says that GH¢537 million has been committed for no fee stress. That was the commitment they made to the young Ghanaians that for this 2025/2026 academic year, we are expecting about 200,000 students to go to public universities, then about 20,000 to go to private universities.

Mr Speaker, the NDC promised to pay for all the academic fee of our young ones. Averagely, each one of them is going to get just about 2,000, which is about 55 per cent for most of the students. In some instances, it is just about 30 per cent of the academic tuition fees that they want to pay for. So, we have not kept the promise we gave to Ghanaians. In fact, I like the musician called King Promise. His songs are nice and we have to play them. But unfortunately, this King Promise is not keeping his promise for the young Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, so with all this said, we know that the double track is something that Ghanaians are proud of. We would realise that the first cohort of the double track had one of the best results in this country. So, if we look at the evidence, performance and contact hours that is being achieved by the double track; it is something that we cannot underrate. In any case, whose child should stay home? Everybody had the opportunity to attend school. It is because of that that we are happy to continue with about 200,000 people. Without the double track, we would not be able to achieve this.

Mr Speaker, the reason I say chameleon is which one is which? This is because the Budget says that by 2026, double track is going to be taken off. The NDC manifesto said double track will be taken off within the first two years. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Education is saying double track will be taken off in three years' time. Mr Speaker, which one should the young Ghanaian or the young parent believe? Which is which? Is it like

the chameleon where depending on where they stand, they change their colour? Please, the young Ghanaian needs some hope. We do not want the Budget to be like a coffin; outside it is beautiful, inside it is sadness.

So, Mr Speaker, we are talking about jobs. Mr Speaker, if we look at the indicative allocation for Youth Employment Agency (YEA), it about GH¢1.9 billion. But if we look at the budgetary allocation for 2026, it has been slashed. So, the question is what is the hope we are giving to young Ghanaians? In 2025, they talked about Adwumawura, the National Apprenticeship Programme. In fact, they are good at renaming and relaunching. This country has already launched National Apprenticeship Programme with a policy. Mr Speaker, where is the GH¢300 million allocated for the National Apprenticeship Programme? How much was given for this programme? Now, we come back and we have reduced and we are giving GH¢170 million. We have the number of youth increasing every day. So, if nothing at all, they could have increased it to about GH¢500 million. But unfortunately, *hwii*; they reduced it instead.

Mr Speaker, they talked about building six state-of-the-art Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) centres, because without skills, our young ones will be trooping. In fact, let me express my condolence to the families of the six ladies that we lost. It is quite unfortunate. I would not want to lose my daughter in such a way. No parent would want their daughter to go

out to go and look for a job and not come back. Which of us would want our children to go out looking for a job and not come back? It is only in this country, Mr Speaker, that when we take your child for primary education, secondary education, tertiary education, then we have to be visiting either the pastor or some just to pray for a job for the child. It is quite unfortunate and not acceptable.

Unfortunately, the National Apprenticeship Programme, has been reduced. As to which policy we are using to implement it, we do not know. What is the status of the six TVET centres that we wanted to construct? The Budget did not talk about it. Every nation that has developed has invested so much in technical and vocational education. With this Budget, TVET is *kojoto*; nothing for TVET.

Mr Speaker, there is a lot that we are missing for our youth. But let us come home. We know how much, work you have done for our revered chiefs. Mr Speaker, unfortunately, in this Budget, there is nothing for our revered chiefs. It was in this same hollow Chamber that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs came to tell us that they were going to do so much for our Chiefs. They were going to construct six Regional House of Chiefs buildings across the six new regions. Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, only a paltry amount of GH¢20 million was allocated. Unfortunately, nothing happened, and for this year's Budget, 2026, it is just about GH¢30 million. It is quite unfortunate.

Mr Speaker, again, for us, I would like to assure our Chiefs that the Minority will always want to stand with them. Because we need to amend the Chieftaincy Act, 2008 (Act 759) to give our Chiefs some more power and authority to support with chieftaincy issues. There are basic things that our chiefs can help us to solve.

6:46 p.m.

Unfortunately, nothing is being done for them. The amendment of the Act would help to give them some power and to give them some more responsibility alongside some training.

Mr Speaker, codification of our chieftaincy line of succession is something we cannot leave. But we want to assure the chiefs of this country that we, the mighty Minority, are with them. Because if we do not provide support to our chiefs—unfortunately, there are some of us who can go to their hometown because of chieftaincy issues. Sometimes, as little as marriage issues could be solved by chiefs. Unfortunately, it is not being done. We need to invest in our chiefs. We need to bring back the Chieftaincy Development Fund that the NPP initiated. We need to make sure we can support our chiefs to support us so that we can develop as a nation.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I implore you to advert your mind to article 106 (3) of the 1992 Constitution. Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we are going back to the *Order Paper Addendum* and take item numbered 8 on page 3. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a financial Bill. Why are we taking a procedural Motion? Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I wanted to seek permission for the Deputy Minister to continue—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but we need to resolve this issue. This is a financial Bill. Very well, we shall address this subsequently.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it has been introduced under certificate of urgency, so we would seek to take it through all the stages today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, let us move to Motion numbered 9.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not know whether your concerns have been addressed. But I was listening to the Majority Leader. You raised an important issue on the subject matter of item numbered 8. Mr Speaker, what is the pleasure of the Majority?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, he has indicated that I am right and that we should take item numbered 9 instead of item numbered 8.

BILL — SECOND READING

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP) *on behalf of the Minister for Finance:* Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion moved by the Hon Deputy Minister and in so doing, I present your Committee's Report.

Introduction

The Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 was presented to Parliament by Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, in accordance with Article 174 of the 1992 Constitution and read for the first time on Thursday, 13th November, 2025. Subsequently, the Bill was referred to the Finance Committee for consideration and report in accordance with Article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 226 of Parliament.

Urgency of the Bill

The Committee met to determine the urgency of the bill pursuant to Article 106(13) of the Constitution and Standing Order 160 of the House. After careful consideration, the Committee determined that the Bill should be taken under certificate of urgency.

Deliberations

The Committee, in considering the Bill met with the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem, officials from the Legislative Drafting Division of the Ministry of Justice and Attorney-General's Department and technical teams from the Ministry of Finance and Ghana Revenue Authority.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents in the consideration of the Bill:

- i. The 1992 Constitution;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Value Added Tax Act, 2013 (Act 870);
- iv. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2015 (Act 890);
- v. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) (No.2) Act, 2015 (Act 904);
- vi. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2017 (Act 948);
- vii. The Value Added Tax Amendment) (No.2) Act, 2017 (Act 954);
- viii. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2018 (Act 970);

- ix. The Value Added Tax Amendment) (No.2) Act, 2018 (Act 980);
- x. The Value Added Tax Amendment) Act, 2019 (Act 1005);
- xi. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2021 (Act 1072);
- xii. The Value Added Tax Amendment) Act, 2022 (Act 1082)
- xiii. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) (No. 2) Act, 2022 (Act 1087);
- xiv. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2023 (Act 1107); and
- xv. The Value Added Tax (Amendment) Act, 2025 (Act 1133)

Object of the Bill

The object of the Bill is to revise and consolidate the law relating to the imposition of Value Added Tax.

Contents of the Bill

The Bill contains fourteen parts, seventy-five (75) clauses and five (5) Schedules.

Clause 1 imposes the Value Added Tax levy. Clause 2 defines persons liable to pay the Tax and Clause 3 provides for the rate of the Tax and its calculation.

Clause 4 defines a taxable person and provides for the effective date of registration of a person as a taxable person. Clause 5 defines what a taxable activity it. Clause 6 provides for Persons required to register. Clause 7 deals with exception regarding thresholds and periods for registration. Clause 8 covers for the period for becoming a taxable person. Clause 9 mandates the Commissioner-General to give notice of registration. Clause 10 deals with issuance of certificate of registration.

Clause 11 is on notice of registration or cancellation in respect of turnover. Clause 12 provides for the designation of taxable persons in respect of groups and distinct divisions. Clause 13 is on voluntary registration.

Clause 14 – provides for the compulsory registration of a person who is not required to register under the Bill. Clause 15 deals with registration of non-resident persons who provide telecommunication services or electronic commerce. Clause 16 spells out sanctions for failure to register. Clause 17 provides provisions for an up-front payment by unregistered importer.

Clause 18 mandates the Commissioner-General to keep a register of taxable persons. Clause 19 deals with a taxable person giving notice of change in business to the Commissioner-General. Clause 20 is on cancellation of registration.

Clauses 21 and 22 define supply of goods and services. Clause 23 is on repossession of goods as supply of

goods. Clause 24 provides for a lay-away agreement as supply of services

Clause 25 deals with separate supply. Clause 26 is on activities that do not constitute supply of goods or services. Clause 27 covers the effect of denial of input tax. Clause 28 is on payment of deposit and receipt of claim as supply of goods or services. Clause 29 covers disposition of taxable activity as a supply of goods and services. Clause 30 provides for the issuance of phone cards, prepaid airtime and other prepayment as supply of services for the purposes of the Tax. Clause 31 is on mixed supplies while Clause 32 provides for supply by agent or auctioneer.

Clause 33 defines taxable supply. Clause 34 covers the payment of Tax on importation of goods or services. Clause 35 exempts certain supply of goods or services from the Tax. Clause 36 provides for zero-rated supply. Clause 37 deals with exempt import. Clause 38 is on relief from Tax.

Clause 39 provides for time of supply. Clause 40 is on time of import. Clauses 41 and 42 provides for the Place of supply of goods and services. Clause 43 deals with the issue of a tax invoice or a sales receipt. Clause 44 defines the value of taxable supply.

Clause 45 specifies taxable value for determining Tax on imported goods and services. Clause 46 — sets out the conditions under which a taxable person is required to make adjustments. Clause 47 provides for adjustments on account

of bad debts. Clause 48 defines a tax payable for tax period. Clause 49 outlines deductible input tax. Clause 50 specifies the qualification for deductible input tax. Clause 51 states other conditions for deductible input tax. Clause 52 provides for the calculation of deductible input tax for mixed taxable and exempt supply. Clause 53 is on refund or credit for excess tax paid. Clause 54 provides for the time for payment of refund by the Commissioner-General.

Clause 55 is on the appointment of Value Added Tax Withholding Agent. Clause 56 spells out the duties of the Value Added Tax Withholding Agent. Clause 57 defines the scope of Value Added Tax Withholding Agent. Clause 58 provides for exemption from withholding Tax.

Clause 59 on the submission of tax return by a taxable person. Clause 60 provides for the date of payment of Tax. Clause 61 is on the payment of Tax on import of services. Clause 62 is on Tax assessment. Clause 63 is on correction of tax return.

Clause 64 deals with recovery of Tax due and Clause 65 is on recovery from recipient of a supply. Clause 66 deals with failure to issue tax invoice while Clause 67 is on evasion of Tax.

Clause 68 covers Tax-inclusive pricing. Clause 69 is on Declaration of representative. Clause 70 is on Persons acting in a representative capacity.

Clause 71 deals with Regulations and Clause 72 is on Interpretation. Clause 73 provides for repeals and savings. Clause 74 and 75 are on Transitional provisions and commencement.

There are five schedules as follows:

- First Schedule - Exempt Supplies
- Second Schedule - Zero-Rated Supplies
- Third Schedule - Relief Supplies
- Fourth Schedule - Tax Credit Note and Tax Debit Note
- Fifth Schedule - Apportionment of Input Tax

Observations

Rationale for the Bill

The Committee observed that the Value Added Tax Act, 2013 (Act 870) had been in force for over ten years and the tax regime is front with a number of challenges and complexities.

The Deputy Minister for Finance indicated that some of the difficulties came about due to amendments to Act 870. Furthermore, the current structure of Act 870 exhibits several distortions.

The Committee noted that even though the statutory rate of the Value Added Tax was fifteen per cent (15 per cent), the effective rate was approximately twenty-two percent, due to the decoupling of the Ghana Education Trust Fund Levy of two point five per cent, the National Health Insurance Levy of two point five per cent and the COVID-19 Health Recovery

Levy of 1per cent had led to tax cascading effects, increased the cost of production and ultimately raised the cost of goods and services.

The Deputy Finance Minister informed the Committee that the present tax system uses a mix of standard rates, flat rates and non-deductible charges, which shows traits of both value added tax and sales tax. This situation undermined the neutrality, efficiency and transparency of the Value Added Tax regime and created compliance and administrative challenges.

The Deputy Finance Minister further informed the Committee that Government has decided to undertake a comprehensive tax reform to improve clarity, consistency and legal certainty. The reforms is also part of broader measures to enhance domestic revenue mobilization, improve efficiency in tax administration and alleviate the tax burden on households and businesses.

The Committee noted that the Bill would also replace the current flat rate tax system with a single, clear structure and further include a provision for increasing the registration threshold for Value Added Tax persons, thereby exempting micro and small businesses from their VAT responsibilities. He therefore urged parliament to pass the Bill

Addressing Cascading Effects of VAT

The Committee observed that the current structure of the Value Added Tax exhibits several, distortions. Although the statutory rate of the tax is 15 per cent, the effective rate of the Tax is approximately 22 per cent due to the non-deductibility of and the prohibition of persons from claiming input tax credits on the Ghana Education Trust Fund Levy, the National Health Insurance Levy and the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy. The situation had contributed adversely to an increase in the cost of production and ultimately raised prices of goods and services.

The Bill addresses the cascading effect of the current VAT regime by revising the existing legal framework of the tax regime, making the Ghana Education Trust Fund Levy and the National Health Insurance Levy deductible and restoring the integrity of the VAT system.

The Committee observed that if approved the rate of the tax would be 20per cent (made up of 15 per cent VAT, 2.5 per cent NHIL and 2.5 per cent GETFUND). This is because the 2.5 per

cent NHIL and 2.5 per cent GETFUND would now be tax deductible.

Increase in the Threshold for Registering VAT

The Committee observed that the Bill seeks to increase the VAT threshold from GH¢200,000.00 to GH¢750,000.00.

The Minister for Finance explained that VAT thresholds are typically adjusted for inflation to ensure the real value of the existing threshold remains accurate for tax registration purposes. He mentioned that since the VAT Act was passed, the threshold has not been updated for inflation. He added that if the VAT threshold of GH¢200,000.00 had been adjusted for inflation annually, its current nominal value would now be GH¢832,000.00.

He mentioned that for the year 2024, considering the inflation rate at the time, the real value of the existing GH¢200,000.00 threshold was actually only GH¢48,000.00. He explained that because of this, tax administration had not been effective as many people who were legally required to collect VAT were not remitting same to the State. Further the cost of tax collection had increased making it not cost effective.

He said the Bill revised the threshold for registering VAT upwards to GH¢750,000.00 in order to make the tax regime more efficient and cost effective.

Fiscal Impact

The Committee observed that the Bill is expected to be revenue neutral in 2026 as a result of increased compliance and

overall positive impact of the reforms on the economy.

Reduction in Tax Burden

The Committee noted that the Decoupling of the NHIL from the GETFund Levy and the repeal of the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy Act, 2021 (Act 1068) and therefore the abolishment of the COVID-19 levy of 1 per cent, will reduce the effective VAT rate from 22 per cent to 20 per cent. The reduction will lessen the tax burden on businesses and consumers. Also, no VAT will be paid on the purchase of firms' inputs as they will be afforded the opportunity to claim input tax credits which hitherto constituted part of their cost of doing business.

Another merit is also that, even though with the passage of the Bill, the flat rate of VAT will be abolished, businesses paying the flat rate under the existing regime will also benefit from the input tax credit claim. With the input tax deduction, those paying the flat rate now will not be worse-off under the new regime because the abolishment of the flat rate, in effect, is not an increment over the flat rate.

The Bill will also increase the threshold for persons registering for VAT thereby exempting small and micro businesses who would have otherwise been compelled to register. This will bring the much-needed relief for these businesses to enable them grow.

The tax burden on businesses and households arising from the cascading effect of the tax regime will therefore be eliminated and the reforms will boost the

income available to businesses and households, which should significantly improve their welfare.

Efforts to Increase VAT Revenue

The Committee observed that the Bill introduces a number of reforms and enquired from the Minister whether these measures would translate into an increase in the tax revenue.

The Minister informed the Committee that if passed, the measures would make the tax regime much more transparent, improve clarity, consistency and legal certainty. The new law would uphold neutrality, and enhance compliance. Further, the bill would reduce administrative burden and create a much more equitable and growth-supportive tax environment.

The Bill would enhance revenue mobilisation and improve efficiency in the tax administration thereby making tax collection much more cost efficient. In addition to other broader measures to be undertaken, the Authority would embark on sensitisation programmes to educate the public on the tax reforms to enhance compliance. He said that these measures would enable Government raise the needed revenue for the State.

Conclusion

After consideration of the Bill, the Committee is of the view that the Bill was in the right direction as it seeks to create a more equitable tax system, reduce complexities in the administration of the Tax, promote

voluntary compliance and also foster a growth-supportive tax environment.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt this report and also pass the Value Added Bill, 2025 under certificate of urgency in accordance with Article 106(13) and 174 of the Constitution and Standing Orders of Parliament.

Respectfully Submitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion is moved, and the Report presented. It is for the consideration of the House. Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I have checked my time, and it is 6.57 p.m. Many businesses have closed, many Ghanaians have left their offices and they are home, and this is the time that this Government is introducing this Bill, imposing a further tax burden on businesses. Mr Speaker, the Chairperson of the Finance Committee in this presentation says that this is tax neutral. What is tax neutral? What is a neutrality concept in this? Revenue neutral in what sense? This VAT—

6:56 p.m.

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, hold it. Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, no tax is being imposed and I just want it for the records that no tax is being imposed and if there is any tax that is being imposed, the Hon Minority Leader can refer us to the specific clause that imposes a new tax.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, by way of guidance, the Bill has already been introduced. It is now at Second Reading.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have this report with me. I have the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 document with me. I have both.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have taken that and it is at the Second Consideration stage, so the introduction has been done and the Bill has been referred to the Committee. The Committee is now ready with the report. So, your statement that the Bill is now being introduced is what I am worried about.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is so, Mr Speaker. I mean, for want of a better word, that is a language used. I am not using it as a term of art. What I am saying is that Government is imposing tax and I will explain.

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader has asked the question, and he said I should prove to him. Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader must be tolerant. I will explain to him. He has asked the question, let me answer it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, he has a copy of the Bill to prove that it is imposing tax.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you do not need to repeat yourself.

Mr Speaker, retail services and goods, originally was 3 per cent. It is no more 3 per cent if this Bill is passed. They are taking it to 15 per cent. Tell me that I am lying. Real estate from 5 per cent is going to 15 per cent. Are they maintaining the current threshold or are they increasing it? And by increasing, does it not amount to imposition of tax?

Mr Adongo — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Look, we are wide awake; we are watching every move of theirs. We are watching them. They cannot smuggle anything in, in the dead of night.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, hold on, the Chairperson of the Committee is on his feet.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, he should rebut.

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, it is important for us not to mislead the people of Ghana. If you were a trader and you were charged a presumptive tax of 3 per cent that he is referring to, you went to the warehouse to buy the stocks that you sell, there was an imposition of a tax you did not recover. So, if you wanted to

tell the effective rate that the person paid, it is the 3 per cent plus what he paid at the warehouse to buy the stock.

Today, what he paid at the warehouse would be allowed as a deductible expense. It will be an input VAT. If he now adds a value of 2 per cent, it is 2 per cent he is charging, technically. So, for anybody to ignorantly say that if you move from 3 per cent to 15 per cent, you are imposing a tax.

Some Hon Members — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Adongo, kindly withdraw the word “ignorantly”.

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, I withdraw.

Except that effectively, if you look at this, we said the tax that you are expecting, there is a revenue neutral. Why do we say that? You lose some, you gain some. So, what you get is that, that person who was losing the cost of the material that he bought in terms of VAT now gains. But in addition to that, GHC3 billion is being made available by abolishing the decoupling of the NHIL. And so, the effective VAT rate are moving from 21.95 per cent to 20 per cent. Let anybody tell me that you would like to pay a tax of 21.95 per cent as opposed to 20 per cent. I do not know what the Minority Leader wants to tell me that he would prefer to pay a tax of 21.95 per cent instead of 20 per cent. That is what it is. So please, let us not mislead the people of Ghana for the sake of politics.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, before I go on with my issues in this matter, let me appeal to my respected Colleague. I debate issues in this Chamber trying not to disrespect Colleagues. And Hon Adongo knows how much I respect him. Let us debate and get out happy fellows. Those abusive languages, though you have withdrawn it, but please, I accord you every respect. Let us disagree with high level of decency.

Mr Speaker, having registered that protest, I would want to proceed. The respected Chairperson of the Committee, in an attempt to water down my concerns, rather escalated the matter. I raised a specific issue, the burden contained therein is this, that you are increasing retail services and goods VAT from three per cent to 15 per cent, *simpliciter*. Secondly, real estate is going up from five per cent to 15 per cent. This revenue neutrality language and all that, we are not interested. They claim some threshold has been increased. They are saying in their own report, that the introduction of this Bill will help Government to generate revenue, true or false?

Would they listen? They do not get it. When they talk, we keep quiet and listen to them. That is not the rule of the game, Mr Adongo.

We are telling them that this Bill is being brought because they need revenue. If they are not imposing taxes,

if this Bill does not seek to burden the ordinary businessman, then what else are they seeking to achieve? If indeed they claim that there is revenue neutrality, *et cetera*, then let the status quo remain. They are coming here with a Bill; the Bill to allow them to impose tax.

Mr Speaker, in his own report, he says that he is relying on the Constitution and the Standing Orders of this House. They only came to Parliament with a tax Bill because the Constitution says so. That is why you are here. This report does not seek to repeal any existing law neither is it saying that it is not going to impose any tax. So, all these plenty of grammar and semantics, that is not the issue.

Clearly, you have indicated that Government needs more revenue. They need more revenue. They are bringing this Bill because of revenue. It is the reason I keep telling them that they are a Government of convenience, not a government of principle. They said they are lessening the burden;

7:06 p.m.

A moment ago, they said they were taking the COVID-19 Levy out. They again said that they were taking away the E-Levy, but in its place, they brought the one litre, GH¢1. They introduced an 18 per cent tariff on electricity and further imposed a tax. So, what are they telling us? They have made their Majority Leader so busy, looking for an opportunity to obstruct me, but he cannot find any. The Report is clear. They said

that the Government needs more revenue. That is the reason the Deputy Minister is here.

Look at the Memorandum of the Bill. Are they going to increase tax or not? They should simply tell us. And if this Bill is passed, are they going to use it to generate more revenue or not? They should tell us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think it is important for us to start from the basics. The basis is Order 167, which is the Second Reading. And it says,

“(1) When a Motion is moved “that a Bill be now read a Second Time”, a full debate shall ensue on the basis of the explanatory memorandum and the report from the relevant Committee.”

So, this is what Second Reading is all about: the Memorandum and the Report. I asked him to prove that there is an imposition of tax. He spoke, but has not proven anything. Let us go to the Memorandum. What does the Memorandum say? The Memorandum says that, and it is quite lengthy, but I will read the relevant portions. It says that:

“The object of the Bill is to revise and consolidate the law relating to the imposition of Value Added Tax.”

To revise and consolidate, not to impose a tax. It is clear we are not

imposing a tax. We are revising and consolidating existing taxes. The Value Added Tax, which is already imposed under Section 2 of Act 870, provides for the imposition of a Value Added Tax on the supply of goods or services made in the country and the import of goods or services into the country.

Act 870 has been in force for over 10 years, and several challenges identified in the implementation of Act 870 have made it necessary to reform and consolidate the legislative framework to ensure effective implementation. So reforming, consolidating with the object of effective implementation, are the key principles underpinning this Bill.

Firstly, Act 870 has undergone several amendments in response to evolving policy, administrative and economic considerations. These amendments, while necessary, have resulted in the fragmentation of the legislative framework of the Value Added Tax and contributed to the complexity of the current Value Added Tax regime. So, it has become complex. There is, therefore, the need to consolidate the amendments to improve clarity, consistency and legal certainty.

Furthermore, the current structure of the Value Added Tax exhibits several distortions. Although the statutory rate of the tax is 15 per cent, the effective rate of the tax is approximately 22 per cent. Due to the decoupling of the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) Levy of 2.5 per cent, the National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) of 2.5 per cent and the COVID-19 Health Recovery

Levy of 1 per cent, the prohibition of businesses from claiming input tax credits on the National Health Insurance Levy, the Ghana Education Trust Fund Levy and the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy has led to tax cascading effects, increasing the cost of production and ultimately raising the cost of goods and services.

Additionally, the current Value Added Tax regime incorporates a combination of standard rates, flat rates and non-deductible levies, exhibiting the features of both Value Added Tax and sales tax systems. This has undermined the neutrality, efficiency and transparency of the Value Added Tax regime and created compliance and administrative challenges.

Mr Speaker, thus far, the Memorandum does not talk about imposing any tax or increasing any tax, except to even add that the effective rate is higher, but the statutory rate is lower, and they are seeking to correct and define the statutory rate, which is the lower rate. So in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Government decided to undertake comprehensive reforms to the Value Added Tax regime of the country as part of broader measures to enhance domestic revenue mobilisation, improve efficiency in tax administration and alleviate the tax burden on households and businesses. The reforms seek to enact a new Value Added Tax Act to abolish the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy and reverse the decoupling of the National Health Insurance Levy and the Ghana Education

Trust Fund Levy from the Value Added Tax base, thereby restoring the ability to claim input tax credits.

So in fact, this helps the payer of the tax because it enables him to make some claims. The reforms also provide for a reduction of the effective rate of the Value Added Tax. So, there is going to be ultimately a reduction in the effective rate of the Value Added Tax to ease the burden on households and businesses, eliminate the flat rate schemes of the tax in favour of a unified and transparent structure, make provision for an upward revision of the registration threshold for the value added tax in order to exempt micro and small enterprises from Value Added Tax obligations. Micro and small enterprises are going to be freed from the burden of this tax, as well as improve taxpayer compliance through enhanced public education and awareness campaigns.

The Bill, therefore, seeks to revise and consolidate the existing legal framework in respect of the Value Added Tax to restore the integrity of the Value Added Tax system, promote voluntary compliance, reduce the administrative burden, and create a more equitable and growth-supportive tax environment.

Mr Speaker, where in this Memorandum has it been stated that a tax is being imposed? Instead of realigning the system in such a way that the burden is reduced. That is what the Bill says, that there is a need for a realignment so that effectively, we can achieve a reduction in the effective rate of the tax. So, when he gets up to announce that the Government

is imposing a tax, and I ask him to prove it, I expect him to show me anywhere where the Government is imposing a tax. But the Minister who brought it has a Memorandum, and our Standing Orders say that at the Second Reading stage, what should guide us is the Memorandum and the Report of the Committee.

But he is importing extraneous assumptions, making his own statements that cannot be found anywhere in the Memorandum, and he says that we are frustrated. No, please, he should stick to the Memorandum and what it says. If he wants to challenge what is in the Memorandum, he should go ahead, but he must prove it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, so that was a point of order, not his debate? I see. So, he has no opinion on this matter. I pray that he will be silent to also listen and tell his—*[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I gave you the floor, instead of continuing—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Well, Mr Speaker, you can call him. He controls the House. As for him, if you do not call him, he will rise.

7:16 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, for him to say that my Backbenchers are not acting

in a way that is consistent with decorum is an insult. It is an insult.

He is insulting my Backbenchers and he must withdraw. If it is misconduct in this Chamber, speaking out of turn, and importing irrelevant matters into a debate, I do not think that there is anybody who is a more serious culprit than them. In this Chamber, their Backbenchers have hurled insults, have led them to stand up and disregard the Speaker, in clear violation of our Standing Orders, *et cetera*. We have all lived with this. So, he does not get up and point fingers at my Backbenchers and say that they are not acting decorously. Please, let us respect each other. We will listen to him but do not accuse them of not being decorous in their conduct. It is an insult, and he must withdraw that, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, just do the needful.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, even as he was on his feet, the Member of Parliament for Kwesimintsim, was loud enough. Even when he was on his feet, trying to call for some orderliness, that Hon Member was loud, showing gross disrespect.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you have drawn my attention to Standing Order—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you heard the Majority Leader in silence. May I make my point?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, he raised some issues, and I am directing that avert your mind to Standing Order 123(2) and do the needful.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is only when it gets to this Side of the House that you find your voice to be asking us question. He spoke—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do the needful.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: You heard him. He spoke, and you did not utter a word. When it gets to this Side of the House, then—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will direct that the word—should be expunged from the record.

Yes, proceed. Hon Minority Leader, you may proceed.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I exercise a right to protest in silence, not to speak anymore because of the unfair treatment. I so rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister.

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem): Thank you, Mr Speaker. The Majority Leader has made enough comments about this Bill, and I just want to add a few. Clearly, the intention of the Government is not to impose any new tax. We rather want to lessen the burden on Ghanaian taxpayers. We would recall when Dr Ato

Forson presented the first Budget, he hinted that we are going to spend some time to consult widely and come to this House with a new VAT Bill. That is exactly what we are doing. The Bill, contrary to what the Minority Leader was saying, is not imposing any new tax on Ghanaians. It is rather giving back to Ghanaians. The decision to change the treatment of National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) and GETFund to allow for tax credit deductibility is rather giving back. In fact, NHIL alone, by changing from a straight levy to a VAT to allow for tax input credit, will let us lose an amount of GH¢1.7 billion—*[Interruption]*—Hon Minority Leader, please.

Mr Speaker, GETFund alone is letting us lose an amount of GH¢1.742 billion. The COVID-19 levy that we repealed a short while ago is also giving back to Ghanaians in excess of GH¢ GH¢3 billion Ghana. So, that is what is happening. We are not imposing any new tax. We have made a point that the current VAT Act is so disjointed. In fact, it has been amended 13 times. So, today, if we want to look into VAT laws, we have to look at many places. We have decided that we are bringing a new Bill to consolidate all the laws into one so that we will have a one-stop shop for our VAT laws. That is why you are seeing us come in with a new Bill so that at the end of the day, we will have one Act for VAT.

Apart from that, one would realise that the threshold of GH¢200,000 is so low. More than 10 years ago when Act 870 was passed, GH¢200,000 was the

threshold. Today, the value of that GH¢200,000 is estimated at GH¢48,000. We have taken a decision to increase it to GH¢750,000. Mr Speaker, currently, records show that revenues from VAT is from threshold above 750,000. That revenue constitutes 97 per cent of the total VAT revenue that we receive. Those below 750,000 contributes only some 3 per cent. So, raising it to GH¢750,000 and above is the right thing to do.

In addition to that, we are also abolishing VAT on recognisance and prospecting for minerals. That is also being abolished in this amendment. That also will cost the Government some money. But, we are convinced that if we want to increase, promote, or encourage prospecting for our mineral resources, we must give that incentives to businesses to do so. This amendment is also seeking to remove that VAT on prospecting for minerals.

It is clear that the intention of this amendment is not to burden anybody. What the Hon Minority Leader was raising— VAT on real estate currently adds to the cost because it is not allowed to be deducted. What we are replacing is the normal VAT that will allow for input-output deductibility. It is clearly to allow for businesses to flourish. That is what we are doing. We want to encourage everybody to support this. I am happy the Hon Minority Leader is a man of his word. He says he will listen in silence, and he will no longer say anything.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Why is he getting up? Is he changing his mind? *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I want everybody to support this cause because it is something that Ghanaians are looking out for, and we are doing just that. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, my earlier position remains, except that he mentioned my name in a submission and misquoted me. Mr Speaker, I thought in bringing the issue of the 15 per cent imposition of tax on real estate, he will rebut in absolute terms. Now he says that it is being introduced to allow for input and output, meaning that the earlier submission that this is an imposition is right and factual. He is now telling us that it is for the purpose of input and output tax. But if he is imposing a 15 per cent tax on real estates, how does he then describes it as it is merely for input and output tax? I mean, with respect, what sort of submission is this? He ends by saying that it will enable Government to get more revenue. Mr Ampem, I think that instead of going on that path, rather encourage the Majority Chief Whip to bring the numbers in because where they are going will not help them. I just decided to let it go. But now they have exposed themselves, that indeed, what I was saying earlier, that this imposes a 15 per cent tax on real estate is true. He is saying that it is being done for the purpose of input and output tax. What does he do when he brings taxation

which leads to input and output tax? Are they not imposing tax?

7:26 p.m.

Now, are you not indirectly telling us that the status quo is lesser tax for real estate and by this law they are increasing it to 15 per cent. I want them to rebut this in clear terms.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, what I have said is that the flat rate adds to the costs of businesses because they are not allowed to input them for tax credit. Right now, we are replacing all those flat rates with a normal VAT rate that allows for input tax credit. And the reason I am saying that we are going to get more revenue is that we intend to improve compliance and we are also introducing a reward system to motivate everybody to go for their VAT receipts, so that when they pay, they insist on their receipts and get Government to enforce compliance. These are the measures that are going to help us to improve revenue and not that we are increasing VAT for anybody.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Deputy Minister has misled this House with the submission that the flat system which is being done away with allows efficiency. In the least, I am an entrepreneur and the Hon Deputy Minister knows that I deal with this matter as an everyday thing. The flat system was lesser, made it more convenient and allowed for higher compliance. He cannot tell me that a real estate owner who was paying 5 per cent

under the flat system regime and now having to pay 15 per cent is better off. With respect, let us get the facts right. If they say they are doing away with the flat system, that the flat system had lower threshold, and had lesser percentage, and they now want to bring all of them into the mainstream VAT regime, are they not going to increase tax? So, if, for instance, I was a beneficiary under the flat system, they are now saying they are doing away with the flat system, so I should come into the mainstream VAT regime and they are telling me that that allows efficiency? Oh, no.

I am not a tax expert. I do not need to be a tax expert, but I am a businessman. I know that practically, when I am benefiting from the flat system, it is lesser tax I pay. If they now say that they are moving me into mainstream VAT, which is 15 per cent, I am going to pay more. They say that there is going to be input and output. Input and output already exist. The essence of VAT is that they pay and then they know. The Hon Deputy Minister should stop it. For the sake of the politics, he should not sacrifice his profession.

I am telling them that doing away with the flat system would increase the burden on businesses because now they are pushing everybody to pay the VAT. That is why they say they are going to get more revenue. What is a reward system? I have read the report, so he should point out to me a single line in this report that expressly provides a reward system as businesses are being graduated to pay. So do not say there is a reward system. There is nothing like that as a matter of

fact. This is the Bill. There is no incentive being introduced for the purposes of moving somebody who is an ordinary businessman, somebody doing a microcredit business, an entrepreneur with less capital who was benefiting from the flat system, what they are doing rather is going to make it difficult for people to comply because the flat system has some flexibility.

I repeat, I am a businessman so I know these things handily. The flat system was more convenient and allowed for higher compliance. What they are doing now will make many people run away. So, he should, please, not mislead us again. Mr Speaker, if it is their pleasure, so be it. We have expressed our objection and we state so without more.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 accordingly read a Second time.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we will do the item numbered 11.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE **Value Added Tax Bill, 2025**

Clause 1 to 3 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 4 — Taxable person

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee? Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you are a man who respects the law. Fortunately, we have a Majority Leader who does not joke with procedure. So, Mr Speaker, we are considering this important Bill. Behind the Deputy Minister for Finance are many empty seats. The Minority would want to state for the record that the Members of the Majority Side in this Chamber are less than 50. If the Deputy Minister for Finance knows that he has such an important Bill, he knows what to do. They should have distributed the Report to Members ahead of time, informed Members and ensured that they have sufficient reading materials.

7:36 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister cannot come here and say we should pass a Bill. It is 7 o'clock, getting to 8 o'clock. Mr Speaker, Members are prepared for debates. He should come well-prepared, and ensure that the Clerks-at-the-Table distribute sufficient reading materials to his own Backbench so that tomorrow we would come and do this. Every time he comes here under the Certificate of Urgency without the necessary preparation, if Members do not have their Report, how can they follow proceedings?

Mr Speaker, let us go back and take comments on the Bill. This is a matter that the entire House agrees on. Do you agree or not? *[Uproar]* The House is in agreement, let us suspend this and ensure that he does the right thing. Let us go back to the comments on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

You cannot always come here and go. The Deputy Minister should get the Report through to Members, and let them read.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, indeed, it is the case that there are not sufficient copies of the Bill in the Chamber right now. I even had to ask the Clerk for their copy of the Bill. It would not be tomorrow, Mr Speaker. We would just take two comments; by which time I think that enough copies would have been distributed. Mr Speaker, let us take two comments, and then we would get back to the Bill, so that the clerks can make arrangements for enough copies to be distributed.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I think there is a consensus. We would revert to the commentaries on the Budget, then the Majority Leader would make more copies of the Bill, and then we can decide on how to navigate. For now, Mr Speaker, we would take the comments.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, so we have to temporarily suspend the Consideration Stage of the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025. Hon Members, back to commentary, I would give the floor to Dr Sandaare. You have the floor.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2025

[Resumption of commentary from column 169]

Dr Sebastian Ngmenenso Sandaare (NDC — Daffiama/Bussie/Issa): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to make some few comments on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana. Mr Speaker, in 2025, this Government presented the Budget with the theme: “Resetting the Economy for the Ghana We Want.” That was a budget of hope, a budget that laid the foundation to stabilise the economy. Now, we have moved to 2026 and the Budget is under the theme: Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation” which you can find in paragraph 8 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is a budget for jobs and prosperity; prosperity for all Ghanaians, not for a few selected Ghanaians. Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy demonstrates clearly the interplay between population, health and development. Mr Speaker, I am going to demonstrate in a few minutes how this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is one of the best you can find in the past eight years that I have been in this House. This Budget shows consistency and it demonstrates our links with the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was presented, unlike the previous budgets that were not consistent.

Mr Speaker, the Government has shown bold initiatives that have great impact on the health status of the people of this country. Let me tell you one, take the Big Push Agenda, and on this note, on behalf of the people of the Upper

West Region, I would want to thank H. E. John Dramani Mahama for inaugurating the construction of the road from Accra to Kumasi, through to Techiman, Wenchi, Bole, Sawla and Wa, and also linking Wa through Tumu to Navrongo and Bolgatanga

Mr Speaker, one may think that this is just about roads and bridges, but this intervention has great impact on the health status of the people of this country. Take a woman in my Constituency, as far as Jolinyiri in the Kojokperi zone, who, during labour, has complications and has to be moved from Jolinyiri to the Upper West Regional Hospital. If this woman in complication is not fortunate and is referred to the Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital, what it means is that this woman is likely to die on the way as a result of delay due to the bad roads.

7:46 p.m.

So, the intervention by H. E. John Dramani Mahama to come with the Big Push that will link communities, will create good roads from the Upper West Region through Techiman to Kumasi. What it means is that the intervention will save more lives, referral will be facilitated, and our ambulances that break down will no longer break down, increasing the cost.

Mr Speaker, I will add another intervention that has great impact on the health status of the people of this country. Not only did the past Government leave this economy in shambles, but it will be shocking to the people of this country that the Ghana

Demographic and Health Survey has indicated that nearly half of children between 6 months and 59 months are anaemic. Our children between 6 months and 59 months that the past government handed over, about 50 per cent of them were anaemic. So, the Government of H. E. John Dramani Mahama, knowing very well that the past government handed over half of our children being anaemic, affecting their ability, intellectual and learning ability, decided to introduce bold agricultural policies such as Feed Ghana. The impact of Feed Ghana is that our children will be well-nourished. The children who are malnourished will be well-nourished. And this is what this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy guarantees that no longer will half of the children of this country be malnourished, but almost all of them will be well-nourished. If you do not want this, what do you want?

So, Mr Speaker, when H. E. John Dramani Mahama promises, he delivers. Therefore, we are grateful for that bold policy.

I will move from these great interventions into the real health sector. Mr Speaker, if we go to paragraph 1057, it states:

“That Government is steadfast in the commitment to achieving universal health coverage, ensuring that every Ghanaian, regardless of income or location, would have access to quality health care”.

What it means is that whether you are in Accra, Kyebi, Oti, Daffiama, Bussie,

or Issa, you would have access to quality health care. Unlike the previous Government, in fact, people were struggling to even access essential medications at health facilities. Now we are all guaranteed of quality health care, and that is what the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy guarantees.

Mr Speaker, I was surprised with my Ranking Member and other people who passed the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, yet they were not clear about the MahamaCares, confusing it with free primary health care. They are not able to differentiate what the Fund does and what National Health Insurance does. Let me take a few minutes to educate them. MahamaCares is an intervention that deals with the complications of non-communicable diseases. National Health Insurance was not covering issues like kidney dialysis. What MahamaCares will do is that this specialised care, this complicated non-communicable diseases that were not covered by the National Health Insurance, will now be covered. That is MahamaCares.

When we talk about free primary health care, we are talking about the care at the community level. If a community health nurse has to go on health promotion, has to go and educate the community members, at the community level, health insurance does not pay for going to visit and educate community members on nutrition, on sanitation, or whatever. So primary health care is more at the community level. So again, H. E. John Dramani Mahama has put an intervention that ensures that primary

health care is free. And one bold thing he is doing to ensure that is that every year, in every district, at least two CHPS compounds will be constructed, and manned by well-qualified community health nurses, ensuring that the people at the community level are healthy. That is the President with vision. That is the President who understands health care. That is the President who knows that there is a linkage between population, health, and development. So, he does not throw interventions anyhow, but that they are well-calculated and structured to ensure that the people of this country are healthy.

Mr Speaker, I know time will not allow, but let me remind Colleagues and the people of this country that the era where our children could not have access to basic vaccines has passed. And since January to date, who can tell me that they have heard of shortage of vaccines for our children in this country? Have we heard that? We used to hear in the previous year from 2023, 2024, shortages of vaccines. A Leader has come: a President who cares, and a President that believes that the children are the future of this country has ensured that no child is left out when it comes to immunisation and vaccination in this country.

So, support this Budget. Let us pass it, because it is a Budget that will ensure that everybody, every Ghanian has access to quality health care, our children have nutrition, there will be food in abundance, the economy will move on, and would have jobs. Under this Budget, and moving on, they are assured of jobs.

We are not like the other governments, because this Government, when we promise, we deliver.

I am very grateful to you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to make these few comments on the 2026 Budget. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member. It is now the turn of Dr Stephen Amoah. Hon Member, you have 15 minutes.

7:56 p.m.

Dr Stephen Amoah (NPP — Nhyiaeso): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this prestigious opportunity.

Mr Speaker, if there is anything that as a country, if they want to really keep that psychological contract between us and the very Ghanaians, who gave us their mandate, is to tell the truth. It looks as if propaganda economy is becoming an exclusive economic policy in this country, used and perpetrated by my Brothers from the NDC.

Mr Speaker, I would like to make this emphasis, clearly, without any ambiguity, that the present Government has no hands in the present state of our economy. Absolutely nothing, zero performance. I am saying this not to also say that they have failed. I would not say that. I want to be honest. The only disappointment here is that they lie to Ghanaians, they use propaganda tools, deception and communist inferior tactics for Ghanaians to believe that they will be

better managers of our economy, which they have not.

Mr Speaker, I have their Budget Statement and Economic Policy here. My statements are going to be underpinned by what my own Brother, Dr Ato Forson has put here. I am saying this because they have gone around saying that this year, they have been able to manage the economy of our country so well that sometimes, suddenly, I see glaringly some professors and doctors who either display intellectual dishonesty, ego trips, or suffering from unconscious incompetence, and want to support this misconception that the present Government has managed the economy well. That is palpably false. We need to accord Ghanaians the need of respect.

Mr Speaker, this is from their own Budget. In 2020, the world inflation rate in terms of growth was - 2.7 per cent. In 2024, it went to 3.3 per cent. In 2025, 3.2 per cent. In Sub-Saharan Africa, for 2020, it was—1.2 per cent. In 2024, it was 4.0 per cent. Then in 2025, it was 4.2 per cent. Then let us come to Ghana, and this is where the lies of the NDC are being exposed, and Ghanaians should listen.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, withdraw the word “lie”.

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, the deception and the propaganda—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Speaker, I just asked you to withdraw.

Dr Amoah: I have done so, Mr Speaker, but the deception and propaganda they are using to deceive Ghanaians and influence their decision-making processes are here, in their own Budget.

Mr Speaker, page 5 of the Budget. In 2020, Ghana grew 0.5 per cent, better than even the world and the sub-Saharan region. In 2024, our GDP grew 5.7 per cent, even higher than in 2016, which was 3.4 per cent. Now, in 2025, our economy is growing at 4.0 per cent, and they are telling us that even in 2026, what they can do is 4.8 per cent. How could the same Government tell Ghanaians that they have been able to manage this economy well? I mean, economic figures are not just like using our intuition to analyse a picture. We deal with numbers, and this is what we need to look at. Their own numbers are exposing them, and these are lies.

Mr Speaker, they should be able to tell us which of their flagship programmes or policies have contributed to the growth of our economy? I am asking what the percentage the Government spending this year that we see in terms of numbers in our GDP? What is the percentage of the 24-Hour Economy project in our GDP? Zero. What is the percentage of the Big Push to our economy? Zero. *MahamaCares*, respectfully, I am not using that name because he is my President, but they say Mahama—The NDC Government has virtually done nothing this year economically. Nothing.

Mr Speaker, I am saying this because the economic process is not an event. Last year, Hon Ato Forson came here with the 2025 Budget and stated all the economic figures. Inflation rates had reduced from 54.1 to 22.9 per cent. Asset rate from 54 to about 16.8 per cent. Our GDP was growing at 5.7, higher than even in 2016, and they are benefiting from that because we are running a defensive sector economic market, and they should understand that. There is a long period. So what Ghanaians are enjoying today has nothing to do with the NDC Government.

Mr Speaker, let us come to the exchange rate. What are the independent variables? What are the factors? One, we need to look at the primary balance. We need to look at our GDP growth. We need to look at our reserves. They were all doing better in 2024. Two, by December 2024, we had put in our coffers over US\$500 million because of the syndication process or policy that we domesticated in our country.

Mr Speaker, by January 2025, we had put over US\$1 billion. What has the NDC Government done about our exchange rate? Nothing. Two, we had a very peaceful election, and as a result, it attracted the interest of investors. Three, America had engaged in, I mean, a terrorist war with its partners from the Asian countries. The NDC Government should tell Ghanaians one policy they put in place, one economic policy. They have not done anything, and I think the earlier they tell Ghanaians the truth, that the NDC has no idea in managing the economy of this country. Even now, we

are still finding out from them. We want to find out from the NDC whether they are capitalistic or socialistic in nature. They cannot do proper policies. They cannot manage the economy. They do not know anything. Everyday propaganda—[Hear! Hear!]¹—and they will be exposed.

Mr Speaker, this is the inflation rate from their own Budget. In 2023, because we have been reducing the inflation rate, we reduced it within one year by 16.3 per cent. The NDC has done 16.6 per cent, which means we have done better. Then we come to the most important aspect. When it comes to managing the economy of any country, Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How can the two Leaders be up at the same time? Please, I will humbly expect my two Leaders to resume their seats. Dr Stephen Amoah, a few minutes ago, the word ignorance was used. I ask that it be withdrawn. So, you should also withdraw, “they do not know anything.”

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, I have done so respectfully. I have withdrawn.

Mr Speaker, all that I meant was my Brothers are rather suffering from unconscious incompetence, and some of them are displaying intellectual dishonesty or ego trips. And they are all distortions of public information to put elements of adulteration in decision-making processes.

8:06 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to come back to this. Anywhere in the world, if any government, whether in Asia or Africa or America, is touting itself for managing any economic transition well, what it means is that our problems with our fiscal space, which our Brothers from the other Side should have given us any path, clearly, nothing was done.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is a country that we are practising negative effective tax rate economy. What it means is that we are always having ritual deficits. Come and check their own revenue. they are talking about not meeting their revenue targets. It is in their own Budget Statement. I did not write; it is here. Secondly, the number one problem confronting our fiscal space is our debt sustainability challenges. We reduced it from 80.4 per cent to GDP to about 61.3 per cent to GDP, and it is coming down. They have not put in place any discretionary policy to do that. The NDC, apart from the statutory expenditure, have not done anything. Right now, they are talking about the VAT. They are saying effective and statutory rates. Effective rates should have figures less than statutory because it is the payment, and they gave otherwise. They are talking about deductibility. In fact, all the economic terms indicate that—

Mr Speaker, I think maybe we need to provide some sort of tertiary education for them when it comes to managing the economy. When it comes to these things, just look at all these facts. Another aspect of our economy that they are just creating a whole lot of issues today is the moneys they are allocating to managing—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Stephen Amoah, should somebody tell you he wants to provide a tertiary education for you, how would you appreciate it?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, by that I meant further training or orientation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Will you withdraw “provision of tertiary education”?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, I was talking about capacity building.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Will you withdraw?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, I withdraw.

Mr Speaker, all that I am trying to say is that we need to redefine our corporate focus. By doing that, we need to spend more money in capacity building so that it will assist our Brothers to meet the expectation of Ghanaians. I think any time they are in power, check right from the year 1992 to 2000, they cannot manage our economy and grow it beyond 4 per cent. Check all the Budget Statements and Economic Policy. All of them. The highest they went was 2.4 per cent. I have a problem with that. It is not about the propaganda.

Mr Speaker, one area of importance, apart from the economy, in the Budget that I am dealing with, is how the new Government is making us unproductively expend in the area of managing our rule of law in a way that citizens are not being served equally. Mr Speaker, one of the maxims of equity law

is that equality is equity. Are we getting that? Yesterday, one of my Brothers that I respect so much, was talking about the fact that—*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, one of our respectable MPs made a statement on the Floor asking where Mr Ken Ofori Atta was. I was shocked. If you come to Government and you abuse *nolle prosequi*—I am not a lawyer, forgive me if I got it wrong—that all NDC appointees that had issues to be dealt with by the court, you cancelled all and you start arresting NPP people. Is it a rule of law? Are we being served equally? Are we still democratic? What are we introducing? What is the new culture? Is the NDC going back to what precedes 1992? Are we going back to military rule or is it autocratic rule? What kind of kangaroo society are they creating? Are we to use our Budget to make sure that—Per the Constitution, Mr Speaker, Article 17(1), “All persons shall be equal before the law”. Is that what we are using our money for?

All that I am saying is that, when it comes to managing this economy, to create the needed equitability and equality, our Brothers are far below expectation. One painful thing is that they are enemies of the poor. Tell me any of their pro-poor policies. Is it in kind or cash? Is it free SHS? Is it school feeding? Is it capitation grant? Is it free maternal care?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I proceed to give the floor to Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah. You are speaking for 15 minutes.

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Budget ably presented by our Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson. I will begin by asking a few questions. Have we heard in this era, John Dramani Mahama's era, that heads of schools, basic education, are complaining about capitation grants? Have you heard about John Mahama's regime, that school feeding caterers are in red banners at the Ministry of Education? Have you heard that the Conference of Heads of Assisted Senior High Schools are telling students that they have no food for them? Have you heard of any Russia-Ukraine war by H.E. John Dramani Mahama? Have you heard of any issue that President Trump has cancelled money for Ghana, and because of that we do not have money to take care of our institutions?

Mr Speaker, the people of Ghana are the judges. The people of Ghana, and people on social media are commending this Budget beyond imagination. Mr Speaker, I am old enough in this House. Let us go to the Ministry of the Interior. I refer the House to the 2023 Budget. What happened there? Mr Speaker, in 2023, under the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO) specifically, my community suffered a disaster. There was a heavy downpour and lot of buildings were affected. I tabled a lot of Questions in this House. But in their Budget, what did they say? They told me they were getting money from the Ministry of Finance to be able to take care of disaster issues.

The following year, 2024, was the issue of Akosombo Dam spillage, which affected many people. It took H.E. John Dramani Mahama and his brother Ibrahim Mahama, when he was not yet in Government, to send truckloads of food to support disaster victims in Kintampo and to support victim in the Volta Region. This is a Government that has come to help us once more. You talk more than you do. The NPP Government that we took power from, we know they are full of talk shops, but do little. They are Mr Do-Littles.

On the educational budget, currently, nobody needs to tell you that the figures are splendid. They are there. They are reassuring. They are giving hope. Is it about infrastructure? Is it about feeding? Is it about projects? What else do we want to hear?

8:16 p.m.

Let us go to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, paragraph 551.

“Government fully paid capitation grant and feeding grants for all public basic and special schools during the 2024/2025 academic year. In addition, registration fees for 471,586 candidates from public junior high schools writing the 2025 BECE were fully absorbed to ease the financial burden on both parents.”

Mr Speaker, I relate this to even West African Examination Council (WAEC). By now, WAEC would have been on the

Committee on Education several times, asking the then Ranking Member what would happen for them to get money for marking. Dr Asamoah, my Colleague on the other Side was debating, but he has so soon forgotten how WAEC was struggling to survive under the former President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. Yes, he will get up, but the truth is bitter. Dr Asamoah should better shield his shame.

Mr Speaker, to continue, let us talk of feeding grant. For the free senior high school education, about GHC1 billion was paid to them. The Conference of Heads of Assisted Senior High Schools (CHASS) are comfortable at their corner. Children do not ask parents for *shito* and other provisions for school. Parents are now delivered from a lot of expenditure. Mr Speaker, that is the Budget of hope, that has come to deliver Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, furthermore, there is No-Fee-Stress. Colleges of Education were paying fees as much as GHC5,688. Under No-Fee-Stress, Government is absorbing GHC2,644 per student and so far, 1,551 students have been catered for. Any challenger? No.

Mr Speaker, the NPP party should not dream of coming to governance again. Why am I saying so? In the agricultural sector, 660 tractors and its accompanying implements, are coming in to boost agriculture. The palm plantation, which we call the red gold, is coming into the system to boost agriculture. There are a number of foreigners trooping to our Committee on Food and Agriculture, trying to invest.

The Akans would say *εεε w'ani*. The Committee on Food and Agriculture is not resting.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the meaning of that?

Mr Kumah: To wit, Mr Speaker, it is something that everybody would love to see.

Mr Speaker, the Budget is an economic policy that gives direction and tells the world about what the Government intends to do, then the rest of the world now takes advantage of the policy. This policy is influencing foreign investments. They are telling us that the 24-Hour Economy is a zero-percentage. They are aware, since there are a lot on social media, that foreigners are willing and ready to come and take advantage of 24-Hour Economy shops in Ghana to partner with the Government. They must have something to say to their constituents so that at the end, they will say that they came to say nothing in Parliament and so they are forced to say something.

Mr Speaker, they say *agoro be so aa efiri anɔpa*, to wit if things will go well, the foundation says it all. Mr Speaker, when the 2025 Mid-Year Budget Review was read, they told the Minister for Finance that he was not spending. He came and told us a lot of things and the 2026 Budget is continuing. What things have we done? An amount of US\$700 million-euro bond payment has been paid. It shows that the Government has not come to complain, but we have come

to act, push and pay. That is what the NDC Government is.

Mr Speaker, to add, an amount of GH¢10 billion to domestic bond holders has been paid. We remember pensioners under Nana Akufo-Addo's government were all over, crying and cursing. We have paid them and the place is silent. In 2026, they have budgeted to settle a lot of debts in addition. An amount of GH¢2.9 billion paid to the District Assembly Common Fund (DACF), verily happened, and more of the common fund is being released.

We have been in this House together and we used to complain about DACF being in arrears for three quarters, at times getting to four quarters. Today, it is left with just one quarter and we are ongoing. Do not worry. If some accounts have not yet been hit, we will see it by tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, this is a Government that is out to work and let Ghanaians have the free and the right governance structure in place. Ghana is fully at peace with its neighbours. This is a Government that is creating the enabling environment for businesses, institutions and for the system to work; that is what we are seeing.

On the side of retooling of the military, it is common knowledge that the Government is doing everything to give things for free for people.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 122 (1) (c). My Hon Colleague just made a statement that during the previous administration, DACF releases were in arrears, but at the moment, there is nothing like that. This is factually incorrect. The Ministry of Finance - the Deputy Minister for Finance is here—is owing the DACF administrator over GH¢5 billion, so the information that he has put out cannot be true. Also, there are still DACF arrears that they have not been paid yet. So, he cannot say that there is nothing in arrears because there are a lot in arrears and the Ministry of Finance—

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is not the case that this Ministry of Finance—
[*Interruption*] It is—

Mr First Deputy Leader: Hon First Deputy Minority Whip, did you raise point of order, point of elucidation or clarification? You came under Order 122(1) (C). It is Order 122 (A) that is point of order. I would have asked you to state the Rules that have been breached.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is not the case that this Ministry of Finance owes DACF arrears of GH¢5 billion. The arrears of GH¢5 billion is money that should have gone to DACF under the NPP administration, which they never

transferred to DACF. The NDC comes to government and they are saying that we should go and find that GH¢5 billion and give to DACF to pay for contracts that the Administrator awarded. Mr Speaker, those are the facts and he knows that. Every amount accrued since NDC assumed office has been duly transferred to DACF Administrator, from the first to the third quarter. Indeed, that of third quarter was paid ahead of time, and the monies have been transferred to the districts.

That is why, as we speak, under NDC's government the district assemblies have become far richer than the central government. Just as the welfare of District Chief Executives (DCEs) have improved and the welfare of assembly members have improved. Assembly members are getting allowances, DCEs have their salaries enhanced and the transfers are consistent, timely and adequate and regular, just as the allocations to Members of Parliament have improved and they have been consistent and regular.

8:26 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this is the point of elucidation.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not know at this point whether the Majority Leader was debating or whether he was under Order 122. Mr Speaker, in trying to make that statement, the Majority Leader cannot say that the District Assemblies are richer than the central Government. That

is factually incorrect, and it should be expunged from the record.

Mr Speaker, the point that I raised earlier was to the fact that the Member said that there is nothing in arrears. There is something in arrears. The Majority Leader could not address that. The Deputy Finance Minister said they are owing; governance is a continuous process. It is never the case that the NPP Government owed GH¢5 billion, and for that matter, the NDC Government is owing GH¢5 billion—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Member indicated that under the current Government, they are not owing the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF), and you indicated that they are owing about GH¢5 billion. That is what the Majority Leader and the Leader of Government Business came to clarify that these were the arrears.

Hon Member, I am a member of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies. We have oversight over the DACF, so I am privy to some information.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, definitely, you can guide us. But my point is that it is never true, and it cannot be true that the DACF Administrator has paid every releases up to date. Even the districts, they still owe them. They have not paid.

Mr Speaker, the last time, the Majority Leader is aware that—we did a press conference to that effect—moneys were released to the Administrator and was swept. Yes, so they are owing. It is not true.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, you are speaking the same language. He is saying that yes, they are owing Administrator, but what they are owing the Common Fund Administrator, is the arrears from the previous regime.

Yes, Hon Deputy Minister?

Mr Ampem: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

For the avoidance of doubt, I want to let our Leader on the other Side appreciate the fact that for the year 2025, DACF is not in arrears. We have paid DACF every amount owed them.

Mr Speaker, everybody in this Chamber is aware that DACF is paid a quarter in arrears. So, the fourth quarter will be due before we pay the third quarter. But as I speak now, we have even paid part of the third quarter amount to DACF. This never happened under your regime. It never happened. So, I am telling you that in the year 2025, DACF has been paid even ahead of what they should receive by the third quarter. This is something that you should know.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Joseph Kumah. You may continue.

Mr Kumah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Thank you, Leadership, for insisting that Mr Joseph Kumah is rightly on point.

Mr Speaker, to continue, I would send you to page 78, paragraph 556 of the 2026 Budget Statement and

Economic Policy. With your permission, I will read:

“Government will also resource and expand infrastructure in SHS and TVET institutions to increase the number of Category A and B schools, with priority given to underserved regions.”

Mr Speaker, my interest is in paragraphs 557, 558, and 559. The *Hansard* should capture. It talks about the Government's expansion of education infrastructure at the tertiary level to be able to rope in the increased number of Free Senior High School (FSHS) students who are coming up.

Mr Speaker, what interests me is that the Government is to build technical universities at Jasikan and Techiman in the Bono East Region, Catholic University of Science and Technology in Damongo, and that of the almighty Kintampo University. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, the Asantes would say, “*Wo mpe wei, na wo pe den*”. To wit: if you do not like this, what else do you want? So, it surprises me. It baffles and I wonder why people can just say the Budget is empty. Mr Speaker, the world is listening and judging. *Asempa ye tia*. To wit: good news is very short. Good news is very short because the number of pages in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is just 287. President John Dramani Mahama does not speak too much. Dr Ato Forson does not say much. But the good news is here.

Mr Speaker, let us go to the 2023 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. It is full of talks; talk show. It has 315 pages. Let us go back to the 2024 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, which has 309 pages. Just imagine, a talk show, and a short message.

Mr Speaker, I will not use all the time because our news is perfect, splendid, and short.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members. It is now the turn of Prof Kingsley Nyarko. You are speaking for 15 minutes. You are the floor.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I am grateful to you for the treasured space for me to make a few comments on the Budget that was presented by the Minister for Finance. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance came to this House and stood at the Despatch box and created the impression that he possesses a magic wand. He made the whole world to believe that he is the fountainhead of the relative stability that we are seeing in the economy. He tried to portray to the world that he is the ship anchor of the current economy of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, respectfully, I beg to differ and deviate from his proposition. The Minister for Finance was nominated and approved by this House on 21st January, 2025. The next day, on the 22nd, he was given the instrument of office. That was when he was appointed by the President.

Mr Speaker, we must also not forget that the Budget that was used within the first quarter of this year was expenditure in advance of appropriation. It was the Budget that was prepared by the previous administration. Mr Speaker, again, we have an IMF programme, a post-COVID-19 programme of economic growth—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did you say the Budget that was read in March was expenditure?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am saying that in the first quarter, we passed a budget in advance of appropriation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But that was not in March.

Prof Nyarko: No, I am saying that the first quarter of this year, that Budget was the one that was passed in 2024. That is what I said.

Mr Speaker, for me, it is strange for anybody to suggest that Dr Ato Forson, the Minister, for Finance, is the originator of what we are seeing in the economy. It cannot be true. And I would tell you why. Mr Speaker, I am holding in my hand the Ministry of Finance document.

3:36 p.m.

The title is *Finance Minister Positive on Economic Outlook amid Challenges*, dated 2nd September, 2024. If Mr Speaker would indulge me, I will read the third paragraph, and it reads:

“Our medium-term outlook is optimistic, with projected improvements in GDP growth, inflation control, and fiscal health”

This was by Dr Amin Adam. So, there was a prediction that this year, the economy was going to do well. If we read the document, the IMF had projected a growth rate of 4.4 per cent for Ghana by the end of 2025. This was contained in the IMF's Global Economic Outlook released on the sidelines of the annual World Bank-IMF Spring Meetings in Washington, D.C., U.S. A. What I am saying is that all that we are seeing had been predicted. So, the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson, has done nothing.

Mr Speaker, there is another publication which I have here which says;

“Ghana will record single-digit inflation rate of 8 per cent in 2025, IMF predicts.”

If they are doing inflation of 8 per cent, it had already been predicted by the IMF. So, Dr Ato Forson has done nothing. The foundation had been laid. We achieved GDP growth rate of 5.3 per cent within the first quarter of this year. We are doing 6.3 per cent after the second quarter.

Interestingly, inflation is doing well. But I remember, in the year 2002, when former President J. A. Kufuor took over office, inflation was 40.05 per cent. By the time he existed in 2008, inflation had been reduced to 18 per cent. The late

President Mills took inflation to a single-digit, nine per cent. When President John Mahama took over in 2012, inflation went up to 15.4 per cent. When we took over power in 2017, inflation was 15.4 per cent. We worked so hard, that in 2019, inflation came down to 7.8 per cent. We had global shocks. We all know that the economy was not doing well globally. Inflation went to the roof. But we were able to bring it down to 23.8 per cent before we lost power. The point I am making is that the NDC in 2016 left inflation at 15.4 per cent. We worked hard, brought it to single digits, and it went back again to 23.8 per cent.

Mr Speaker, for me, what is even puzzling is that the Minister for Finance did not tell us that in the first quarter of this year, the industry sector did 3.4 per cent. When he came here for the Mid-Year Budget Review, he told us that industry growth was 3.2 per cent. So, we saw a reduction of 3.4 per cent at the first quarter to 3.2 per cent. He did not tell us.

Mr Speaker, I hold in my hand a report from the Ghana Statistical Service which shows that in the first quarter of this year, agriculture grew by 6.6 per cent, and in the second quarter, it reduced to 6 per cent. The Minister has got the benefits to succeed, but he has begun failing. They cannot build anything on nothing. They must build something on something, and that foundation has been firmly laid by the NPP Administration before we exited.

Mr Speaker, is it not puzzling? Is it not strange? Is it not paradoxical that we are being told that inflation has come

down? We are being told that the cedi is doing well. Fair. I will yield.

Mr Speaker, we are also being told that growth is increasing, however, prices of goods and services are going through the roof. **[An Hon Member: How?]** What kind of economics is this? Our Friends opposite us, our NDC Friends, I respect them, in terms of individual capacity, I respect them. Mr Speaker, today you are sitting in a Chair; you are a neutral arbiter; I know your capability; I know you are the master of our rules in this House. I know how you do it. My very good Friend, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, and others. I cannot doubt their capabilities. But when it comes to governance, the NDC is zero. When it comes to managing the economy, the NDC is worse than zero. They have fine brains, but economy-wise, our Friends are always failing. Because I expect, with my modicum of knowledge in economics, that when our currency, the cedi, is doing well, inflation is coming down, and GDP is increasing, I do not expect prices of goods and services to rise. It does not make economic sense.

Mr Ampem — *rose* —

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, let me continue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Prof Nyarko, hold it. They will hold your time.

Yes, Deputy Minister for Finance, why are you up?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, my good Friend and my namesake, Prof Nyarko, is misleading the House. I just want to give a simple education. We say inflation has gone down but as long as inflation is positive, prices will go up. What inflation going down means is that the rate at which prices are increasing will be reducing. So do not mislead students by saying that we are saying inflation is going down but some prices are going up. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, let me tell him, contrary to what he is saying, go to the markets and ask. Recently, the Minister for Finance led us to Takoradi Market, and we were told by the market women that one “Kufuor gallon” of oil, which during their time was GHC1,000, is today selling at GHC580. The prices of a lot of things, petroleum products, have gone down. A lot of other factors come into play. But I just want to give this education. That we should stop saying that we say inflation is going down but prices are going up. As long as inflation is positive, prices are going up but at a reduced rate. That education must be given because we have students who are listening to us. So, it is important that we get that concept right.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, my good Friend should not lecture me. We sat in this same Chamber. What he is saying now is different from what he was saying before. He is not saying what he was saying when he was sitting where I am

now. When inflation was even coming down, he made that argument, as if the economy was being mismanaged—*[Uproar]* When I am in Accra, the food I enjoy most is kenkey. Today, when I got to the airport, I drove to Adabraka, close to the GNAT offices, where there is woman called Aunty Pat who sells kenkey. I was there this morning and I bought two balls of kenkey. I am an evidence-based politician. *[Laughter]*

[Prof Nyarko displayed a ball of kenkey.]

Mr Speaker, this small kenkey, this mosquito-like kenkey was sold at GH¢5. And they told me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kingsley Nyarko, you are talking about evidence. Where is the receipt on the kenkey you bought at GH¢5 if you are talking about evidence? *[Laughter]*

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, this is the first time in this country that I have heard that if one goes to a joint to buy kenkey, one must demand a receipt. Mr Speaker, be honest—

8:46 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kingsley Nyarko, you are talking about evidence. Where is the receipt for the kenkey you bought at GH¢5? *[Laughter]*

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, this is the first time in this country that I have heard that if one goes to a joint to buy kenkey, they must demand a receipt. Let us not be honest with ourselves.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you said you are an evidence-based politician.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, where does one buy *kenkey* and receive a receipt? Let us be honest.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you are talking about evidence.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I said that we should go to Aunty Bee at Adabraka. She is close to the Ghana National Association of Teachers (GNAT) offices. Hon Members should go there tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, the point I am making is that something is not working. The NDC economics team are not telling us something. Something is amiss, and Ghanaians demand that they are told how the economy is being run. When we come to the energy sector, on 3rd May, 2025, utility tariffs increased by 14.75 per cent. In July, it was increased 2.45 per cent. On 1st October, it was 1.14 per cent, which is a total of 18.34 per cent. On top of this, as if the NDC Government, headed by President John Mahama, does not care, they slapped GH¢1 per litre on fuel products, which is GH¢4.50 a gallon. If we do the calculation, the percentage increase when we amended the Energy Sector Levies translates to 105 per cent from 95 pesewas to GH¢1.95. How inconsiderate can a government be?

They say that the economy is doing well, and the GDP is rising. Last year, during the labour negotiation for an

upward salary adjustment, the President met with the Labour Unions and had to beg them to agree to a 10 per cent increment. This year, they are saying that the economy is doing well. They have increased it by a paltry 9 per cent. If the economy is doing well, then it means that the salary adjustment should have been more than what they have given workers. For them to give only 9 per cent increase, tells me that, on the contrary, the economy is not doing well. We should not deceive ourselves.

Mr Speaker, I am now moving to education. I know that the capitation grant has increased from 147,000 to about 150,000. That is policy. The Free Senior High School is being continued. It seems that the NDC wants the Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, to fail. Why? Because he wants to end the double track system, but he cannot find money. When the Rt Hon Speaker was launching his scholarship programme, he said that reset is not by words but by actions. We demand action from them—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think sufficient copies of the Bill have been distributed. So, we should get back to the Consideration Stage of the Value Added Tax Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 under consideration.

8:56 p.m.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025

Clause 4 to 15 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 16 to 44 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

9:06 p.m.

Clause 38 to 50 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, suspension for just two minutes.

9.12 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

9.14 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025

[Resumption of Consideration from column 229]

Clause 51 to 53 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 53 – 55 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 56 – Duties of a Value Added Tax Withholding Agent.

Hon Members, any proposed amendment to clause 56?

9:16 p.m.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if we look at clause 56 (1) (a).

“A value added tax withholding agent shall withhold from payment to a person registered for the tax 7 per cent of taxable output values of supplies. And at a time of making payment for supplies issuing a withholding tax credit certificate in the form prescribed by the Commissioner-General to the supplier.”

Mr Speaker, before I make any input on this matter, I want the Chairperson of the Committee to clarify clause 56 (1) (a).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee, they want clarification on clause 56 (1) (a).

Hon Minister, can you clarify?

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, a tax collection agent would have registered with the value added tax service through the Commissioner-General. Unfortunately, there are people who bring goods into this country that are not registered. Normally, when those people clear those goods, they would not want to come back and pay so they ask them to pay in

advance some withholding tax before they can clear those goods out.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is where I have a problem and I will lay bare the issue before I come out with a proposed amendment. Mr Speaker, many businesses especially our small and medium enterprises that are Ghanaian owned have serious issues with capital. They take loans from the informal sector to finance their businesses.

Mr Speaker, currently, withholding tax is 3 per cent. So, for someone like me running a small-scale business in Winneba, if I am getting payment and they are withholding as much as 7 per cent, then that is punitive. They are holding my capital.

Mr Speaker, how many people make even 10 per cent profit on sales? The status quo now is 3 per cent. Why do we not maintain the 3 per cent and we want to increase withholding tax to 7 per cent?

Mr Speaker, it is only the big companies that are able to meet the conditions to enable them have exemption so they would file ahead of time, they have the big audit firms that would be doing their filing for them and all. But for our own, let us be careful. Let us not rush and increase 7 per cent because it used to be 10 per cent, and it got reduced way back in former President Kufour's time. In 2004, I remember those days when I was into

transport business, and withholding tax came to 5 per cent and got further reduced to 3 per cent.

If now we want to increase it to 7 per cent, we would be killing local business because their profit margins are very low and what it means is that they would now have to price by a certain margin above that. We want to create more problems.

Mr Speaker, that said, I would want to respectfully propose an amendment that clause 56 (1) (a), after tax *delete* 7 per cent and *insert* 3 per cent. Mr Speaker, it would mean that we are maintaining the current 3 per cent and in fact that will feed into the argument of Mr Ampem that the new system of efficiency that has been introduced will encourage more people to pay with the digitalisation that you are ruling out. But if we take it to 7 per cent, it is only the multinational companies that will continue to benefit because they already have capital. You and I, our small-scale businesses, will continue to suffer, capitals would be locked, and trust me, we would be doing a disservice.

Colleagues, this is not a partisan matter those of us who are entrepreneurs in this Chamber look at this, and you know the real challenges you face. We cannot be in this Parliament and tomorrow it will be announced that there were entrepreneurs in this Chamber; the small and medium-scale enterprises and the beginners, where they will need their revenue to reinvest, we are saying that hold 7 per cent. No. Let us maintain the 3 per cent.

Mr Speaker, I expect colleagues to support this amendment so that we go back to 3 per cent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me subject your amendment to consideration.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker. That is exactly what I am trying to do.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, his proposed amendment is that after tax, *delete* 7 per cent and *insert* 3 per cent.

It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we should be guided by article 108 of the 1992 Constitution. It states:

“Parliament shall not, unless the Bill is introduced or the Motion is introduced by, or on behalf of, the President—

- (a) proceed upon a bill including an amendment to a bill, that, in the opinion of the person presiding, makes provision for any of the following—
- (i) the imposition of taxation or the alteration of taxation otherwise than by reduction; or
- (ii) the imposition of a charge on the Consolidated Fund or other public funds of Ghana or the

alteration of any such charge otherwise than by reduction; or

(iii) the payment, issue or withdrawal from the Consolidated Fund or other public funds of Ghana of any moneys not charged on the Consolidated Fund or any increase in the amount of that payment, issue or withdrawal; or

(iv) the composition or remission...”

9:26 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the intention at all times is that the Executive; the President and the Minister for Finance, should be the ones that guide us and take decisions on tax issues. So, at best, I will propose that we stand this clause down for some further consideration, some deliberation, some engagement with the Minister for Finance to find out why he wants it at 7 per cent and then we can consider the proposal that is being made. So, my proposal is that let us not debate this. He has made his point. We will hold on with taking a decision on this clause. Let us move on with the other clauses and then have some more engagements with the Minister for Finance on this particular clause.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but Hon Majority Leader, in this case, Article 108 will not be applicable. But the proposal is that we have clause 56 stood down.

Mr Ayariga: That is so. I do appreciate that this is not caught squarely by Article 108, but as I said, if you read the intention, it is the Executive that drives the issues of determination of tax figures. We may propose reduction, but I am saying that in this instance, let us engage with the Minister for Finance and see if we can understand the rationale for fixing it at 7 per cent or otherwise, then we can come back and consider the proposal to reduce it to the 3 per cent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the proposal is that we have clause 56 stood down.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I agree with the second leg of the Hon Majority Leader’s argument. That is to enable further consultation. I have been there before. But the first leg of his argument was constitutional in nature and I humbly disagree. He cannot invoke Article 108 to stop this proposed amendment because Article 108, as you rightly said, is rather imposing an obligation on Parliament to act in a certain manner only when the Bill is introduced. So it is exactly what we are doing. It says that Parliament shall not unless the Bill or the Motion is introduced by or on behalf of the President.

I am not on my own introducing a Bill. I am rather proposing an amendment to a Bill that has been introduced by the President through his Minister for Finance to this House. These are part of our *bona fides*. That is why we have what we call the Consideration Stage. The Consideration Stage means

we the parliamentarians in the House of Assembly would read and bring out views. So, on the constitutional argument, I respectfully submit that the Hon Majority Leader did not perhaps, look critically at the law. However, the second leg, which he is reaching out that we should stand down, I am not in a rush, he is the Leader of the House, if he wants to engage the Minister for Finance on the basis of the argument—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, all what you have said is not different from what I have said.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is so, Mr Speaker. Except that I want you and me to go into the *Hansard* that we were on the same firm ground against the Hon Majority Leader.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Indeed, if one listens, I did not say that Article 108 stopped us from proceeding. I read Article 108 to say that there is some understanding that we be informed by the Executive position on Bills before we proceed on them, especially in tax matters. I recognise that Article 108 leaves room for us to propose downward review of taxing proposals. We can review it downwards as a House, but I quoted that Article to say that it is better to listen to the Executive before you proceed. That is how come I ended on the note of let us stand it down and have the Minister for Finance engage on that particular provision. But his Deputy is here, in case he has some indications—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, I am trying to get information to prove that it has not been increased. So, I will support the position of the Hon Majority Leader that we stand that particular one down and move on. We will come back and resolve it.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is a reputational issue. I, Kwamena, pay withholding tax. Withholding tax for the last eight years has been 3 per cent. The Deputy Minister said that it has not been increased but what we have before us is saying 7 per cent. It is not everything they have to oppose. I pay withholding tax. So, he should not say it has not been increased. They should not destroy businesses.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the application to defer the consideration of Clause 56 is in order. Clause 56 accordingly deferred for further consideration.

We then move to Clause 57.

Clause 57 is ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 58.

Clause 58 — Exemption from Withholding Tax.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Taking me back to 57. Yes, you have the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have a very humble appeal to the Leader of Government Business. I will not be an obstructionist. I will not do that. I know government needs revenue. This Bill was just distributed to us and I am getting it the first time today. The Report was laid and we have been told to look at everything today.

Mr Speaker, with what I am seeing, let us not rush this Bill. I would plead with the Hon Majority Leader to let us suspend the consideration and allow Members to look at it. The business community is watching us. If we do everything under certificate of urgency without scrutinising, we will have a challenge. I will plead with my respected Colleague. I am not invoking any law; it is a plea. Let us suspend this, come tomorrow and deal with it. I am pleading with the Hon Majority Leader for our own sake. Because I am seeing a lot of things that we should assist the Minister for Finance with to pass the right tax law.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, I have the information I was talking about, and it is the VAT Amendment Bill, Act 2017, clause 47 (a), and it reads:

“A value-added tax withholding agent shall withhold from the payment to a registered value-added

tax trader 7 per cent of the taxable output value of standard-rated supplies”.

So, it is the same 7 per cent. We have not changed it. So, I refer the Hon Member to the amendment in 2017. In clause 47 (a), it is stated clearly. It is the same that has been lifted here. It has not changed.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we are back to clause 56.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have made an application. What he is saying—That is where the confusion is and that is the more reason for which we need to interrogate this. What they are doing is that, they are taking away the flat system—*[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, Hon Ampem knows this is not a matter to joke about. He should stop this “we are consulting”; this is a serious matter.

9:36 p.m.

What they are doing is that they are taking away the flat system. Hon Ampem, this is not a joking matter, please. Stop saying you are consolidating. This is a serious matter. I do not know whether he is an entrepreneur apart from this day job, but there are a lot of entrepreneurs who are going to suffer, so let us interrogate the issues.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, you indicated that the 7 per cent ought not to have been 7 per cent, but 3 per cent. Now, he is saying that by the existing law, it is 7 per cent. So, he is reading the rendition by the existing law to show that they are only consolidating, and not increasing it from 3 to 7 per cent.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me explain to you. There is some mischief somewhere. This is a thing that I do daily. Colleagues should relax.

Mr Speaker, we have two regimes currently. With the VAT system, we have those who, by law, charge the regular VAT, and those who go under the flat system, which is the 3 per cent. In the current dispensation, if one is under the flat system, the 7 per cent he is talking about is not applicable. Therefore, one does the 3 per cent. Now, the introduction of this 7 per cent in real terms is an amendment, because now he is taking away the flat system and bringing everybody under the same threshold.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What did the 2017 law say?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am saying that the 2017 law that he read applies to those big companies. My argument this evening has been the cry of small and medium-scale enterprises that benefit from the flat VAT system. I am saying that with the introduction of this, what it means is that the 3 per cent flat system that they are

withholding is amending it. Why is he not reading the flat system 3 per cent? He should read it. Why is he reading the 7 per cent, which is the existing law for the big companies?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, Hon Member, if you look at this marginal note, it says “Duties of a Value Added Tax Withholding Agent”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is the same thing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is the same thing that he is quoting from the existing law to signify that there is no increment. It is the same existing law that they are consolidating.

Let me hear the Majority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The Hon Majority Leader should bear with me.

Mr Speaker, let me answer you. The mischief lies in what they claim to be consolidation. There are two regimes: regime one, small scale—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we can cut a long story short. So, what is the current law?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The current law has two components—Even as a Minister for Finance, he had to go and consult, please. Is he saying that we do not have a 3 per cent flat VAT for small-scale enterprises? Is that what Hon Ampem is saying? He is a public officer.

Mr Speaker, the consolidation is implicitly amending the 3 per cent and bringing everybody under the same threshold. I am not contesting the 7 per cent because it is limited to only the big companies. Now, what they are doing by introducing the 7 per cent is to do away with the existing 3 per cent withholding. So that even the small and medium-scale enterprises that benefit will no longer have that dispensation.

If they say they are consolidating, then they have two regimes catered for both. If they say for the big companies, the 7 per cent will remain. But for the small companies, they will continue to have their 3 per cent, I would agree with them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right, let me recognise the Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader has said several times that he is an entrepreneur and that he has been paying 3 per cent. The Deputy Minister just dug out the law, and the law says 7 per cent. Is it the case that he has been underpaying the taxes? [*Hear! Hear!*] Is that what has been happening? Because if he is drawing on his experience, the 7 per cent withholding tax law was passed in 2017. Who was in office in 2017? In 2017, which party was in office? So, the NPP passed this tax and imposed a 7 per cent withholding tax and obliged collectors to withhold 7 per cent. How come he was paying 3 per cent? Because the 3 per cent is a flat final rate, not a withholding tax.

Here, we are consolidating and then dealing with withholding tax. And withholding tax is 7 per cent. So please, the matter is simple. The Deputy Minister indicated that it is consolidating an existing tax legislation passed under the NPP. If he disputes it, he should show us the alternative legislation. If he is not showing us the alternative legislation, then we have to allow what he has said to stand. So, all this dragging of the matter does not help because this is consolidating existing legislation.

If he claims that that is not the amount, he will have to produce the legislation that indicates a 3 per cent withholding tax. If he does not show that, then we have to proceed based on what he has demonstrated, which is to read a specific legislation that says it is 7 per cent.

So please, either we proceed, or defer consideration of that clause. But he promised to provide the information. That is what he has just done. But as I said, we can step it down. I think that he has demonstrated that he is only consolidating existing legislation.

Mr Speaker, I also acknowledge the fact that we have had a long day. We are not almost done. How many clauses do we have?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have fewer than 20 clauses.

Mr Ayariga: We have fewer than 20 clauses. Given that there are really no amendments—

Given the issues he has raised; it is clear that nobody is changing anything. It is an existing legislation and we indicated right from the start that this is just consolidating existing legislation. So, let us take a few more clauses and then break, to continue tomorrow. Let us negotiate. Maybe 10 more clauses.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would not drag matters.

I believe that if we place these matters on ice and come back tomorrow, we can do a better work. I still hold the view that this law will make the small and medium-scale business owner, including myself, worse off. Because it is doing away with the VAT flat rate of 3 per cent. As to all the explanations and getting the other laws, I would yield to the Leader of the House. If he says we can place it on ice for further consultation, no problem.

But Mr Speaker, let us not rush this. If he wants to do 10 more clauses, it is all right. And if we can defer and deal with it tomorrow, I do not mind. But I would want the Deputy Minister for Finance to assure this House of further engagement on this matter. Because if we keep rushing things through, in the end, Parliament would bear the wrath of the people. We all know that. He was previously with the Finance Committee. Mr Speaker, from what I am seeing here, I think we can do a better work if we put all things on ice.

9:46 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clearly, the Hon Member's proposed amendment is abandoned, or I should still put the question on 3 per cent?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I think the understanding is that we put it on ice, so that we do further consultation. That is the understanding I have.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We were putting it on ice so that he can get to the Minister for Finance. Now, the Deputy Minister for Finance brought the law which signified that really, it is an existing law that they are consolidating. Since 2017, that has been the position of the law. It is not a new provision, *per se*. It is different laws that are being consolidated into one for easy application. I will prevail on you to drop your amendment so that we can proceed.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I yield. After all, it is not a finality.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we can do a Second Consideration Stage.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if we come back tomorrow and there is the need to look at it again, I do not mind.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Therefore, we have to make progress.

Clause 56 to 61 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the entire clause 61—The declaration form, is it going to be digitally generated or is it still going to follow the manual system, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance? I want to propose an amendment, but I need clarity from him. Or he has not read it? Clause 61.

I am asking him, is the declaration going to be digitally generated or are they going to rely on the old manual system?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, currently, there is an available option for a digital generation. Yes, it is available, and the GRA is using it. So, whether manual or digital, that option is available for taxpayers.

Clause 62 to 65 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I was just drawing your attention that we have exhausted the 10 clauses.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We were dealing with clause —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we were at clause 56 and he said we should do 10, Mr Speaker. So now 65. Mr Speaker, *mede kuku na wo*. Let us.

We said 10. We were at 65, please.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I did not realise that he agreed to the 10 clauses.

Honestly, because there was some dispute whether we should do 10 or not, there was no clear agreement that we would do only 10 clauses. We can add another 10 and proceed.

Mr Speaker, we can add another 10.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, instead of going back and forth, may I ask the Leaders to engage? We can do up to 67, if you are able to engage, we will complete it. If not, then we leave only the Miscellaneous Provisions. Hon Leaders, you can engage. We can stop at clause 68 which deals with Miscellaneous Provisions, which is a comfortable place to land?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think the Hon Majority Leader agrees with the Minority Leader. Majority Leader, we started from clause 1 to 66. This one, just understand. The Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Ampem, tomorrow, it will be left with what? There are 75 clauses. We have done 66 clauses. We have less than 10. Tomorrow, as much as we are just bringing it in between Businesses, we will just finish it, with respect.

9:56 p.m.

Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe: Mr Speaker, we want to work, we are ready to work. We the women are not tired, so how can men say they are tired? We are working, so let us work. They are complaining about a 24-hour economy and we are here to do a 24-hour economy. Mr Speaker, please go ahead, we are not tired, we want to work.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, even though Hon Doyoe was 23 years last Monday, we should understand that we have done a lot. Our health matters. Look at the time we started. Now, it is three minutes to 10:00 p.m., and tomorrow, we have serious Businesses and our Leaders need to conclude on the debate. Even at the moment, we still have some people to debate—*[Interruption]* No, we still have about four people left to debate, on the list that we submitted today. So, if we are postponing, let us just defer the Consideration Stage, so that tomorrow, we can conclude. Our health matters. We started a little after 12 noon. We have sat for 10 hours.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, initially, the problem was that enough copies of the Bill had not been distributed, and we took steps to make copies and distribute. Now, I think there is some issue of fatigue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, we will stop after clause 65. Or should we stop at clause 66?

Mr Ayariga: I was thinking clause 70 would be convenient.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, Hon Members, if you look at the Bill, you would realise that at page 69, from clause 68, it is on a different subject matter, that is Miscellaneous provisions. That is why I am saying that we can do the clauses 66 and 67, then we leave the miscellaneous matters for consideration on another day. So, clause 66.

Clauses 66 and 67 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Majority Leader, this is a convenient place to bring the consideration of the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 to an end for today.

Hon Members, are we going back to the debate? Yes, Majority Leader? The indication is that we should debate.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the indication is that people are exhausted. My proposal is that we start at 12 noon tomorrow and then allow the outstanding Members to make their comments. Then the Leadership will start their contributions at 4:00 p.m. so that we can have some additional comments from other Members. This is so that we can take an adjournment now and people can get home and rest. It is already 10:00 p.m. and it is just comments, it is not some—*[Interruption]*

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, considering what is going on, on two different occasions, we had to offload some of the debaters. I wanted to appeal to the two Leaders that they give us tomorrow to conclude on those who are debating. Because it has never been the case that on the day Leaders are concluding, people are debating. It is the Leaders' Day, so I will suggest strongly that tomorrow, like today, we still have our standing at about 4 or 5 Members, then we add some number to it, and debate tomorrow to conclude. Then on Thursday, the Leaders will conclude on debate. They will not have anything to do.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in fact, that is the proposal. So, we are very happy that the two Leaders have agreed to push their concluding remarks to Thursday, so that tomorrow we can take care of the overflows from Friday, today and other intervening Businesses that are coming up. So, on Thursday, then we can hear our Leaders.

Mr Speaker, that is the proposal.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, should I keep this list? Tomorrow, we are going strictly by this list. Because if you continue to add, there will always be a backlog.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes, I agree with you. But Friday, for instance, we promised those that we could not take, that we would take them today, but the intervening Businesses have made it very difficult for us to take them. So, I want to propose that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I hold in my hand the list from the Minority. I realised that they have started from the arrears from Friday.

Mr Dafeamekpor: We could not accommodate everyone on Friday. So, we may add a couple to what you have and update it for you tomorrow. You will have it set by tomorrow before we start sitting, and we will seal the numbers tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if care is not taken, the Leaders may not be able to even conclude on Friday.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It is Thursday. We are pushing them to Thursday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If care is not taken, they may even not be able to conclude on Thursday. Because if tomorrow, with the intervening Motions, you are both saying you are bringing eight people, what happens if the eight on the list are not exhausted?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I was suggesting to the Majority Chief Whip that today, we were scheduled to do 13, but now we have done nine; it is left with four on both Sides. So, if we add additional either five or six, nothing more than that. If we achieve nine today, tomorrow, we can do another nine. So that today, the four that is left on both Sides, we keep it and add additional five to make it nine. Because today there have been other Businesses, but that we succeeded in doing nine. So, we just add only five on both Sides.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Who told you that tomorrow there will not be other Government Businesses?

10:06 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my issue is that with the intervention, we still achieve doing nine speakers.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me propose that in addition to the names that you have outstanding from today, we add only four, so we do eight speakers from each Side in addition to outstanding Businesses that we may continue with tomorrow. So, we would

have Thursday solely for the Leaders. We should be able to accommodate eight speakers from each Side tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Members, Leadership should engage.

Mr Dafeamekpor: All right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have done more than five hours, fortified by Order 56 (2), it lies within my authority to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 10: 08 p.m. till 26th November, 2025 at 12:00 noon.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 9th December, 2025.